Declining Fertility and Housing Costs

Tommaso De Santo*

November 11, 2026

Updated frequently. Click here for the latest version

Abstract

I study how the cost of family space shapes fertility decisions, and what role housing policy can play. Housing costs are at the center of the debate on declining fertility: children need space, and the young households who are deciding whether to have kids have few resources to pay for it. I build a life-cycle model in which households face income risk and choose fertility, savings, and whether to rent or own, subject to a down payment constraint. In the model, a child increases the demand for physical space, and young households face a tradeoff between having children sooner, when fecundity is high but earnings are low and uncertain, and later, after building up savings. I calibrate the model to the United States in 2007 and estimate an exogenous decrease in the desire for children to match the recent fertility decline. Along the transition to a new steady state with a smaller population, the presence of fewer households makes housing cheaper, which feeds back into higher fertility. I use the estimated model to assess different housing policies. Relaxing credit requirements has small effects on fertility in the medium run, as it mostly shifts the timing of fertility. Instead, the effect of policies that change long-term incentives, such as more housing supply and credit available only to parents, is stronger, and builds up over time. The results shed light on the importance of focusing on the long-run effects of policies aimed at increasing fertility.

*New York University (td2248@nyu.edu). I am grateful to Corina Boar, Guido Menzio, Raquel Fernández and Sharon Traiberman for their guidance and support. I thank David Berger, Arielle Bernhardt, Jaroslav Borovička, Nicoló Ceneri, Gian Luca Clementi, Simon Gilchrist, Isaac Hacamo, Paolo Martellini, Virgiliu Midrigan, Abdoulaye Ndiaye, Alessandra Peter, Diego Perez, Martin Rotemberg, Saverio Spinella, Venky Venkateswaran, Matthew Wiswall, and participants to the NYU Macroeconomics Lunch Seminar and NYU Student Macroeconomics Lunch Seminar for their comments and suggestions.

1 Introduction

Fertility is falling almost everywhere. In the United States, the period fertility rate fell from about 2.1 children per woman in 2007 to 1.62 in 2023, and by some estimates the world as a whole is now below replacement for the first time (World Bank, 2026; Fernández-Villaverde and Norrick, 2026). The consequences of this decline are vast, ranging from pressure on social security to slower growth. As a result, this phenomenon has become a central concern for policymakers. The causes of the decline are elusive,[1] but housing is often at the center of the discussion on how to raise fertility in the future, both in public debate and in policy.[2] The logic is intuitive. Housing is the largest item in household budgets, representing a third of all spending of the average US household (U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, 2025). Children increase the pressure on this already high bill: they require physical space, so becoming a parent raises a household's demand for housing. On the other hand, prospective parents are young, with low earnings and savings, so that the extra room is particularly expensive exactly when it could shift the fertility decision.

Many policy proposals seek to help young families buy a home, intervening on the financial constraints by lowering the cost of borrowing or the down payment. If saving for a down payment is what keeps young couples out of a 'family-sized' home, especially where larger homes have to be bought,[3] such policies could raise births. However, the extent to which this is quantitatively relevant is unclear. Easier credit lowers the down payment, but not the cost of the extra space, which a family pays every year its children live at home: whether it rents or owns, and in bad years as well as good ones. Looser credit may therefore lead young couples to buy a home, and perhaps to have children earlier, without lowering the long-run cost of children enough to make them have more.

This paper asks how the cost of family space shapes fertility, and what housing policy can do about it. I answer this question with a quantitative life-cycle model in which households face idiosyncratic earnings risk and choose whether to have children, whether to rent or own, how much housing to demand and how much to save. I find that housing policy raises births most when it lowers the

[1] The literature has not reached a consensus. For example, Kearney et al. (2022) do not find a single economic or policy factor that accounts for the decline. Kearney and Levine (2026) argue for "shifting priorities" across cohorts, a change in norms around work, parenting, gender roles and leisure, shaped in part by new technologies such as the smartphone and social media. Doepke et al. (2023) argue that in rich countries fertility now depends on how easily parents can combine careers and family.

[2] In a fourteen-country survey, housing is among the most cited reasons for having fewer children than desired, after finances and job insecurity (United Nations Population Fund, 2025). Germany, Greece, Hungary, Italy, Poland and Spain subsidize or guarantee home loans for families, with terms that improve with the number of children (KfW, 2025; Hellenic Republic, 2026; Government of Hungary, 2023; CONSAP, 2026; Sejm of the Republic of Poland, 2024; Boletín Oficial del Estado, 2024); South Korea lends at subsidized rates to households with a child under two, to buy a home or pay a rental deposit (Ministry of Land, Infrastructure and Transport, 2023), and Singapore gives families priority for public flats (Ministry of National Development, 2026). In the 2024 US presidential campaign, Kamala Harris proposed up to $25,000 in down-payment assistance for first-time buyers (Harris for President, 2024), and JD Vance argued that young people are delaying families "because they can't afford a place to raise a family" (NewsNation, 2024).

[3] In the United States, 43% of owned homes have seven or more rooms, against 7.5% of rented homes (2023 American Housing Survey).

long-run cost of having children, through cheaper space or credit available only to parents, rather than when it only eases financial constraints. For example, removing the down payment for all households and expanding the housing supply raise births by about the same amount on impact, 1.3% and 1.4%. Yet, the gain from the credit easing policy is gone within four years, while the gain from the supply expansion keeps growing, to 3.0% by 2063. Credit available only to parents raises births by 5.1% on impact and by 16.6% by 2063.

The reason for these different effects is what each policy changes for a couple deciding whether to have a child. Lowering the down payment makes it easier to buy a home, but does not affect the flow cost of children. As this policy does not lower the burden of parenthood, and it does not change the demand for space, most of the households who use it buy the small homes they would otherwise have rented. As a comparison, increasing housing supply lowers prices and rents, and with them the cost of family space in the present and future. Credit offered only to parents does not lower the flow cost of children either, but it ties the gain to having a child: it raises the value of parenthood relative to childlessness, not only the value of owning.

These findings speak to a growing empirical literature that links housing costs and access to credit with births (Dettling and Kearney, 2014; Lovenheim and Mumford, 2013; Hacamo, 2021; Cumming and Dettling, 2024; Dettling and Kearney, 2026; van Doornik et al., 2024). My model is consistent with the positive effect of easier credit on births that these studies find, and it complements this evidence in two ways. First, a structural general-equilibrium model helps in disentangling the forces at play. By jointly modeling the households' choice of children, tenure, housing and savings, the model can shed light on the interaction between housing and children in equilibrium, and it can extrapolate to policies outside the range of existing evidence, such as credit available only to parents. Second, it allows a long-run comparison of policies. Empirical designs typically operate at short horizons and given prices. Some studies look at longer timeframes (Dettling and Kearney, 2026; van Doornik et al., 2024), but they are necessarily retrospective: it takes more than two decades for the effect of a policy on completed fertility to unfold. The model instead allows me to project forward. Starting from the economy of 2023, I follow each policy for several decades, as cohorts age and prices adjust.

I start by documenting how housing changes when a child arrives. Using the Panel Study of Income Dynamics, I show that three to four years after their first birth, parents live in 1.44 more rooms than two to three years before it, a 31% increase over 4.71 rooms, and they are 27 percentage points more likely to own their home, up from 43%. Moving to obtain more space becomes a third more likely after the birth, while moving for a better neighborhood does not.

I then build a life-cycle model in which households face uninsurable earnings risk. They save, decide whether to have children, whether to rent or own, and how much space to live in. A child requires a minimum amount of space while it lives at home. The largest homes are only available for sale, buying requires a down payment, and owners can borrow against their home. Housing is supplied along an upward-sloping supply curve, so house prices rise with the number of households, and

therefore fertility choices feed back into the price of space a generation later.

To quantify the model, I approximate the United States economy of 2007 with a steady state in which births are at replacement. I assign some parameters from external evidence and choose the others so that this steady state matches fertility, housing and wealth moments of 2007. Holding these parameters fixed, I then let the preference for children fall after 2007 so that the model matches the decline in fertility through 2023, and I solve for the transition of the economy as prices, family composition and household formation adjust.

Finally, I study a range of policies, starting from the 2023 point in this transition. The results show why focusing on the immediate impact of a policy can be misleading. Credit for all buyers raises births immediately, but most of this effect disappears in four years, as many of the children born early would otherwise have been born later. Births then rise again, to 0.6% above the path without policy by 2063, as households that enter later gain more from credit while housing becomes cheaper. Instead, a supply expansion with the same effect on impact keeps raising births, to 3.0% above the path without policy by 2063, as each cohort that enters adulthood benefits from lower housing costs. Credit for parents raises births by 16.6% by 2063. In the long run, births per household return to replacement in every scenario, so the lasting gains of a policy show up as more households rather than more children per household: with credit for parents, there are 36% more households in the new steady state, and the house price is 33% higher. The main lesson is that housing policy aimed at births should be judged by its long-run effects, not only by its effect on impact.

1.1 Related work

This paper contributes to many strands of the literature on fertility, housing, and macroeconomics.

First, the paper relates to the large literature on housing and childbearing. This literature shows that fertility is lower where rent per room is higher (Simon and Tamura, 2009), dwelling size predicts first births (Ström, 2010), and higher house prices raise births among owners (Dettling and Kearney, 2014; Lovenheim and Mumford, 2013) but lower them among renters (Dettling and Kearney, 2014). These papers are mostly empirical; I study these effects in a general equilibrium model, which lets me focus on complex interactions between housing, credit and fertility and their long-run patterns. Structural work has also modeled fertility and housing choices, estimating dynamic models on micro data (Khorunzhina and Miller, 2022; Couillard, 2025). I add to this by placing similar choices in a life-cycle economy where house prices respond to the number of households, and follow policies over several decades.

Second, this paper relates to the literature on credit, housing and fertility. Quasi-experimental studies find that credit raises births: an expansion of home credit in the mid-2000s led young households to buy homes and have children (Hacamo, 2021), lower interest rates on home loans raise births among affected households (Cumming and Dettling, 2024), federally backed home loans raised births, and possibly completed fertility, during the baby boom (Dettling and Kearney, 2026),

and winners of housing-credit lotteries in Brazil have more children, especially at ages 20 to 25 (van Doornik et al., 2024). I add to this literature in two ways. First, I separate the timing of births from their number. In line with Kaplan et al. (2020) lower down payments lead young households to buy the small homes they would otherwise have rented. As a result, births rise on impact but mostly shift earlier in agents' lives, with a modest effect over the decades. Second, I compare credit with policies that lower the cost of space or tie credit to births.

Third, it relates to work on earnings risk and fertility. Because a child is an irreversible commitment, prudent parents who face more risk want fewer children (Fraser, 2001). Quantitative life-cycle models find that uninsurable earnings risk delays and reduces births (Sommer, 2016; Ejrnæs and Jørgensen, 2020; Nakakuni, 2026), and de la Croix and Pommeret (2021) show that risk gives the postponement of a first birth an option value. Quasi-experimental studies find that job displacement and job insecurity lower fertility (Del Bono et al., 2012; Clark and Lepinteur, 2022). I focus on modelling the housing component of such commitments. Children affect housing demand, and by modelling tenure choice and credit constraints I can study how the response of fertility to earnings risk is influenced by the housing market.

Fourth, it builds on quantitative models of housing over the life cycle. These models study tenure choice under earnings risk, down payments and transaction costs (Fisher and Gervais, 2011; Halket and Vasudev, 2014; Boar et al., 2022), how credit conditions and beliefs affect house prices, rents and ownership (Kaplan et al., 2020; Greenwald and Guren, 2025), why young households own less than they used to (Fisher and Gervais, 2011; Paz-Pardo, 2024), and the intergenerational allocation of housing (Coven et al., 2026). I contribute to this literature by endogenizing the fertility decision, to understand fertility and housing over the life cycle.

Finally, although this paper does not try to explain the decline in fertility, it relates to the broad literature on its causes and consequences. The literature on the causes has documented the importance of the cost and timing of children, bargaining within couples, changing attitudes toward parenthood, shifting priorities across cohorts and the compatibility of career and family (Jones et al., 2010; Doepke and Kindermann, 2019; Kearney et al., 2022; Doepke et al., 2023; Kim et al., 2024; Kearney and Levine, 2026; Fernández et al., 2026). Work on the consequences studies the efficiency and optimal rate of population growth, whether low fertility stabilizes, and the economics of a shrinking world (Golosov et al., 2007; Ball, 2026; Coffey et al., 2026; Fernández-Villaverde and Norrick, 2026). I take the decline as given, driven by an exogenous fall in the preference for children, and study how, for given preferences, housing shapes fertility decisions.

The rest of the paper is organized as follows. Section 2 presents the evidence on housing around the first birth. Section 3 describes the model, and Section 4 its quantification and the transition from 2007 to 2023. Section 5 describes household choices in the calibrated model, Section 6 studies housing policies, and Section 7 concludes.

2 Empirical Evidence

In this Section, I show some motivating evidence on housing changes around the first birth using the Panel Study of Income Dynamics (PSID). I begin by describing changes in housing at parenthood. Three to four years after the birth, parents live in 1.4 more rooms than two to three years before it, a 31% increase, and are 27 percentage points more likely to own their home, up from 43%. Both margins, space and ownership, are central to the model of Section 3, and they crucially inform the quantification in Section 4. I then document the increased salience of space among the reasons households give for moving. One to two years after the birth, the probability of moving for more space rises by 2.1 percentage points, a 33% increase over 6.4%, while moves for neighborhood reasons do not rise. Among households that move, the share citing more space rises from 12% to 27% three to four years after the birth.

2.1 Data and Design

The PSID has followed a representative sample of U.S. families and their descendants since 1968, every year until 1997 and every two years since. I use the waves from 1968 to 2023.

In this Section, I focus on four housing outcomes. "Rooms" is the number of rooms in the home. "Owner" equals one if the household owns its home. Households that moved since the previous interview are asked why they moved, and I use the first reason they give. "Moved for space" equals one if the household moved and its first reason is expansion of housing, such as more space, and zero otherwise. "Moved for neighborhood" is defined in the same way for neighborhood reasons, such as a better neighborhood or being closer to friends or relatives; this category also includes moves to attend school. Appendix A details the variables and the sample construction.

I measure how housing changes around the first birth, relative to two to three years before it and relative to adults who never have a child. I use this reference, rather than the year before the birth, because households may move ahead of a planned birth. Formally, let Y_{it} be an outcome of adult i in survey year t and E_i the year of the first birth. I estimate

$$Y_{it} = \alpha_i + \lambda_t + x_{it}'\gamma + \sum_g \sum_{k \neq -3/-2} \delta_{g,k} \, \mathbf{1}\{E_i = g\} \, \mathbf{1}\{t - E_i \in k\} + \varepsilon_{it}, \tag{2.1}$$

where α_i and λ_t are person and survey-year fixed effects, x_{it} contains indicators for age and education, g indexes first-birth years, and k indexes two-year windows of event time $t - E_i$. The coefficient $\delta_{g,k}$ is the change in Y in window k for adults whose first birth is in year g, relative to the omitted window.

The treated group consists of adults who have a first child and who, two to three years before the birth, were already the reference person or the spouse of a household, so that their housing in the

omitted window is that of their own household.[4] The control group consists of all adults who never have a child; they carry no event-time indicators. To account for effects that differ across cohorts of first births, I estimate equation (2.1) with the estimator of Sun and Abraham (2021).[5] I report

$$\hat{\beta}_k = \sum_g w_{g,k}\, \hat{\delta}_{g,k}, \tag{2.2}$$

where $w_{g,k}$ is the share of first-time parents observed in window k whose first birth is in year g. I refer to β_k as the housing response to the first birth in window k. For example, $\beta_{+3/+4}$ is the change in Y three to four years after the first birth, relative to two to three years before it and relative to the change among never-parents. Observations are weighted by the PSID longitudinal weight.

2.2 Housing Around the First Birth

Figure 1 shows the response of housing choices around the first birth. Panel (a) shows the path of housing size. Two to three years before the birth, parents live in 4.71 rooms. Rooms rise by 0.62 in the birth window (+13%) and by 1.44 three to four years after the birth (+31%), and rise more slowly afterwards, to 1.8 more rooms eleven or more years after the birth. In the windows before the reference, the coefficients are below a tenth of a room. The adjustment is large and concentrated around the birth: two-thirds of the long-run increase occurs by one to two years after it. This indicates that, although the analysis does not rule out anticipation, children acquire particular salience around the birth itself, and the demand for space rises abruptly.

Panel (b) shows the path of homeownership. Two to three years before the birth, 43% of parents own their home. Ownership rises by 16 percentage points in the birth window (+37%) and by 27 points three to four years after the birth (+63%).[6]

Figure 2 explores the reasons households give for moving. Panel (a) shows the probability of moving for more space, and panel (b) the probability of moving for neighborhood reasons. Two to three years before the birth, 6.4% of households move for more space and 3.0% for neighborhood reasons. One to two years after the birth, the probability of moving for more space is 2.1 percentage points higher (+33%), while the probability of moving for neighborhood reasons does not rise.[7] This

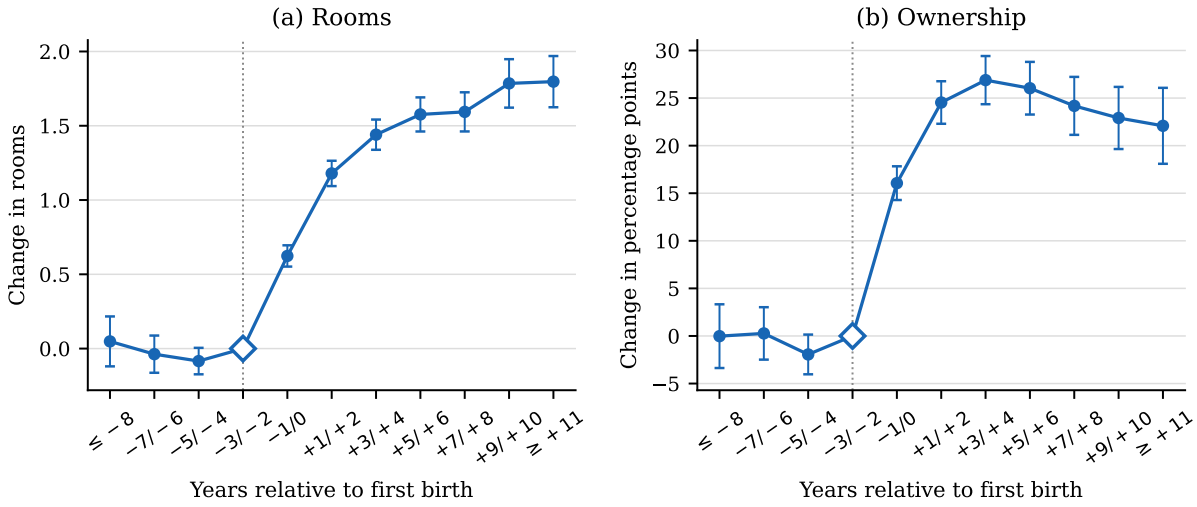
[4] The results are qualitatively similar when the sample includes, at each interview, every woman who is the reference person or the spouse of a household. For more detail, see Appendix A.2.

[5] Two-way fixed effects regressions with pooled event-time indicators are biased when the effect of the birth differs across cohorts (Goodman-Bacon, 2021). The method of Sun and Abraham (2021), followed here, estimates a separate path for each cohort of parents, compares it only with never-parents, and averages the paths with the cohort shares.

[6] Appendix A.2 also shows the probability of moving since the previous interview. It is highest two to three years before the birth, at 54%, and is 17 percentage points lower one to two years after the birth and 21 points lower three to four years after it (Table 9). Couillard (2025) finds the same anticipation of births in the ACS.

[7] Among households that move, the share citing more space rises from 12% to 27% three to four years after the birth (Table 9). A larger home could also come from a move to a cheaper location rather than from spending more on housing. Among households that already owned two to three years before the birth, house value rises by 30% three to four years after the birth and value per room by 11%, and moves across state lines become less frequent

Figure 1: Rooms and Ownership Around the First Birth (PSID)



Note: This figure shows the estimates of β_k in equation (2.2), in two-year windows, with 95% confidence intervals. Rooms use the sample on which the model's event study is measured ($N = 112{,}148$); ownership uses its available observations ($N = 111{,}272$). The hollow marker is the omitted reference window.

highlights a strong role for concerns about size of the dwelling at childbirth.

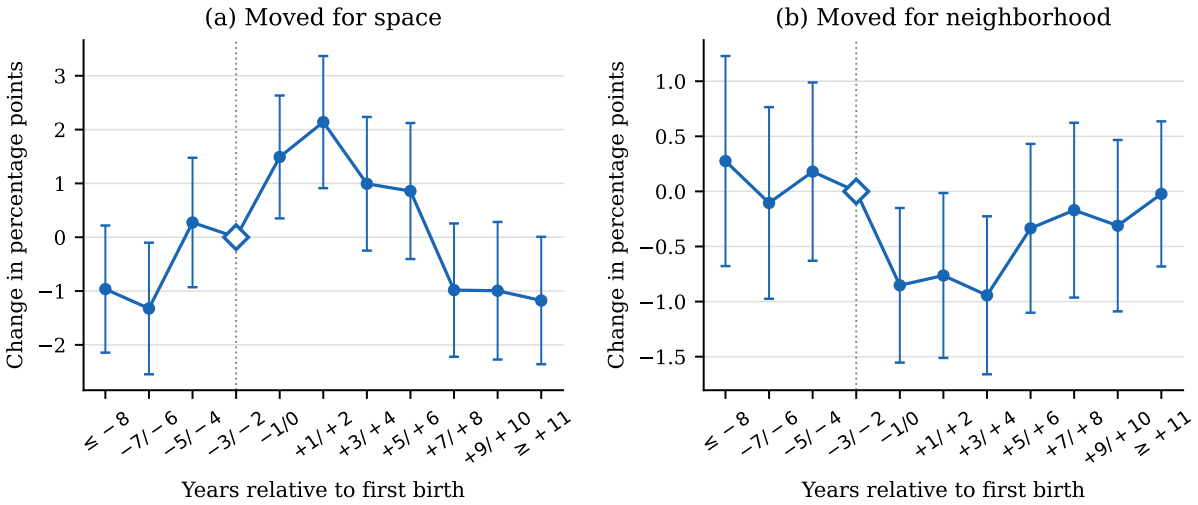
In summary, housing is particularly relevant around childbirth, which increases the desire for size and leads people to ownership. The complex web of interactions that take place in the data motivates the writing of a model. Agents need to make a set of intertwined decisions. Having children increases desire for space, and it is easier to get this space by owning (see Appendix B). Owning requires saving to be able to afford a down payment, and children also increase general expenses. The model developed in Section 3 tries to model the interaction between these forces, in order to discipline their relative strength and potential for policy. The evidence detailed above not only motivates, but also informs my modeling choices. Parents add about 1.4 rooms around the first birth: in the model, a child requires a minimum amount of space, which I measure by running the same event study in the model. Parents also become more likely to own. In the model, ownership gives access to larger homes, since the largest homes are only for sale. This is a potentially important channel, although Section 6.3 suggests it matters less than one might expect.

3 Model

In this Section, I develop a model of fertility and housing decisions. Households live a finite number of periods in an overlapping-generations economy. They face persistent idiosyncratic earnings risk and transitory taste shocks over fertility and housing. They derive utility from consumption,

(Appendix A.3).

Figure 2: Reasons for Moving Around the First Birth (PSID)



Note: This figure shows the estimates of β_k in equation (2.2), in percentage points, with 95% confidence intervals ($N = 116{,}697$). The outcomes are probabilities among all households, including those that did not move. The hollow marker is the omitted reference window.

housing services and children at home, and they save in a one-period bond with an exogenous interest rate. They either rent or own their home. Owning gives more services than renting the same space, and the largest homes are only for sale. Owners can borrow against their home, up to a fraction of its value, while renters cannot borrow. A buyer must therefore make a down payment, and a seller pays a transaction cost. During a fertile period of their lives, households choose whether to try for a child. Children raise the household's needs and the value of space, so the decision to have a child is also a decision about housing. Households work until retirement and then receive a pension, financed by a payroll tax on workers, who supply labor inelastically. House prices and rents are determined in equilibrium.

3.1 The economy

I begin by describing households and their preferences, the income process, housing, the assets available for trade and the fertility process. I then describe the housing market and firms. Time is discrete and indexed by t.

Households and Preferences. The economy is populated by overlapping generations of households, with adult age $a = 0, \ldots, J$. Households can have children until age a_F and work until age a_R, after which they retire. A household of age a survives to age $a + 1$ with probability p_a. Figure 3 illustrates the different periods of the life cycle. Households differ in wealth, housing, labor efficiency, age and the number of children. During their fertile years, households can choose whether to try for a child. Throughout their life, they choose whether to rent or own their dwelling,

how much housing to demand and how much to save.

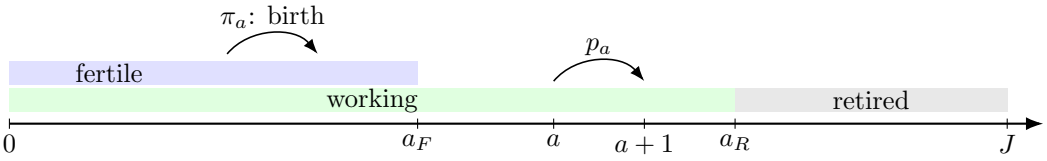


Figure 3: Life cycle of a household. Until age a_F, a try for a child succeeds with probability π_a, which declines with age. A household of age a survives to age $a+1$ with probability p_a.

Households value consumption c_t, housing services $\hat{h}_t$ and the number of children at home n_t, and discount the future by β. A household either owns h_t^O or rents h_t^R, and its housing services are

$$\hat{h}_t = \begin{cases} \chi\, h_t^O, & \text{owner}, \\ h_t^R, & \text{renter}, \end{cases} \qquad \chi > 1.$$

The parameter χ determines the additional services a household obtains from owning a home of a given size. Flow utility is

$$u(c_t, \hat{h}_t, n_t) = \frac{1}{1-\sigma}\left[\frac{c_t^{\alpha_0}\left(\hat{h}_t - \chi^{\mathbf{1}\{\text{own}\}}\,\bar{h}(n_t)\right)^{1-\alpha_0}}{e(n_t)}\right]^{1-\sigma} + \psi_t\, v(n_t), \tag{3.1}$$

with

$$\bar{h}(n_t) = h_P\,\mathbf{1}\{n_t > 0\}, \qquad v(n_t) = n_t^{1-\gamma}.$$

The first term is utility from a Cobb–Douglas composite of consumption and housing services above a requirement $\bar{h}(n_t)$, per adult equivalent, where α_0 is the weight on consumption and σ the curvature. Children raise the household's needs in two ways. First, a household with children at home must occupy h_P units of housing before additional housing yields services; an owner obtains $\chi(h_t^O - h_P)$ and a renter $h_t^R - h_P$. The requirement kicks in with the first child, and the household pays for it every period its children are at home, whatever the tenure choice. Second, the equivalence scale $e(n_t)$, with $e(0) = 1$, measures adult equivalents relative to a childless couple.[8] The second term, $\psi_t v(n_t)$, is the benefit of children at home: ψ_t is the preference for children and γ governs how fast the benefit of an additional child declines. The first child also carries a one-time utility cost ξ at birth.

Bequests. A household that dies at the end of period t leaves the estate $x_{t+1} = b_{t+1} + (1-\mu)P_t h_t^O$, its bond position and the value of its home net of the selling cost. As in De Nardi (2004), it values the estate according to

$$B(x_{t+1}) = \theta_0\,\frac{(\theta_1 + x_{t+1})^{1-\sigma}}{1-\sigma},$$

[8] I use the scale of Scholz et al. (2006), $e(n_t) = \big((2+\omega n_t)/2\big)^{\nu}$, where ω is the weight of a child relative to an adult and ν governs economies of scale.

where θ_0 scales the strength of the bequest motive and θ_1 determines the extent to which bequests are a luxury good. Estates are collected by the government.

Income. Before retirement, a household supplies one unit of labor inelastically, with efficiency $e_a z_t$. The term e_a is the age profile of earnings, and z_t is idiosyncratic labor efficiency, whose logarithm follows a first-order autoregressive process,

$$\log z_{t+1} = \rho_z \log z_t + \epsilon_{t+1}, \qquad \epsilon_{t+1} \sim N(0, \sigma_z^2),$$

where ρ_z is the persistence and σ_z^2 the variance of the innovations. Earnings are taxed at rate τ^w, and retirees receive a pension m_t:

$$y_t(a, z_t) = \begin{cases} (1 - \tau^w)\, w\, e_a z_t, & a < a_R, \\ m_t, & a \geq a_R. \end{cases}$$

Every household also receives a transfer T_t, the rebate of property-tax revenue.

Housing. There is one housing good, measured in units of space. Units can be combined and split at no cost, so all housing trades at one price P_t per unit and rents at one rent r_t per unit. Between periods, a fraction δ_H of every unit depreciates. A household enters period t with the home it owned at the end of the previous period, h_{t-1}^O, which is zero for a renter or a new household. Owner-occupied homes come in a finite set of sizes, $h_t^O \in \mathcal{H}$. Owners pay the property tax τ^p on the value of the home they choose, $P_t h_t^O$, and maintenance δ_H on the value of the home they enter the period with, $P_t h_{t-1}^O$, which restores it. Selling a home costs a fraction μ of its value. Renters choose any size up to a cap, $h_t^R \leq \bar{h}^R$, at rent r_t per unit, and reoptimize each period. Since $\bar{h}^R < \max \mathcal{H}$, the largest homes are only for sale.

Borrowing. Households save or borrow in a one-period bond, traded with the rest of the world at the exogenous gross return R_b. Let b_{t+1} denote the bond position a household chooses in period t. Borrowing must be secured by a home, so a renter cannot borrow, $b_{t+1} \geq 0$. An owner can borrow up to a fraction ϕ of the current value of its home:

$$b_{t+1} \geq -\phi\, P_t h_t^O. \tag{3.2}$$

The condition applies both to a household that buys a home and to one that remains in a previously owned home. A buyer must therefore pay at least $(1 - \phi) P_t h_t^O$ itself, out of its savings, the income of the period and the proceeds from selling the previously owned home if it had one.

Fertility. Until age a_F, a household decides each period whether to try to have a child. A try succeeds with probability π_a, which declines with age, and a success adds one child at home in the same period. Children make no decisions and affect the household by increasing housing

and consumption needs and through the benefit in preferences. Each child at home leaves with probability λ per period, independently of its siblings, so a child stays at home for $1/\lambda$ periods on average. Children who leave form new households and enter the economy at age 0, with an initial wealth position drawn from an exogenous distribution.

Construction. New housing is built by competitive developers from the consumption good. A developer that uses X_t units of the good builds I_t units of housing,

$$I_t = Z_t\, X_t, \qquad X_t \geq 0, \qquad Z_t = \Big(\frac{\bar{H}}{H_t}\Big)^{1/\eta}, \tag{3.3}$$

where Z_t is the number of units built per unit of the good. Productivity falls with the aggregate stock H_t, which stands in for land and regulation: each further unit is built on scarcer or more regulated land. The parameter $\bar{H} > 0$ sets the scale of the stock and $\eta > 0$ is the price elasticity of supply. Housing depreciates at the rate δ_H, and the stock evolves as

$$H_t = (1 - \delta_H) H_{t-1} + I_t. \tag{3.4}$$

Construction is irreversible, $I_t \geq 0$.

Rental companies. Rental housing is owned by rental companies, which live outside the economy. A rental company enters period t with the units it held at the end of $t-1$, of which $1-\delta_H$ per unit survive. It buys or sells units at P_t, in the same market as households, and rents all the units it holds at the end of the period to households, at the rent r_t per unit, paid at the start of the period. Rental companies pay the property tax $\tau^p P_t$ per unit, finance their purchases at the gross return R_b and, unlike households, pay no transaction cost when they sell.

Ownership of housing. At the end of each period, every unit of housing is owned either by the household that lives in it or by a rental company. Developers sell all they build in the period they build it. The home of a household that dies at the end of period t is part of its estate, valued at $(1-\mu) P_t h_t^O$; the government collects it and sells the units in period $t+1$. All sales take place in one market at the price P_t, where households, rental companies, developers and the government trade units.

Firms. A representative firm produces the consumption good, which is the numeraire, with a linear technology in effective labor,

$$Y_t = A\, L_t, \qquad L_t = \int_{a_t < a_R} e_{a_t} z_t \, \mathrm{d}G_t(\mathbf{s}_t, \boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_t),$$

where A is productivity, G_t is the measure of households defined in Section 3.4, and L_t is the total efficiency units of labor supplied by households of working age. The firm is competitive and

pays each efficiency unit its marginal product, $w = A$. The wage is therefore constant over time. Developers use the good, not labor, so construction does not change earnings; the goods market clears through net exports.

Government. The government runs a pay-as-you-go pension system, taxes housing and collects estates. It taxes earnings at the constant rate τ^w and pays the same pension m_t to every retired household. The pension system balances its budget every period, so the pension equals payroll-tax revenue divided by the number of retired households. When the number of retirees rises relative to effective labor, the pension falls. The government also levies the property tax τ^p on the value of all housing, owned and rented, and returns the revenue to households as a lump-sum transfer T_t, equal across households. Finally, the government collects the estates of the households that die. It uses them to pay new households their initial wealth and spends the remainder on government consumption, from which households derive no utility.

3.2 The household's problem

I next characterize the household's problem recursively. A period has two stages, shown in Figure 4. At the beginning of the period, the household observes its fertility taste shocks and decides whether to try for a child. After the birth outcome, it observes its housing taste shocks and chooses its home and saving. A birth therefore changes the demand for housing in the same period. The state of a household is its bond position b_t, the home it owns h^O_{t-1}, its efficiency z_t, its age a_t and the number of children at home n_t.[9]

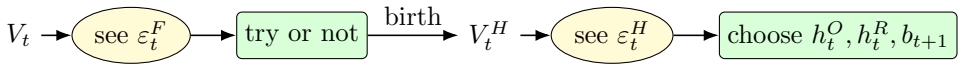


Figure 4: Timing within period t.

Fertility. Let $V_t(b_t, h^O_{t-1}, z_t, a_t, n_t)$ denote the value of a household at the beginning of period t, before it observes its fertility shocks. A household of fertile age chooses between not trying, $j = 0$, and trying, $j = A$. Each option receives a taste shock $\varepsilon^F_{t,j}$, i.i.d. Gumbel with scale κ and mean zero, with $\kappa = \kappa_1$ before the first child and $\kappa = \kappa_C$ after. The value of the household and the probability of trying are

$$\begin{aligned} V_t &= \mathbb{E}_{\varepsilon^F_{t,j}} \max_{j\in\{0,A\}} \left\{V^F_{t,j} + \varepsilon^F_{t,j}\right\} = \kappa \log\left[\exp\left(V^F_{t,0}/\kappa\right) + \exp\left(V^F_{t,A}/\kappa\right)\right], \\ \pi^F_{t,a} &= \frac{\exp\left(V^F_{t,A}/\kappa\right)}{\exp\left(V^F_{t,0}/\kappa\right) + \exp\left(V^F_{t,A}/\kappa\right)}, \end{aligned} \tag{3.5}$$

[9]The household also knows whether it has ever had a child: a birth is the first only if none was born before, whether or not that child is still at home. I keep this indicator out of the notation; it enters only ξ, κ_1 and the count of children ever born.

where $V^F_{t,0}$ and $V^F_{t,A}$ are the values of not trying and trying before the shocks. Both depend on V^H_t, the value of the household after the birth outcome, which I define below:

$$V^F_{t,0} = V^H_t(b_t, h^O_{t-1}, z_t, a_t, n_t),$$
$$V^F_{t,A} = \pi_a\big[V^H_t(b_t, h^O_{t-1}, z_t, a_t, n_t+1) - \xi\,\mathbf{1}\{\text{first child}\}\big] + (1-\pi_a)\,V^F_{t,0}.$$

Not trying leaves the number of children at home unchanged. Trying succeeds with probability π_a, adds a child at home and, for the first child, carries the utility cost ξ; if it fails, the household is in the same position as if it had not tried. Given its state, a household has a child with probability $\pi_a\pi^F_{t,a}$. Outside the fertile ages, there is no fertility choice and $V_t = V^H_t(b_t, h^O_{t-1}, z_t, a_t, n_t)$.

Housing and savings. After the birth outcome, the household observes its housing taste shocks and chooses its home, its tenure and its bond position. Let n denote the number of children at home after this period's birth outcome, n_t or n_t+1. Before the housing shocks, the value of the household is

$$V^H_t(b_t, h^O_{t-1}, z_t, a_t, n) = \mathbb{E}_{\varepsilon^H_{t,j}} \max_{h^O_t, h^R_t, b_{t+1}} \Big\{u(c_t, \hat{h}_t, n) + \varepsilon^H_{t,j} + \beta\,\mathbb{E}_t\Big[p_a V_{t+1}(b_{t+1}, h^O_t, z_{t+1}, a_t+1, n_{t+1}) + (1-p_a)B(x_{t+1})\Big]\Big\}, \quad (3.6)$$

subject to the budget constraint of the chosen option,

$$\begin{aligned}
&\text{Buy:} && c_t + b_{t+1} + \tau^p P_t h^O_t + \delta_H P_t h^O_{t-1} = R_b b_t + y_t + T_t - P_t h^O_t + (1-\mu)P_t h^O_{t-1},\\
&\text{Stay:} && c_t + b_{t+1} + \tau^p P_t h^O_{t-1} + \delta_H P_t h^O_{t-1} = R_b b_t + y_t + T_t, \qquad (3.7)\\
&\text{Rent:} && c_t + b_{t+1} + r_t h^R_t + \delta_H P_t h^O_{t-1} = R_b b_t + y_t + T_t + (1-\mu)P_t h^O_{t-1},
\end{aligned}$$

and the borrowing limit (3.2) for buyers and stayers, or $b_{t+1} \geq 0$ for renters. A buyer sells the home it owns, if any, and buys a new one; a stayer keeps its home, $h^O_t = h^O_{t-1}$; a renter sells the home it owns, if any, and rents. Every owner pays maintenance $\delta_H P_t$ per unit on the home it enters the period with, which restores it, and a seller then receives $(1-\mu)P_t$ per unit. The expectation $\mathbb{E}_t$ is over next period's efficiency and the departure of children, which takes the household from n to n_{t+1} children at home. The shocks $\varepsilon^H_{t,j}$, i.i.d. Gumbel with scale κ_T and mean zero, are one per option j: renting, or owning each $h^O \in \mathcal{H}$. Let V^j_t denote the value of option j before the shock. Then

$$V^H_t = \kappa_T \log \sum_j \exp\big(V^j_t/\kappa_T\big), \qquad \pi^H_t(j) = \frac{\exp(V^j_t/\kappa_T)}{\sum_{j'}\exp(V^{j'}_t/\kappa_T)}, \quad (3.8)$$

where $\pi^H_t(j)$ is the probability of choosing option j. An option that leaves no saving choice within the budget and borrowing constraints cannot be chosen. Housing costs, credit and earnings risk shape V^H_t, and through it the gap $V^F_{t,A} - V^F_{t,0}$ that governs fertility.

Staying or selling. Owners are part of the supply of housing when they decide to sell. An owner that enters period t with the home $h^O_{t-1} > 0$ stays if

$$\underbrace{V_t^{h^O_{t-1}} + \varepsilon^H_{t,h^O_{t-1}}}_{\text{stay}} \;\geq\; \underbrace{\max\Big\{V_t^R + \varepsilon^H_{t,R},\; \max_{h \neq h^O_{t-1}} \big(V_t^h + \varepsilon^H_{t,h}\big)\Big\}}_{\text{sell, then rent or buy}},$$

and sells otherwise. The owner compares the value of keeping its home with the value of selling it and then renting or buying another, taking into account the future path of prices.

3.3 The problems of developers and rental companies

Developers. A developer takes the price P_t and productivity Z_t as given and solves

$$\max_{X_t \geq 0} \; P_t Z_t X_t - X_t.$$

With constant returns and free entry, developers earn no profit: they build only if a unit sells for what it costs, $P_t = 1/Z_t$, and build nothing if the price is below the cost of building on the stock that survives from the previous period.[10] By (3.3) and (3.4), the stock is then

$$H_t = \max\big\{(1-\delta_H)H_{t-1},\; \bar{H}\, P_t^{\eta}\big\}. \tag{3.9}$$

Rental companies. The value of a rental company that holds H^L_{t-1} units at the end of period $t-1$ is

$$J_t\big(H^L_{t-1}\big) = \max_{H^L_t \geq 0}\Big\{\big(r_t - \tau^p P_t\big)\, H^L_t - P_t\big[H^L_t - (1-\delta_H)H^L_{t-1}\big] + \frac{1}{R_b}\, J_{t+1}\big(H^L_t\big)\Big\}.$$

The first term is the rent net of the tax, the second the cost of net purchases and the third the continuation value. As a result, in equilibrium rental companies are indifferent between holding a unit of housing for one period and investing its price in the bond,

$$R_b\big(r_t - \tau^p P_t\big) + (1-\delta_H)P_{t+1} = R_b P_t,$$

that is,

$$r_t = (1+\tau^p)\, P_t - \frac{(1-\delta_H)\, P_{t+1}}{R_b}. \tag{3.10}$$

[10] Both the aggregate stock and the supply of housing to the market have a kink at the price at which nothing is built. The supply to the market, the left-hand side of (3.12), adds construction to the homes that owners sell and the homes of households that died. Above the kink, the stock rises with the price with elasticity η, and construction adds to the supply. Below it, developers stay out of the market, so the supply comes only from existing homes. The stock is thus elastic when demand rises and rigid when it falls, as in Glaeser and Gyourko (2005, 2018). If developers built in $t-1$, construction stops only if the price falls by more than $1-(1-\delta_H)^{1/\eta}$ in one period. In a steady state, construction replaces depreciation, and $H = \bar{H}P^{\eta}$.

Rental companies supply any quantity of rental housing at this rent. The rent equals the user cost of housing: the price and the property tax, net of the discounted value of what survives to the next period. When the price is expected to fall, the rent rises relative to the price, because rental companies must be compensated for the expected capital loss.

3.4 Equilibrium

Let G_t be the measure of households over pairs $(\mathbf{s}_t, \boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_t)$, where $\mathbf{s}_t = (b_t, h^O_{t-1}, z_t, a_t, n_t)$ is the state at the beginning of period t and $\boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_t$ collects the shocks drawn within it: the fertility shocks $\boldsymbol{\varepsilon}^F_t$, whether a try would succeed, which it does with probability π_a, and the housing shocks. Let N_t be the number of households. A household first chooses whether to try, $f_t(\mathbf{s}_t, \boldsymbol{\varepsilon}^F_t)$, and after the birth outcome chooses its home $h^O_t(\mathbf{s}_t, \boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_t)$, the space it rents $h^R_t(\mathbf{s}_t, \boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_t)$ and its bond position $b_{t+1}(\mathbf{s}_t, \boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_t)$.[11]

Definition 1. Given an initial measure of households G_0, initial stocks H_{-1} and H^L_{-1}, and the homes of the households that died at the end of period -1, an equilibrium is a path of prices $\{P_t, r_t\}$, stocks $\{H_t, H^L_t\}$, construction $\{I_t\}$, pensions $\{m_t\}$, rebates $\{T_t\}$, value and policy functions, and measures $\{G_t\}$ such that every period:

1. *Households* optimize: f_t, h^O_t, h^R_t and b_{t+1} solve the problem of Section 3.2, given prices, pensions and transfers.
2. *Developers* optimize: the stock satisfies (3.9).
3. *Rental companies* optimize: the rent satisfies (3.10).
4. The *rental market* clears at the rent r_t:

$$\underbrace{H^L_t}_{\text{held by rental companies}} = \underbrace{\int h^R_t(\mathbf{s}_t, \boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_t)\, \mathrm{d}G_t(\mathbf{s}_t, \boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_t)}_{\text{rented by households}}. \tag{3.11}$$

[11] Outside the fertile ages, $f_t = 0$. A renter has $h^O_t = 0$ and an owner $h^R_t = 0$.

5. The *owner market* clears at the price P_t, with construction $I_t = H_t - (1-\delta_H)H_{t-1}$:

$$\begin{aligned}
&\underbrace{I_t}_{\text{construction}} + \underbrace{\int \mathbf{1}\{h_t^O(\mathbf{s}_t,\boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_t) \neq h_{t-1}^O\}\,(1-\delta_H)h_{t-1}^O \,\mathrm{d}G_t(\mathbf{s}_t,\boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_t)}_{\text{homes of owners who sell}} \\
&+ \underbrace{\int (1-p_a)\,(1-\delta_H)h_{t-1}^O \,\mathrm{d}G_{t-1}}_{\text{homes of households that died in } t-1} \\
&= \underbrace{\int \mathbf{1}\{h_t^O(\mathbf{s}_t,\boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_t) \neq h_{t-1}^O\}\, h_t^O(\mathbf{s}_t,\boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_t)\,\mathrm{d}G_t(\mathbf{s}_t,\boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_t)}_{\text{homes bought}} + \underbrace{\delta_H \int \mathbf{1}\{h_t^O(\mathbf{s}_t,\boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_t) = h_{t-1}^O\}\, h_{t-1}^O \,\mathrm{d}G_t(\mathbf{s}_t,\boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_t)}_{\text{maintenance of owners who stay}} \\
&+ \underbrace{H_t^L - (1-\delta_H)H_{t-1}^L}_{\text{rental companies' net purchases}} .
\end{aligned} \tag{3.12}$$

6. The *goods market* clears: output equals consumption, the good used in construction, the costs of selling homes, government consumption and net exports (Appendix C).
7. *Pensions*: payroll taxes pay the pensions of the N_t^R retired households, $\tau^w w L_t = m_t N_t^R$.
8. *Rebate*: property-tax revenue is paid to all households, $T_t N_t = \tau^p P_t H_t$.
9. *Estates*: the government pays new households their initial wealth out of the estates it collects and consumes the remainder, C_t^g, given by (C.1).
10. *Population*: births are $B_t = \int \pi_a f_t(\mathbf{s}_t, \varepsilon_t^F)\,\mathrm{d}G_t(\mathbf{s}_t,\boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_t)$, and $G_{t+1} = \Gamma_t(G_t)$, where Γ_t takes the households that survive, with probability p_a, to the states $\mathbf{s}_{t+1} = (b_{t+1}, h_t^O, z_{t+1}, a_t + 1, n_{t+1})$, in which n_{t+1} counts this period's births less the children who leave, and adds new households in proportion to past births.

Definition 2. A stationary equilibrium is a price P, a rent r, stocks H and H^L, construction I, a pension m, a rebate T, value and policy functions, and a measure of households G over $(\mathbf{s}, \boldsymbol{\varepsilon})$, such that:

1. *Households* optimize, given P, r, m and T.
2. *Developers* optimize: by (3.9), the stock is $H = \bar{H}P^{\eta}$, and construction replaces depreciation, $I = \delta_H H$.
3. *Rental companies* optimize: by (3.10), the rent is $r = \big(1 + \tau^p - (1-\delta_H)/R_b\big)P$.
4. The *rental market* clears: $H^L = \int h^R(\mathbf{s},\boldsymbol{\varepsilon})\,\mathrm{d}G(\mathbf{s},\boldsymbol{\varepsilon})$.
5. The *owner market* clears: (3.12) holds with I, H^L and G constant. With the rental market, this means that owned plus rented housing equals the stock, $\int \big(h^O(\mathbf{s},\boldsymbol{\varepsilon}) + h^R(\mathbf{s},\boldsymbol{\varepsilon})\big)\,\mathrm{d}G(\mathbf{s},\boldsymbol{\varepsilon}) = H$.
6. The *goods market* clears (Appendix C), with constant aggregates.

7. *Pensions, rebate and estates*: $\tau^w wL = mN^R$, $TN = \tau^p PH$, and the government consumes the estates net of new households' initial wealth, C^g.

8. *The measure G is invariant*: $G = \Gamma(G)$.

3.5 Mechanisms

In this section, I describe three forces that shape fertility in the model. The first is timing: the probability of being successful at conceiving falls with age, while earnings and wealth rise, and owning a large home takes a down payment, which may weigh on fertility. The second is risk: the child's space is paid for in every period the child is at home, out of uncertain earnings. The third runs through the housing market: fewer children lower the demand for housing and its price, and a lower price raises fertility. I assess them quantitatively in Sections 4.4, 5 and 6.3.

Borrowing limits and the timing of children. The chance that a try succeeds, π_a, falls with age, while earnings $e_a z_t$ rise with age through e_a (Figure 5a). A child raises by $r_t h_P$ the spending needed for the same housing services, in every period it is at home. Homes larger than $\bar{h}^R$ are only for sale, and buying a home requires a down payment: a renter cannot borrow, and an owner can borrow only against its home, by (3.2). For a household whose earnings rise, a birth can make the borrowing limit bind harder, since the child raises its spending needs now, when its income is still low.[12] Such a household can delay the child, at the cost of a lower π_a. It can have the child in rented space and forgo the owner premium χ and the homes larger than $\bar{h}^R$. Or it can have the child and buy once its savings cover the down payment.

A higher loan-to-value ratio ϕ lowers the equity $(1-\phi)P_t h_t^O$ a buyer needs, so a household can buy earlier (Figure 5b), which may make it easier to have a child. The cost of the child's space, however, stays the same: by (3.10), that space costs about $r_t h_P$ every period, whether the household rents or owns.[13] For a change in ϕ in period t, (3.5) gives[14]

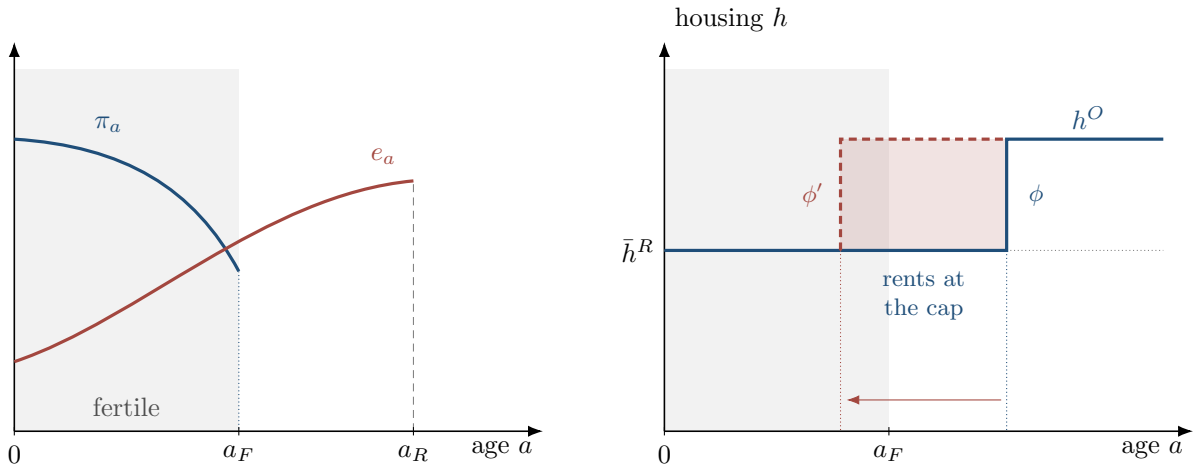
$$\frac{\partial \pi^F_{t,a}}{\partial \phi} = \frac{\pi^F_{t,a}\left(1-\pi^F_{t,a}\right)}{\kappa}\, \pi_a \left[\frac{\partial V_t^H(n_t+1)}{\partial \phi} - \frac{\partial V_t^H(n_t)}{\partial \phi} \right], \tag{3.13}$$

where $\partial V_t^H(n)/\partial\phi$ is the value of credit to a household with n children at home, positive only when the borrowing limit binds (Appendix D). Credit raises the probability of having a child only if it gives a particular benefit related to children: for example, if the household really cannot afford the down payment for a bigger house, and such a bigger house is the key element needed in order to have a kid. Section 6.3 shows that in the calibrated model credit mostly pushes young households to buy small homes they would otherwise have rented. Births come slightly earlier: completed

[12] Appendix D derives the Euler equation for the bond and the conditions behind the results below.

[13] Apart from the selling cost, an owner that holds a unit from t to $t+1$ pays $(1+\tau^p)P_t$ in period t and holds $(1-\delta_H)P_{t+1}$ in period $t+1$, so by (3.10) its cost, in period-t units, equals the rent r_t.

[14] Here $\kappa = \kappa_1$ before the first child and κ_C after. A permanent change in ϕ adds the corresponding terms for all future periods, discounted and weighted by survival.



(a) Chance of a birth and earnings

(b) Housing by age

Figure 5: Timing of fertility, earnings and the purchase of a family home

Notes: Schematic. The shaded area marks the fertile ages. In panel (b), the solid line is the housing of a household that rents until its savings cover the down payment on a family home h^O at the loan-to-value ratio ϕ. The dashed line is the same household at $\phi' > \phi$, and the shaded area is the family space it gains.

fertility falls slightly for the cohort aged 18 to 21 in 2023, and rises moderately for later cohorts.

Earnings risk. A child stays at home for $1/\lambda$ periods on average, so its space must be paid for in years of low earnings as well as high. Consider a renter at the borrowing limit, $b_t = b_{t+1} = 0$, that rents below the cap. Maximizing (3.1) subject to $c_t + r_t h_t^R = y_t + T_t$ gives the flow utility

$$u(c_t, h_t^R, n_t) = \frac{1}{1-\sigma}\left[\Theta_t \frac{y_t + T_t - r_t \bar{h}(n_t)}{e(n_t)}\right]^{1-\sigma} + \psi_t\, v(n_t), \tag{3.14}$$

where Θ_t is a function of the rent r_t.[15] A child enters the first term of (3.14) in two ways. Its space, $r_t h_P$, is a committed expenditure, paid out of income before the household divides the rest between consumption and additional space. The equivalence scale $e(n_t)$ then spreads what is left over more adult equivalents. The second term, $\psi_t v(n_t)$, is the value of the child. Let $\Delta_t(y_t)$ be the utility cost of a first child: the first term of (3.14) with $n_t = 0$ minus the same term with $n_t = 1$. Figure 6 shows two properties of this cost. First, it is higher when earnings are low, and convex in earnings, so a bad year raises the cost by more than a good year lowers it, and earnings risk raises its expected value. Second, this is stronger when the child's space is more expensive, so the lower rent of the new steady state also lowers the cost of risk. Both properties hold for $\sigma \geq 1$ (Appendix D). Savings soften this effect. Section 5.3 measures it in the calibrated model.

Households and the housing market. I refer to a stationary equilibrium (Section 3.4) as a steady state. In a steady state, the measure of households is invariant, so their number is constant:

[15] $\Theta_t = \alpha_0^{\alpha_0}(1-\alpha_0)^{1-\alpha_0} r_t^{\alpha_0 - 1}$.

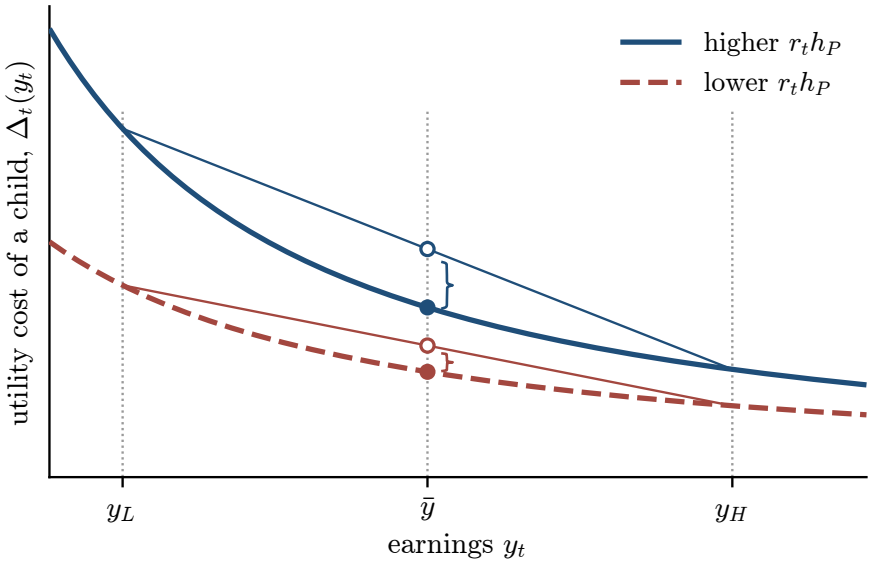


Figure 6: Earnings risk and the utility cost of a child

Notes: The figure is computed from (3.14) at the parameters of Section 4 (Appendix D). The curves plot the cost of a first child, Δ_t, against earnings for a renter with no savings, who spends its income each period, at the rent of the initial steady state (solid) and of the new steady state of Figure 7 (dashed). Earnings are y_L or y_H with equal probability. Filled circles mark the cost at expected earnings $\bar{y}$, open circles the expected cost, and the braces the additional cost due to risk.

each period, the children who leave home replace the households that die, and fertility is at the replacement rate $\bar{n}$. Since the household problem, the pension and the rebate per household do not depend on the number of households, the steady-state price is the one at which households choose replacement fertility, $n(P;\psi) = \bar{n}$. The housing market then determines the number of households N: the housing they own or rent, $N\,h(P;\psi)$, must equal the stock $\bar{H}P^{\eta}$, and construction replaces depreciation.[16]

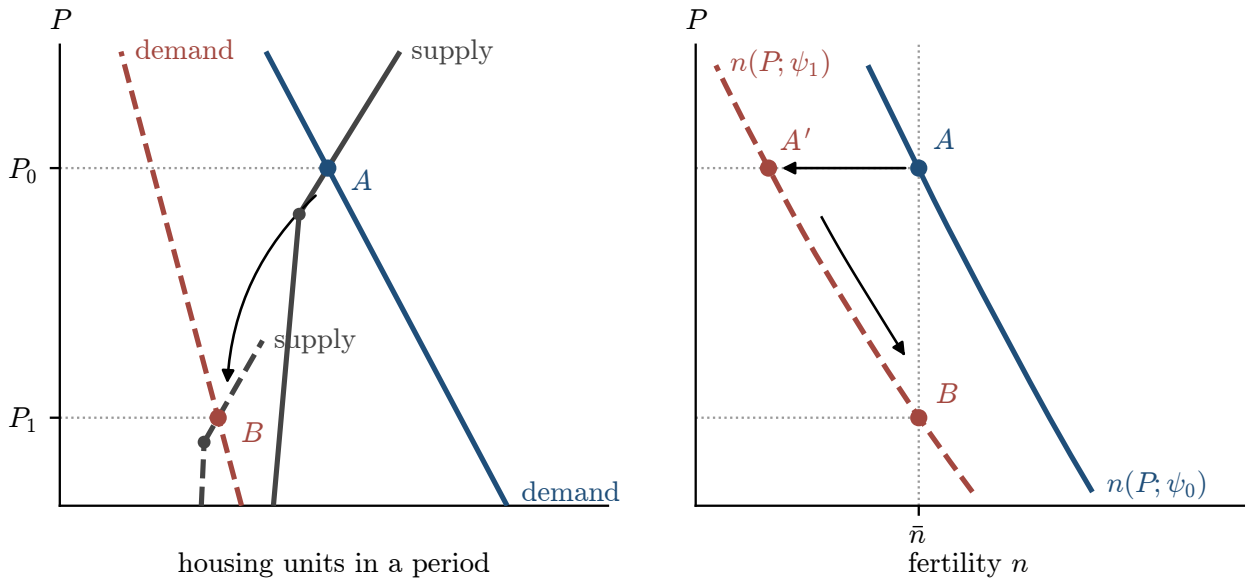
Figure 7 is helpful to understand how the housing market feeds back on fertility. It also illustrates the notion of steady state and the approach to the quantification in the next section. Starting from a steady state, the preference for children falls permanently from ψ_0 to ψ_1, and I compare the steady state the economy starts from with the one it converges to. Panel (b) plots the fertility households choose at each price, $n(P;\psi)$, under the two preferences. Panel (a) plots supply and demand in the market for owned homes (3.12), in each steady state. Supply comes from the homes of households that died, the homes of owners who sell, and construction, and has a kink at the price below which developers stop building.[17] Demand comes from households that buy a home, owners who stay and replace depreciation, and the net purchases of rental companies.

[16] Households respond to the rent. In a steady state, the rent is proportional to the price by (3.10), so housing and fertility can be read against the price. Along a transition, the rent also reflects the expected change in the price.

[17] Developers build only if the price covers the cost of adding to the homes that survive from the previous period. Above that price, construction makes supply elastic. Below it, nothing is built, and only existing homes are sold: the homes of owners who sell, which rise with the price, and the homes of households that died, which are sold at any price. Supply therefore never falls below the latter, hence the positive intercept. With fewer surviving homes, as at B, developers start building at a lower price.

A steady state is characterized by fertility being at replacement rate. The economy starts at A, where households choose replacement fertility at P_0 and the market clears with N_0 households. When the preference for children falls, households have fewer children at the same price, at A', so P_0 is no longer a steady-state price. Fertility is back at replacement when housing is cheaper, at P_1. At B, the market clears at that price with fewer households, N_1. Fewer homes are then bought and sold, so demand and the supply of existing homes are both smaller.

Between A and B, both curves move every period, as the supply depends on the homes that survive from the previous period and on who owns them. Section 4.4 computes this transition. Along it, smaller cohorts reduce the number of households and the demand for housing, and the price falls, but never by enough in one period to stop construction.



(a) Owner market (b) Fertility

Figure 7: The housing market and fertility

Notes: Panel (a) is a schematic of the owner market (3.12), drawn at the holdings of the initial steady state A (solid) and of the new steady state B (dashed). Dots mark the kinks of supply. Demand and the homes that come from existing owners are drawn in proportion to the number of households. Panel (b) is computed from solves of the model at given prices, at the parameters of Section 4 (Appendix D). It shows the fertility households choose at each price, under ψ_0 (solid) and ψ_1 (dashed), and the dotted line marks replacement. A' is the fertility households would choose under ψ_1 at the price P_0.

4 Quantification

In this section, I describe the quantification of the model. Because fertility rates vary a lot over time and the age distribution of the population reflects many years of past fertility decisions, some assumptions are needed to make the quantification tractable. To this end, I approximate the United States economy of 2007 with a steady state in which births are at replacement. I parameterize the model so that this steady state matches fertility, housing and wealth moments of 2007. Holding

these parameters fixed, I then let the preference for children ψ_t fall after 2007 so that the model matches the decline in fertility until 2023, and I solve for the transition of the economy as prices, family composition and household entry adjust (Section 4.4). I treat this fall as an exogenous shock to preferences and take it as given. The 2023 state of this transition is the starting point of the policy experiments in Section 6.

4.1 Quantification strategy

Two measures of fertility guide the quantification (Figure 8). Period fertility, or the total fertility rate, is the number of children a woman would have if she lived through her fertile years at the birth rates of a given year. Completed fertility is the number of children a woman has had by the end of her fertile years. I measure it at ages 40 to 44. Whether a population replaces itself depends on completed fertility, which is then the key number to look at when thinking about population growth trends. In a steady state the two measures coincide. Out of a steady state, completed fertility lags period fertility, because it adds up the births of a cohort over two decades. In the United States, period fertility peaked at about 2.1 in 2007 and fell to 1.62 by 2023, while completed fertility was still 1.92 in 2024. If period fertility stayed at its 2023 level, completed fertility would fall to 1.62 within about two decades, as the cohorts that had their children before 2007 age out.[18]

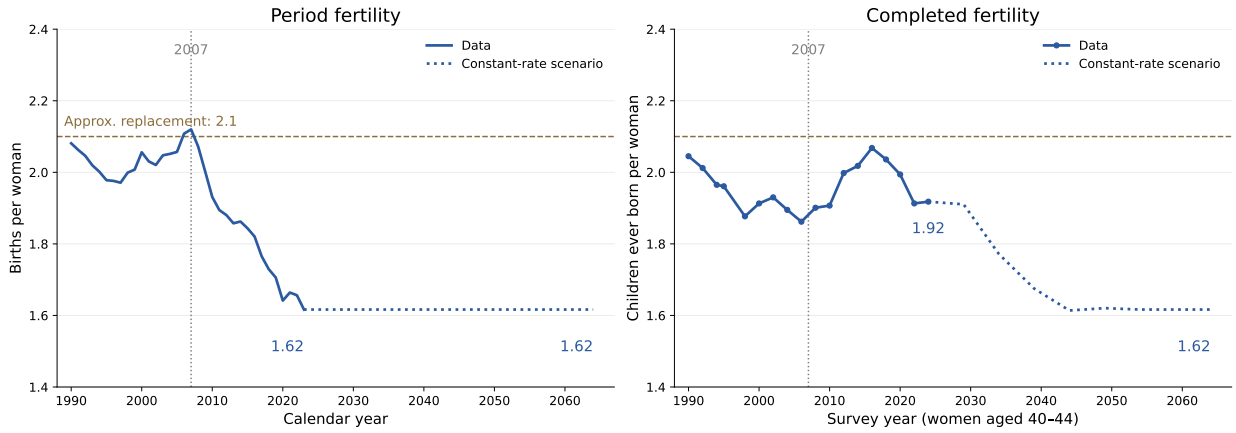


Figure 8: Period and completed fertility in the United States

Notes: Left: period total fertility rate, World Development Indicators. Right: children ever born to women aged 40–44, CPS Fertility Supplement. Dotted lines: a constant-rate scenario that holds period fertility at its 2023 level; the completed-fertility continuation is rescaled to end at that rate.

The transition follows the logic of Section 3.5: fertility falls first at about the inherited price, and the price falls as smaller cohorts enter. I compare each policy experiment with the path the economy follows from 2023 without it.

[18] The same lag then is the reason the number of households does not fall instantly when fertility falls: fewer births lower the number of new households only slowly, as the smaller cohorts reach adulthood. This is also why, despite almost two decades of below-replacement period fertility, the population of the United States has not yet started to decrease.

I divide the parameters of the 2007 economy into two groups. The first group is assigned from external evidence or measured directly in the data. The second is chosen so that the model matches a set of moments in the data. Table 2 reports the moments, and Table 1 the parameters.

4.2 Assigned parameters

Table 1: Parameter values

Assigned			Calibrated		
σ	2	risk aversion	β_{ann}	0.936	annual discount factor
(ω, ν)	0.7, 0.7	equivalence scale	ψ_0	0.177	preference for children
α_0	0.733	consumption weight	γ	0.646	curvature, benefit of children
λ	2/9	child departure, per period	ξ	0.295	first-birth utility cost
π_a	0.98–0.50	success of a birth attempt	κ_1	0.050	first-birth taste scale
ϕ	0.80	financed share	κ_C	0.129	later-birth taste scale
μ	0.06	selling cost	h_P	0.89	space requirement (rooms)
δ_H	0.014	depreciation, annual	χ	1.112	owner service multiplier
τ^p	0.0106	property tax, annual	κ_T	0.013	tenure taste scale
r	0.02	real interest rate, annual	θ_0	0.244	bequest-motive scale
τ^w	0.08	payroll tax	$\bar{H}$	6.776	housing supply scale
η	0.63	housing-supply elasticity			
$\bar{h}^R$	6	rental size cap (rooms)			
θ_1	0.008	bequest shifter			
(ρ_z, σ_z)	0.735, 0.484	earnings, per four years			

Notes: Assigned parameters are set outside the calibration (Section 4.2); calibrated parameters are chosen to match the moments of Table 2 (Section 4.3).

Demographics and timing. A period in the model lasts four years. Households enter at 18, retire at 66 and live at most through 85. Survival is certain before retirement and, after it, follows the 2023 period life table of the Social Security Administration. Births are possible through age 45. The probability that an attempt succeeds within a period falls with age as $\pi_a = 1 - 0.02\, e^{0.134(a-18)}$, and is zero from age 45, using the exponential form of Sommer (2016). The schedule gives 0.90 at 30, 0.80 at 35 and 0.62 at 40, close to the probabilities of a conception leading to a live birth within four years computed by Leridon (2004), 0.91, 0.84 and 0.64. A child leaves home with probability $\lambda = 2/9$ per period, so children stay at home for 18 years on average.[19]

Preferences. Flow utility (3.1) is

$$u(c, \hat{h}, n) = \frac{1}{1-\sigma}\left[\frac{c^{\alpha_0}\left(\hat{h} - \chi^{\mathbf{1}\{\text{own}\}}\,\bar{h}(n)\right)^{1-\alpha_0}}{e(n)}\right]^{1-\sigma} + \psi\, n^{1-\gamma}, \qquad e(n) = \left(\frac{2+\omega n}{2}\right)^{\nu}.$$

[19] Stocks, such as wealth and house prices, are in annual units, and flows, such as income, consumption and rent, accrue over the four years. Interest, discounting and depreciation compound over the period, so $R_b = 1.02^4$ and $\beta = \beta_{\text{ann}}^4$, and the property tax is four times its annual rate. A data statistic for an age window weights each four-year model cell by the share of the cell inside the window.

I set the curvature to $\sigma = 2$, a common choice in the literature. The equivalence scale $e(n)$ is that of Scholz et al. (2006), with $\omega = \nu = 0.7$: a couple with two children needs 1.45 times the consumption, and the housing services above its requirement, of a childless couple to reach the same utility. The consumption weight $\alpha_0 = 0.733$ is set to match the share of housing in the spending of childless renters in the 2019–2023 CEX, 26.7%. Indeed, a childless renter has no space requirement and no owner multiplier, so its utility is Cobb–Douglas in consumption and rented space, and it spends a share $1 - \alpha_0$ of its budget on rent.

Housing finance and taxes. The annual real interest rate is 2%, and selling a home costs 6% of its value, as in Greaney et al. (2025). Buyers can finance at most $\phi = 0.80$ of the price, the conventional limit above which a mortgage requires private insurance, and there is no limit on payments relative to income. I measure depreciation and the property tax at the national level, with the method of Greaney et al. (2025). Depreciation, 1.4% a year, is the 2007 depreciation of owner-occupied residential structures in the BEA fixed-asset accounts, divided by the value of the housing stock, land included, in the Financial Accounts of the Federal Reserve. The property tax, 1.06% of value, is the ratio of aggregate property taxes to the aggregate value of owner-occupied homes in the 2007–2011 ACS. Retirees receive a common pension equal to 23% of mean earnings, the ratio in the CPS ASEC, and the payroll tax that finances it is 8%.

Earnings. A household of age a earns $e_a z_t$, where

$$\log z_{t+1} = \rho_z \log z_t + \epsilon_{t+1}, \qquad \epsilon_{t+1} \sim N(0, \sigma_z^2).$$

I estimate ρ_z and σ_z from the variance and first autocovariance of log household earnings, averaged over non-overlapping four-year spells and net of age and year effects, in the 1984–1997 PSID, the last years in which the survey is annual. This gives $\rho_z = 0.735$ and $\sigma_z = 0.484$, which I approximate with nine states. The age profile e_a is hump-shaped and normalized to average one over working ages: earnings rise by about half from ages 18–25 to their peak at ages 34–45, and decline modestly before retirement.

Housing. Owners choose among homes of 2, 4, 6, 8 and 10 rooms, and renters any size up to $\bar{h}^R = 6$ rooms. The cap reflects the rental stock: in the 2023 AHS, 43% of owner-occupied homes have seven or more rooms, against 7.5% of rented homes (Appendix B). The supply elasticity in (3.9) is $\eta = 0.63$, from the estimates of floor-space supply of Baum-Snow and Han (2024).

Entry wealth. Households enter the economy with the wealth of young adults in the PSID: the net worth of childless renters aged 18 to 24. Negative values are set to zero, since households in the model cannot borrow without collateral.

Bequests. In the bequest motive, θ_1 determines how far bequests are a luxury good. I set it to 1% of median annual earnings in the model, $\theta_1 = 0.008$, as in Greaney et al. (2025).

4.3 Calibrated parameters

I choose the remaining eleven parameters so that the 2007 steady state matches the eleven moments in Table 2.[20] The parameters are chosen jointly, but some moments are more informative about some parameters than others. I group them into four blocks and, for each, describe the variation in the data that disciplines it and the mechanism in the model through which it does.

As the model contains many contemporaneous interactions, there are several things to keep in mind to properly inform the different parameters. First, fertility and housing are determined together. In the 2007 steady state, the house price is the one at which completed fertility equals replacement, so a parameter that lowers births also lowers the price, and a lower price raises the space households occupy and how often they own. I separate the two blocks with moments that respond to the price very differently. How births are spread across women and over the life cycle, measured by the shares of childless women and of mothers with one child and by the mean age at first birth, barely moves with the price. Mean rooms and ownership respond strongly to it. Mean rooms then pin the price, and the fertility moments identify the parameters that govern who has children and when. Second, households with children occupy more space than other households, partly because a child requires space and partly because parents are older and have higher earnings and savings. The change in rooms within households at the first birth, relative to adults who never have a child, isolates the space a child requires, h_P. The difference in ownership between recent parents and other households measures how closely tenure follows these needs, κ_T. Third, a change in when women have children and a change in how many they have both move period fertility. The distribution of completed family size at ages 40 to 44 measures how many children women have, and the mean age at first birth measures when they start.

Fertility. I choose the first-birth cost $\xi = 0.295$ to match the share of childless women aged 40 to 44 in the June Fertility Supplement of the CPS, pooling 2004 and 2006, 19.8%, and the curvature $\gamma = 0.646$ to match the share of mothers with exactly one child, 21.4%. Given that the cost is paid only at the first birth, a higher ξ raises childlessness, and mothers have larger families. A higher γ makes the benefit of an additional child decline faster, so childlessness falls and more mothers stop at one.

Timing of births. I include taste shocks in the fertility decision because, in the data, otherwise similar households make different choices. First births are spread over the whole fertile window, from the late teens to the early forties, and women in the lowest third of family income have

[20] The parameters minimize a sum of squared gaps between model and data moments, each divided by a tolerance for the moment (Appendix E).

about as many children by ages 40 to 44 as women in the top third. The shocks help explain this idiosyncratic variation. The scale of the first-birth shocks, $\kappa_1 = 0.050$, governs how much first births depart from the trade-off between fecundity and earnings of Section 3.5. A larger κ_1 spreads first births over the fertile window, so the mean age at first birth, 26.0 years in the NCHS natality files for 2003–2006, rises. I choose κ_1 to match it. The estimate is small: first births follow the economic trade-off closely, and the shocks mostly spread them across ages. The scale for later births, $\kappa_C = 0.129$, determines how willing mothers are to have more than one child. Since the option of further births raises the value of becoming a parent, a larger κ_C also brings first births forward, and I choose it to match the share of women who are mothers by age 25, 45.7% in the CPS.

Preference for children, housing and tenure. The preference ψ_0 is the taste for children in the 2007 steady state, before the decline of Section 4.4. I choose it so that completed fertility equals replacement, 2.1, and the supply scale $\bar{H}$ so that mean rooms are 5.73, as in the 2007 AHS. The two are chosen together: a larger $\bar{H}$ lowers the house price, households occupy more space, and replacement then requires a lower ψ_0. This gives $\psi_0 = 0.177$ and $\bar{H} = 6.776$.

I choose the owner multiplier $\chi = 1.112$ to match ownership among heads aged 30 to 55 in the 2005–2006 ACS, 67.6%.[21] An owner obtains χ times the services of the same home, so a higher χ raises the value of owning relative to renting.

The space requirement $h_P = 0.89$ rooms is disciplined by the change in housing within households at the first birth. Recall from Section 2.2 that future parents in the PSID live in 4.71 rooms two to three years before the first birth, and three to four years after it occupy 1.44 more rooms, relative to the change among adults who never have a child. I run the same regression on households in the model. The requirement is the space a household must add once it has a child, and this jump is the most direct measure of it in the data.

The tenure taste scale $\kappa_T = 0.013$ is disciplined by the difference in ownership between recent parents and other households. In the ACS, heads whose oldest child is under four own at a rate 12.8 percentage points higher than heads with no children at home. In the model, homes larger than $\bar{h}^R$ rooms are only for sale, so the space requirement pushes parents into ownership. A smaller κ_T makes tenure follow these needs more closely and widens the gap.

Wealth and bequests. I choose the discount factor $\beta = 0.936$ (annual) to match aggregate net worth of 4.46 times aggregate annual gross labor earnings in the PSID:[22] as more patient households save more, wealth accumulation responds directly to the discount factor. The bequest scale $\theta_0 = 0.244$ governs the incentives to hold on to wealth in old age. I choose it to match the

[21] Both ownership samples exclude mobile homes, boats and vans (ACS structure codes 3 to 10), which have no counterpart in the model.

[22] Net worth of heads aged 18 to 85, excluding business and farm equity and other real estate; gross labor earnings of heads aged 18 to 65.

annual flow of estates to children in the 2007 SCF, 0.73% of aggregate net worth.

Table 2 shows the targets and the estimated moments.

Table 2: Moments used in the calibration

Moment	Data	Model
Completed fertility	2.10	2.10
Childless, women 40–44 (%)	19.8	20.1
Exactly one child, mothers 40–44 (%)	21.4	21.7
Mean age at first birth (years)	25.98	25.97
Mothers by age 25 (%)	45.7	45.5
Mean occupied rooms	5.73	5.75
Ownership, heads 30–55 (%)	67.6	66.9
Recent-parent ownership gap	0.128	0.125
First-birth room response	1.440	1.475
Wealth / annual gross earnings	4.46	4.35
Annual bequests / wealth (%)	0.73	0.73

Notes: Fertility: CPS June Fertility Supplement 2004 and 2006, women 40–44, and mothers by 25; NCHS natality 2003–2006 for the mean age at first birth; completed fertility is a normalization. Housing: AHS 2007 for rooms; ACS 2005–2006 for ownership and the gap between heads whose oldest child is under four and heads without children; PSID event study for the room response, measured in the model with the same design on simulated households. Wealth: PSID 2005 and 2007; bequests: SCF 2007. Owners choose among homes of 2, 4, 6, 8 and 10 rooms. The 2007 house price is 0.771.

Identification and sensitivity. I gain insight into identification with two related exercises: I examine how large changes in each parameter affect the moment most tied to it, and which moments respond most to a small change in each parameter. Figure 9 shows the first exercise. Each panel changes one parameter and keeps the others at their estimates, and the house price adjusts so that completed fertility stays at replacement. A higher cost of the first child, ξ, raises the share of childless women, since only parents pay it. A higher γ makes the benefit of an additional child decline faster, so more mothers stop at one. A larger space requirement, h_P, raises the increase in rooms at the first birth, because a household that has a child must add that space. A stronger taste for children, ψ_0, raises the price at which births are at replacement, and households live in fewer rooms. More patient households save more, so wealth rises with β.

For the second exercise, I change each parameter by 1%, keep the others fixed, and measure the percentage change in every moment. Appendix E reports the results.

4.4 The fertility decline, 2007–2023

Starting from the 2007 steady state, I hold all estimated parameters fixed and let the preference for children decline permanently from its 2007 level ψ_0 toward a lower level ψ',

$$\psi_t = \psi' + (\psi_0 - \psi')\,\rho^{\tau}, \tag{4.1}$$

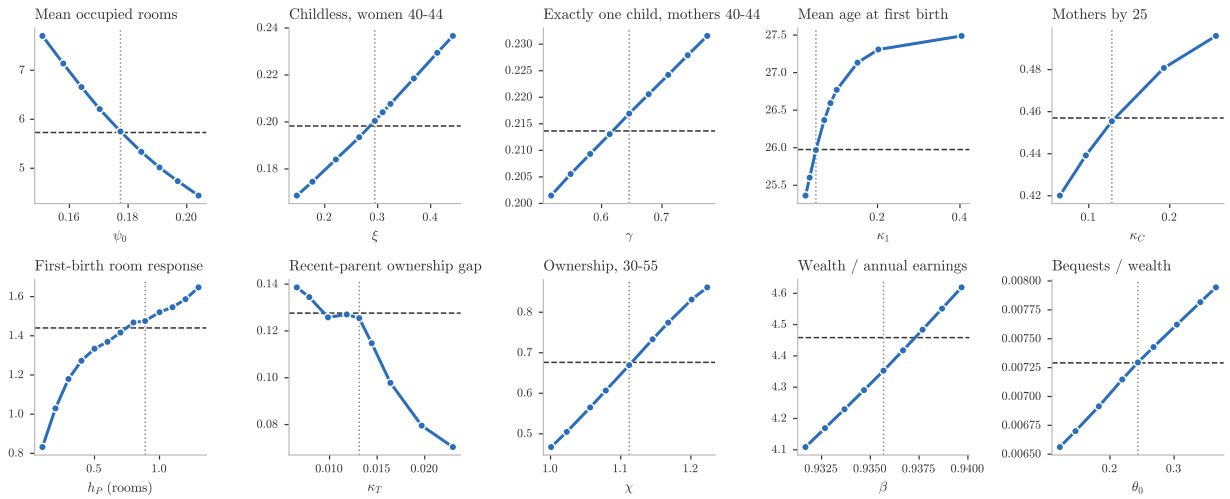


Figure 9: Parameter variation

Notes: Dotted lines: estimates. Dashed lines: data. The house price keeps completed fertility at replacement.

where τ counts four-year periods since 2007. Households learn the whole path in 2007 and have perfect foresight about it and about prices. The house price, the pension and the rebate clear their markets at every date (Appendix F). I set $\rho = 0.35$ and choose $\psi' = 0.148$ to match period fertility in 2020–2023, 1.646 (Figure 10).[23] The decline in ψ_t summarizes changes in the incentives to have children that the model does not otherwise capture.[24] From the period dated 2023 on, period fertility is 1.63 and rises slowly, to 1.73 by 2063.

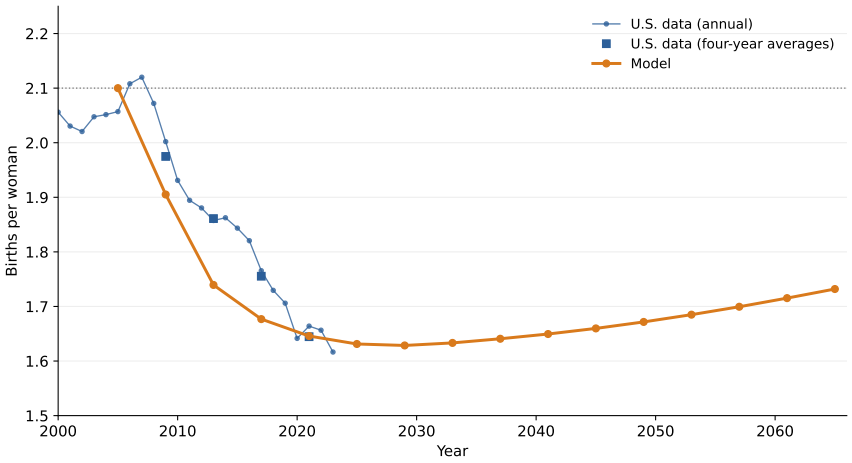


Figure 10: Period fertility, model and data, 2007–2063

Notes: Model: births per woman in each four-year period of the transition from the 2007 steady state. Data: annual period fertility and its four-year averages.

[23] A model period is dated by its first year and compared with the average period fertility of the four following calendar years: the period dated 2019 with 2020–2023.

[24] See Kearney et al. (2022) and Doepke et al. (2023) for reviews of the recent decline in fertility and its possible causes.

Figure 11 shows the whole transition. Period fertility returns to replacement slowly: it is 2.09 by 2203, and by 2403 the economy is at its new steady state, with the number of households at 49%, total housing at 67% and the house price at 53% of their 2007 levels. As the population shrinks, the house price falls: it is 3.6% below its 2007 level in 2023 and 19.3% below in 2063. The rent does not follow the price down at first. Along a transition, rent equals the user cost net of the expected capital gain, so a price that is expected to keep falling raises the rent: in 2023 the rent per room is 2.0% above its 2007 level.

To illustrate the role of the housing stock in determining fertility in the model, the dashed lines in Figure 11 show the same transition with the total housing stock H held at its 2023 level from 2023 on. With a fixed stock, the price falls much further, to 47% of its 2007 level around 2111. At that price fertility overshoots replacement, reaching 2.18 around 2119, and the additional children fill the fixed stock a generation later. As they do, the price recovers and fertility returns to replacement. In the long run the price is the same as in the baseline, 53% of its 2007 level, because fertility at replacement pins it. The stock determines only how many households live at that price, 71% of the 2007 level instead of 49%. This suggests a potential role for housing supply in speeding up the recovery of fertility, which I explore in Section 6.

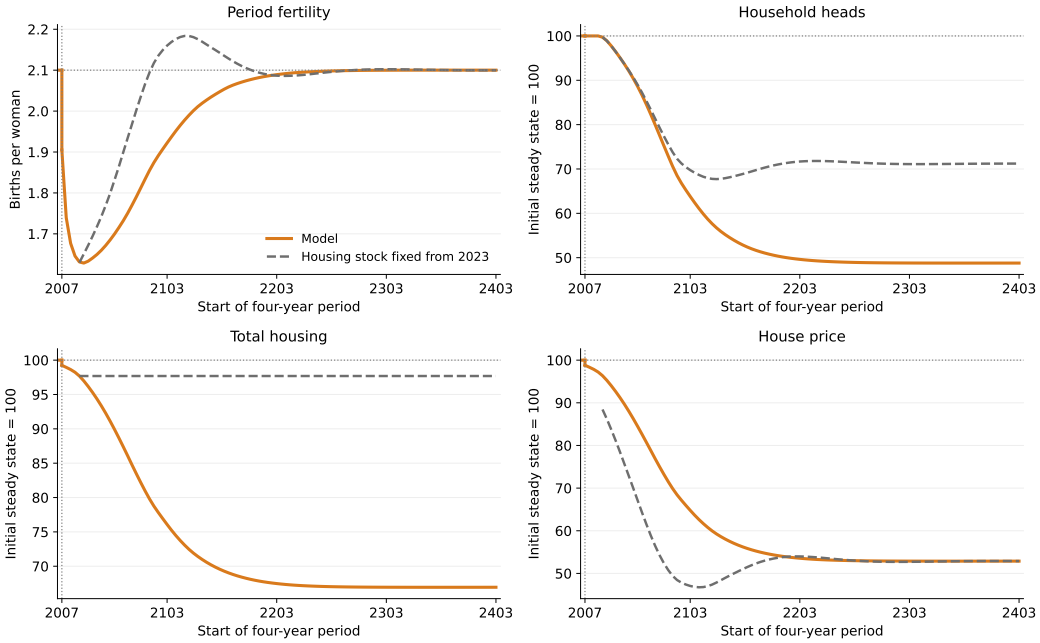


Figure 11: The full transition, 2007–2403

Notes: Period fertility, number of household heads, total housing and the house price along the transition, with the initial steady state normalized to 100. Dashed: the same transition with the housing stock held at its 2023 level from 2023 on.

4.5 Testing the model

I conclude by comparing the model with some moments that the calibration does not target, reported in Table 3. The first is how many children mothers have beyond the first. This matters because the space requirement does not rise with the number of children, so later births test the other costs and benefits of children in the model. The calibration targets the share of women with no children and the share of mothers with one child, but not how the remaining mothers split between two children and three or more. The model matches this split: 32.2% of women aged 40 to 44 have two children and 30.4% have three or more, against 34.4% and 28.6% in the CPS. The second is the timing of first births, which matters because the central trade-off in the model is one of timing, between fecundity that falls with age and earnings and savings that rise with it. The model matches the share of first births at 30 or later, 24.2% against 24.9% in the natality files. The third is the dispersion of wealth among the old, which reflects how much households save: the ratio of the 90th percentile to the median of wealth relative to income at ages 76 to 84 is 3.27 in the model and 3.52 in the PSID. The model fits two housing moments less well. Children are linked to housing in the model through the space they require and the ownership of large homes. Households with three or more children occupy 0.57 more rooms than those with one or two, against 0.39 in the data, and ownership rises around the first birth by 14 percentage points, against 26.

Table 3: Moments not targeted, 2007

Moment	Source	Data	Model
First births at age 30+ (%)	NCHS 2003–2006	24.9	24.2
Rooms: 3+ versus 1–2 resident children	ACS 2005–2006	0.385	0.574
First-birth ownership response	PSID event study	0.261	0.141
Wealth/income p90 / median, ages 76–84	PSID	3.52	3.27

Notes: This table reports moments that do not enter the loss (E.1). The ownership response is the event-study coefficient of Section 2 on the model's observation support, measured on simulated households with the same design.

Figure 12 compares the life-cycle profiles of ownership, rooms and first births by age with the data. The calibration only targets ownership among heads aged 30 to 55, mean rooms and the mean age at first birth, so the shape of these profiles is untargeted. The model reproduces fairly well the rise of ownership with age. It also matches the hump in housing size: rooms rise until the forties and then decline, although the model profile is steeper. First births by age of the mother also follow the data closely. Young households own too often in the model, 34% at 18–21 and 44% at 22–25, against 12% and 24% in the data, and older households keep their homes, since the model has no health or long-term-care risk that would lead them to sell.

Appendix G compares the 2023 economy, the starting point of the policy experiments, with the 2023 data. None of these moments is targeted by the transition. The model reproduces the direction of the shift in the timing of births: from 2007 to 2023 the share of women who are mothers by 25 falls by 13 percentage points in the model and by 18 in the data, in line with the fall in birth rates

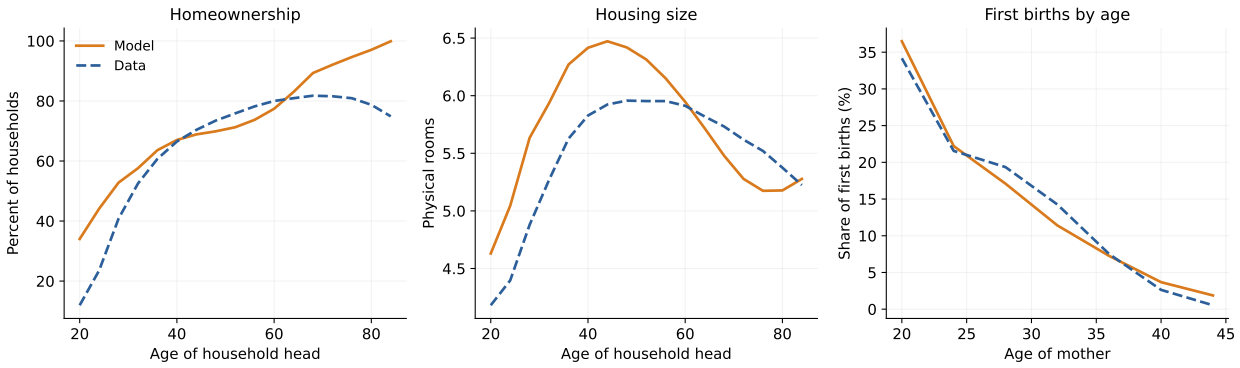


Figure 12: Life-cycle profiles in 2007, model and data

Notes: Homeownership and rooms by age of the household head, and the distribution of first births by age of the mother. Model: 2007 steady state. Data: ownership and rooms (at most nine) from the 2005–2006 ACS; first births by four-year age group from the NCHS natality files for 2005–2007.

at younger ages documented by Kearney et al. (2022). It also matches the share of mothers of only one child, 22.2% in both, and mean rooms, with the model producing 5.51 against 5.58 in the data. To illustrate a shortcoming of modelling the decline through a single preference shock, take childlessness. In the model, the decline operates similarly on every cohort alive, so childlessness among women aged 40 to 44 rises to 28.7%. In the data, instead, it moved only from 19.8% to 18.8%.

5 Household Choices in the Calibrated Model

In this section, I explore how households in the calibrated model respond to parenthood, and how earnings risk shapes the decision to have kids. First, I show that having children changes housing, consumption and tenure. A child increases the demand for space, and the cost weighs most on households with little wealth or low earnings. Second, I illustrate the impact of income risk: lowering the standard deviation of earnings shocks raises completed fertility.

5.1 Choices at the first birth

Figure 13 compares the choices of the same household in the period in which it has no child and in the period in which a first child is born. The household is a renter aged 26 to 29 with median earnings, and the figure varies its liquid wealth. Without savings, a first child pushes the space the household rents close to the rental cap and lowers the probability of owning from 42% to 24%. The child needs space when the household can least afford a down payment, so it rents and pays for the space out of consumption. With more than about two years of earnings in liquid wealth, the child instead raises the probability of owning, and the household buys a larger home.

Panel (d) shows the value of trying for a child, $V^F_{t,A} - V^F_{t,0}$. It is negative without savings and rises

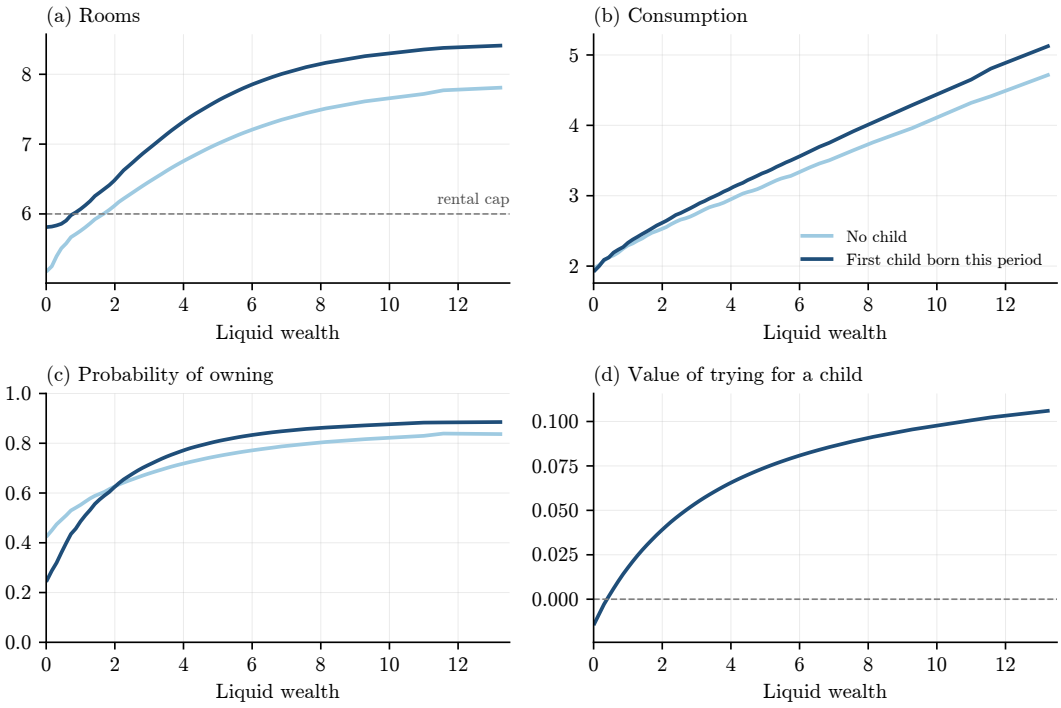


Figure 13: Choices with and without a first child

Notes: Renter aged 26–29 with median earnings ($z = 0.78$), 2007 stationary equilibrium. Liquid wealth in units of mean annual earnings. Rooms and consumption are averages over tenure choices.

steeply at low wealth before flattening. Wealth therefore matters for the decision to have a first child, disproportionately so among poor households.

5.2 Choices across earnings

Figure 14 repeats the comparison across earnings states, for renters aged 26 to 29 without savings. A first child adds about two thirds of a room at earnings up to the median, and about half a room at high earnings, where most of these households buy a home even without a child. Consumption falls by 21% at the lowest state and by 2% at the median state. At high earnings it rises, because the equivalence scale raises the household's needs and these households can afford to meet them. As discussed in Section 3.5, the space requirement does not depend on renting or owning, so owning does not avoid its cost. Since this cost is the same for every household, it weighs most on those with low earnings.

5.3 Earnings risk

Section 3.5 showed that earnings risk raises the expected cost of a child, since that cost falls with earnings at a decreasing rate. To measure this force, I lower the standard deviation of the four-year earnings shock by about a quarter, from 0.48 to 0.35, rescale the earnings states to keep mean

earnings unchanged, and solve the model at the 2007 price. Lower risk raises completed fertility by 12%, from 2.10 to 2.36. Figure 16 below reports the effect over a range of values of earnings risk.

Figure 15 shows where the additional births come from. In the baseline, the model matches the distribution of children ever born among women in their early forties. Lower risk shifts households out of childlessness and toward larger families: the share without children falls from 20% to 12%, and the shares with two and with three or more rise.

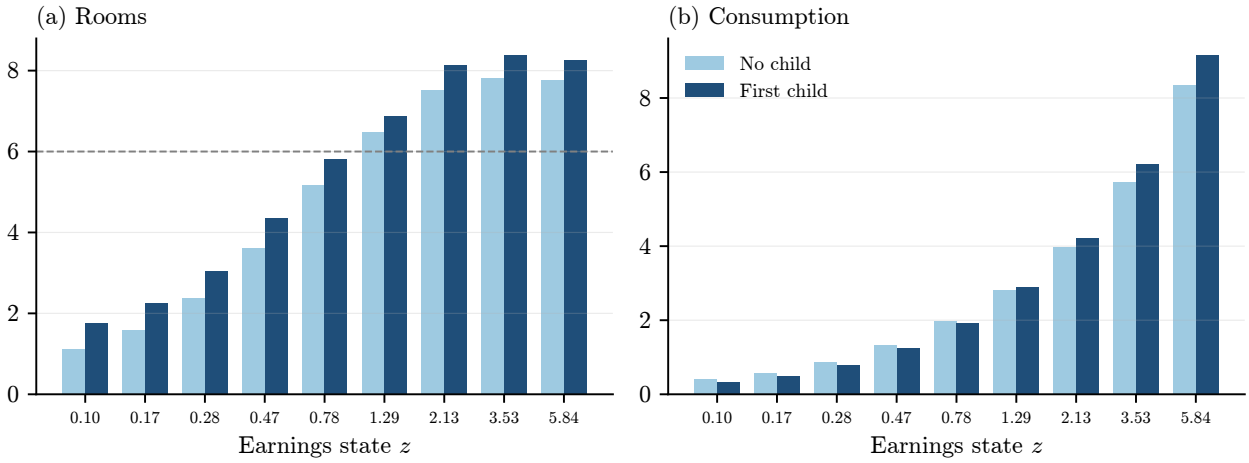


Figure 14: Choices with and without a first child, by earnings

Notes: Renters aged 26–29 without savings, 2007 stationary equilibrium, by earnings state z. Rooms and consumption are averages over tenure choices. The dashed line marks the rental cap $\bar{h}^R$.

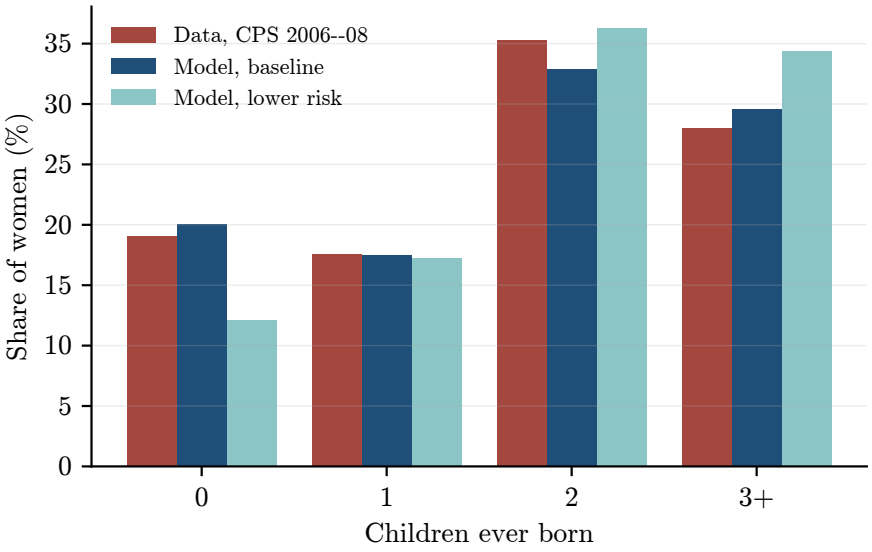


Figure 15: Earnings risk and children ever born

Notes: Shares with 0, 1, 2, and 3 or more children ever born. Data: CPS June Fertility Supplement, 2006 and 2008, women aged 40–44. Model: households at about age 42, 2007 stationary equilibrium, at the estimated earnings risk ($\sigma_z = 0.48$, baseline) and at lower risk ($\sigma_z = 0.35$, earnings states rescaled to keep mean earnings unchanged), same price.

Earnings risk weighs more when a child requires more space. Figure 16 solves the model at the 2007 price for different values of the space a child requires, h_P, and of the standard deviation of earnings shocks. Lowering risk to 0.35 raises completed fertility by 10% when a child requires half a room, and by 17% when it requires 1.6 rooms. The child's space must be paid in every period the child is at home, including after a bad earnings draw, when consumption is most valuable. The more space a child requires, the more these periods cost, and the more a household gains from lower risk.

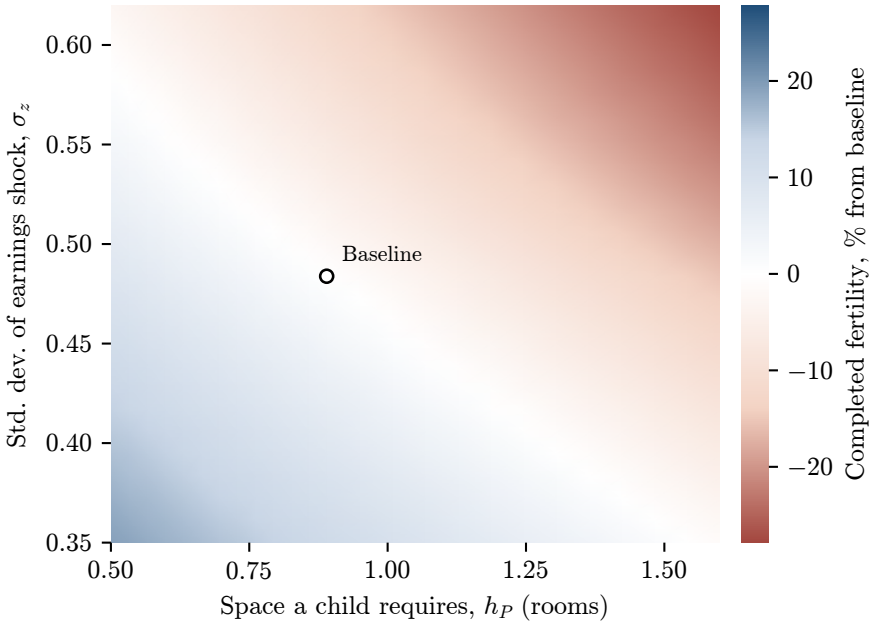


Figure 16: Earnings risk and the space a child requires

Notes: Completed fertility, % change from the baseline (marked), 2007 stationary equilibrium, same price, on a grid of 25 values of each parameter. Vertical axis: standard deviation of the four-year earnings shock, with earnings states rescaled to keep mean earnings unchanged. Horizontal axis: space a child requires, h_P, in rooms.

6 Counterfactuals

In this section, I use the calibrated model to study counterfactual changes to the 2023 economy and unpack the interaction between family space and fertility. First, I show that relaxing credit and expanding the housing supply raise births by the same amount on impact but have different effects over time, with housing supply having a stronger long-run effect. Second, I show that the main reason credit moves births earlier, but doesn't have as strong of a permanent effect, is because young households use it to buy the small homes they would otherwise rent. Intuitively, credit lowers the down payment, not the cost of the space a child needs. Third, I show that credit tied to children, which does lower that cost, raises the completed fertility of the 2023 cohort by 4.9%, and I compare these changes with a property tax.

6.1 Credit relaxation and housing supply

I compare two changes that intervene in the housing market. The first relaxes credit: the loan-to-value limit ϕ rises from 80% to 100%, so buyers no longer need a down payment. As Section 3.5 shows, credit raises the probability of trying for a child only if it is worth more to a household with the additional child than without it (3.13). Importantly, it can raise fertility when the down payment stands between a household and the home its family needs. The quantification is hence an important tool to assess whether there is a significant mass of agents that are giving up on having kids due to their inability of affording a 'family home' with many rooms. The second change expands the housing supply: the scale of the supply curve (3.9), $\bar{H}$, rises by 4.35%, so that at any price the stock is 4.35% larger. I choose this size so that births in 2023 rise by as much as under the credit policy. Credit lowers the down payment needed to buy a home. Supply lowers the cost of housing, both the price and rents. With the same effect on impact, the comparison shows which of the two costs matters for fertility.

Both experiments start from the 2023 state of the transition in Section 4.4. In 2023 the change is announced unexpectedly and understood to be permanent by agents. I compare each experiment with the path the economy follows from the same state without the change. The preference for children follows the same path with and without the change. Appendix H repeats the experiments with a more elastic supply and with a slowly adjusting stock.

I report births in the four-year periods starting in 2023 and 2063 and in the long run, when the economy reaches its new stationary equilibrium, and the completed fertility of the cohort aged 18 to 21 in 2023: the children ever born to these households over their lives. All are relative to the no-policy path. Table 4 summarizes the results; it also reports credit for parents, which Section 6.4 describes.

Table 4: Counterfactuals from 2023

	Births			Completed fertility	House price	
	2023	2063	Long run	2023 cohort	2023	Long run
Credit relaxation	+1.3	+0.6	+3.0	−1.1	−0.1	+3.2
Housing supply, +4.35%	+1.4	+3.0	+4.3	+2.0	−3.9	0.0
Credit for parents	+5.1	+16.6	+36.1	+4.9	+0.3	+33.5

Notes: % differences from the no-policy path from the same 2023 state. Births: births in the four-year period starting in the year shown; long run: the new stationary equilibrium, where births per household are at replacement, so births and the number of households rise by the same percentage. Completed fertility: children ever born to the cohort aged 18–21 in 2023. Without policy, period fertility is 1.63 in 2023 and 1.73 in 2063. Housing supply: the supply curve shifted out so that births in 2023 rise as much as with the credit relaxation.

6.2 Same impact, different long run

Figure 17 plots births and the number of households under the two changes. To understand the dynamics at play, it's helpful to look at the effects at different time horizons.

On impact, in 2023, the two changes look alike: both raise births by about 1.4%. Immediately after that, though, the path of the credit relaxation scenario displays the signs of a 'harvesting' effect: when the down payment disappears, many households act at once, and birth rates rise at every fertile age. But most of these households only bring forward children they would have had anyway.

In the medium run, over the four decades to 2063, the two paths separate. Under the credit policy, the impact gain is gone within four years, and in the following decade births fall below the no-policy path, by 0.6% at the bottom in 2035: the children born early are missing later. Births then recover, to about 1% above the no-policy path by 2055, as households that enter later gain more from credit while housing becomes cheaper. Under the supply policy, births keep rising, to 3.0% above the no-policy path by 2063. Two forces move births after impact: how many children each household has, and how many households are of childbearing age. A policy that raises births today raises the second about twenty years later, when the additional children reach adulthood, form households of their own and have children in turn: a demographic momentum (Keyfitz, 1971), or an 'echo' of the earlier births. Under the supply increase, birth rates stay higher for decades, since every cohort can buy cheaper housing, and from about 2040 the echo adds to them; by 2063 the two contribute about equally. Under the LTV policy, the births brought forward and the births missing later roughly cancel, so few additional households are born and the echo stays small. The cohort aged 18 to 21 in 2023 shows the difference (Table 5): in the supply increase scenario it has 2.0% more children over its life, and in the credit relaxation scenario 1.1% fewer.[25] Credit changes when households have children more than how many they have.[26]

After 2055, births with the credit relaxation fall back a second time, to 0.25% above the no-policy path in 2071, before the echo lifts them toward the long run. This second decline reflects how the effect of credit depends on the price of housing. When homes are very expensive, credit mainly lets young couples buy earlier and have their first child earlier; when homes are particularly cheap, it has a stronger effect in pushing towards larger houses; in the intermediate price range, which is particularly salient for cohorts in their thirties after 2055, neither channel is strong, and credit

[25]The 2023 cohort ends with *fewer* children than without the policy because of the age composition of the population it retires into. After the fast decline, each cohort that reaches working age is smaller than the one before, so the population gradually ages. In 2071, the age mix is at its worst: the original larger cohorts are all retired, and the workforce consists of the younger, smaller ones, with a particularly unfavorable demographic balance. Retirees per worker rise from 0.35 in 2023 to 0.47 in 2071. After that, the population keeps shrinking but grows younger again: fertility recovers toward replacement (from 1.63 in 2023 to 1.86 in 2087), each new cohort is only a little smaller than the last, and retirees per worker return to 0.35 in the long run. With a fixed payroll tax, the pay-as-you-go pension follows this age composition: it falls by a quarter by 2071 and then recovers. The 2023 cohort retires around 2071, at the lowest point, and with the credit relaxation its households enter that period having bought earlier and with more debt. Anticipating this, they have fewer children. With the pension held at its 2023 level, the same relaxation raises this cohort's completed fertility by 0.6%. Later cohorts gain because house prices keep falling while they raise children: with the price held at its 2023 level, every cohort has fewer children. See Appendix I.1 for more detail.

[26]Demographers call these the *tempo* and the *quantum* of fertility. When households bring births forward, period fertility can rise immediately and decline later, even if the number of children of each cohort remains unchanged. Bongaarts and Feeney (1998) accordingly split the period total fertility rate into a quantum component, "the TFR that would have been observed in the absence of changes in the timing of childbearing," and a tempo component, "the distortion that occurs due to timing changes." Kearney and Levine (2026) use the same distinction to argue that the recent fall in fertility in high-income countries has to be read from the completed fertility of cohorts, which is the measure I use here.

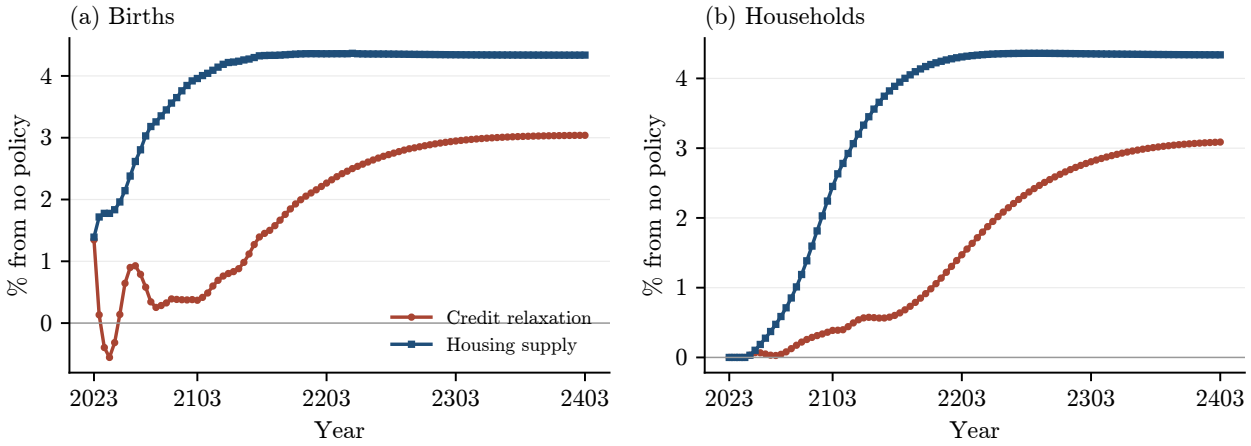


Figure 17: Credit relaxation and housing supply

Notes: % differences from the no-policy path from the same 2023 state, births in each four-year period (panel a) and the number of households (panel b), to the new stationary equilibrium. Credit relaxation: LTV 80 to 100 for all households. Housing supply: the supply curve shifted out by 4.35%.

mostly turns childless renters into owners of mid-sized homes who end up with about as many children (Appendix I.1).

In the long run, the supply expansion raises the number of households, and births with it, by 4.3% at an unchanged price. The credit relaxation raises them by 3.1%, with a price 3.2% higher.[27]

The two paths help us understand an important concern when thinking about fertility policy. Births brought forward are missing later, so a policy that mostly moves timing adds few births over time. A policy that makes children cheaper at a given price adds births in every cohort, and the echo of those births compounds them: by 2063, births are 3.0% higher with the supply expansion and 0.6% higher with the credit relaxation.

Table 5: The cohort aged 18–21 in 2023

	Completed fertility	Share with a first birth	Mean age at first birth
No policy	1.640	0.673	27.15
Credit relaxation	1.622 (−1.1%)	0.665 (−1.3%)	27.07
Housing supply	1.673 (+2.0%)	0.684 (+1.6%)	27.05
Credit for parents	1.720 (+4.9%)	0.701 (+4.1%)	26.88

Notes: Children ever born and the share with a first birth, per household of the cohort, summed over ages 18 to 45. Mean age at first birth: first-birth rates weighted by the midpoints of the four-year age cells.

[27] In the long run births per household are at replacement, so births and households move together. The long-run effect of credit comes from a small rise in fertility at a given price, which is larger at the low long-run price, 45% below its 2023 level. Letting renters rent homes as large as 10 rooms removes about half of it.

6.3 Unpacking the credit policy

Why does credit move births earlier rather than raise their number? Intuitively, this policy lowers the equity needed to buy a home, $(1-\phi)P_t h^O$, but not the per-period cost of the space a child needs. Rent equals the user cost of owning (3.10), so a family can rent that space at about the per-period cost of owning it. By (3.13), credit raises the probability of trying for a child only if it is worth more to a household with the additional child than without it. To understand this better, I look in more detail at the response to the LTV relaxation policy.

Figure 18 shows where young households live in 2023. The credit relaxation turns a fifth of households aged 18 to 29 from renters into owners, and almost all of them buy small dwellings: the share owning a home of 2 rooms rises from 8% to 24%, and of 4 rooms from 13% to 17%, while the shares owning 6 rooms or more barely move. The supply expansion leaves the housing of this age group almost unchanged.

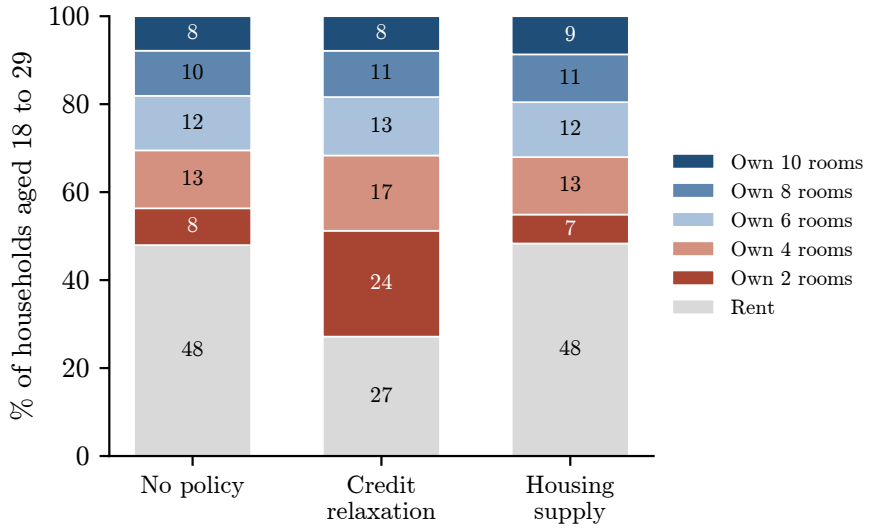


Figure 18: What young households live in, 2023

Notes: Households aged 18–29 in 2023, after the tenure choice, renting or owning a home of 2 to 10 rooms, %. Each experiment starts from the same 2023 state as the no-policy path.

Figure 19 follows the cohort aged 18 to 21 in 2031 through its life. With the credit relaxation, the share owning a home of 2 or 4 rooms roughly doubles in its late twenties and stays well above the no-policy path into its forties (panel a), while the share owning a home of 6 rooms or more is about the same (panel b). Births come slightly earlier, and the cohort ends with slightly fewer children, 0.4% (panel c). The supply expansion instead raises the share in larger homes and births at every age, and the cohort has 1.8% more children. These results illustrate that the mechanism proposed in Section 3.5 does not seem to hold. Households do not use the newly found credit abundance to purchase big houses and have kids, but rather switch from rental to ownership of similar sized dwelling and, if anything, this discourages births,[28] as it makes it more likely these families do not

[28]The PSID offers a descriptive check of this: among childless first-time buyers aged 22 to 33, those who bought

want to expand over the limits of their bought house.[29]

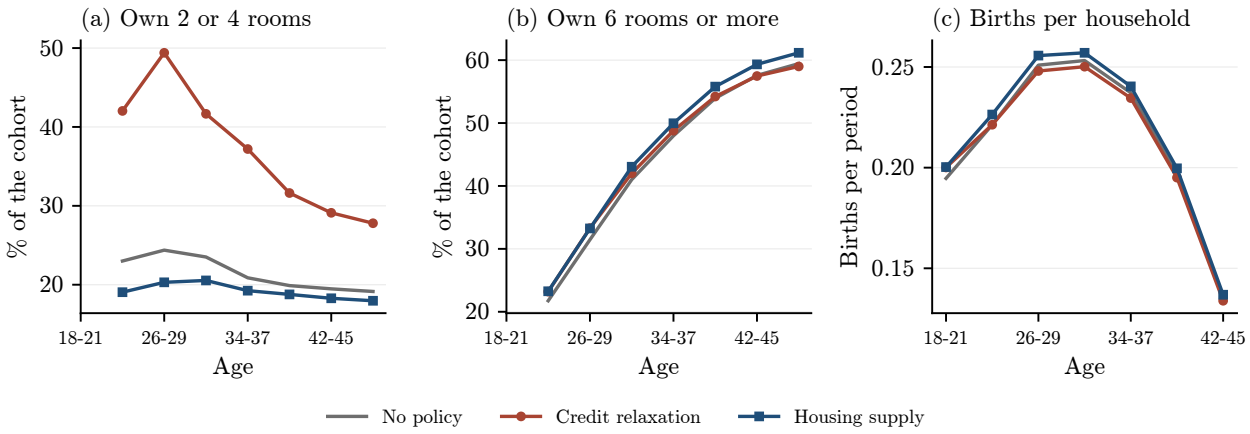


Figure 19: The cohort aged 18–21 in 2031: housing and births by age

Notes: Share of the cohort owning a home of 2 or 4 rooms (panel a) and of 6 rooms or more (panel b) at the start of each four-year age group, and births per household in each age group (panel c). Each experiment starts from the same 2023 state as the no-policy path.

Perhaps surprisingly, the modest effect of the credit relaxation does not seem to be due to a general-equilibrium feedback through higher house prices. When I hold prices, rents and transfers at their no-policy paths (Appendix I.1), the credit relaxation raises births in 2023 by about as much as in equilibrium, 1.4%, and the cohort aged 18 to 21 in 2023 still ends with fewer children.

6.4 Credit for parents

The previous sections seem to suggest that a housing policy aimed at increasing fertility should be one that shifts the relative value of parenthood. To see this, I study a very similar credit relaxation, but targeted to parents. I raise the loan-to-value ratio to 1 only for households with a child at home. While giving the same monetary benefit, the policy has the important difference of explicitly encouraging births. As a result, births in 2023 rise by 5.1%, several times as much as relaxing credit for all households, at nearly the same price, 0.3% higher. The completed fertility of the 2023 cohort rises by 4.9%, and the share with a first birth by 4.1% (Table 5). Births keep rising, by 17% by 2063 (Figure 20). As the larger cohorts demand more space, the price rises, by 3.5% by 2063 and 33% in the long run, when there are 36% more households. The significantly different results are due to the new value of having a child. A birth now unlocks ownership without a down payment, so in 2023 childless renters aged 22 to 29 try for a first child 13 to 16% more often.

a home of four rooms or fewer were 14 percentage points less likely to have a first birth within six years (standard error 6.7; Appendix I.3).

[29]This is in line with what Kaplan et al. (2020) find for the credit relaxation of the US housing boom. In their model, renters who become owners when credit is relaxed "buy houses similar in size to the ones they were previously renting," so that "the age profile of homeownership shifts to the left—households who would have become owners in the future buy houses today . . . —but the life-cycle profile of consumption of housing services remains virtually unchanged."

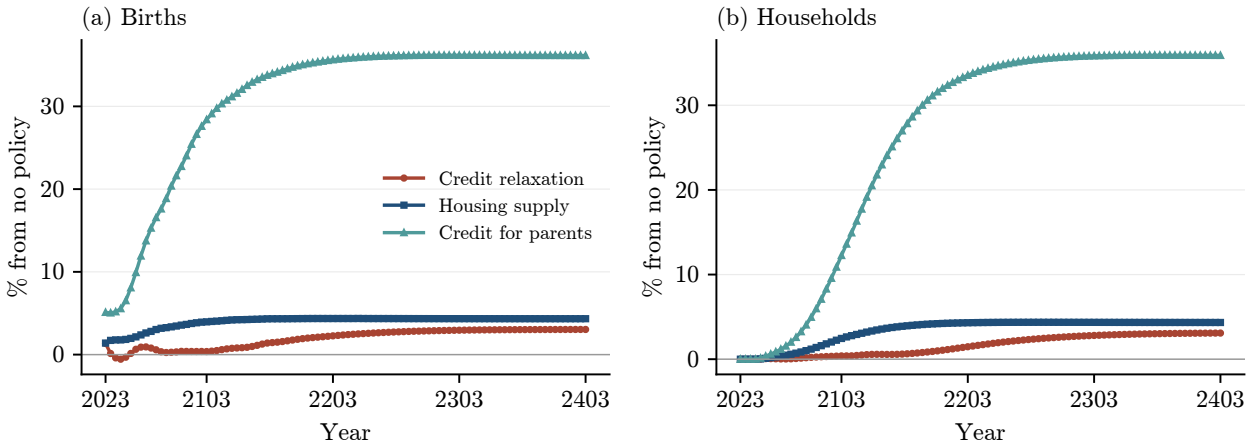


Figure 20: Credit relaxation, housing supply and credit for parents

Notes: % differences from the no-policy path from the same 2023 state, births in each four-year period (panel a) and the number of households (panel b), to the new stationary equilibrium. Credit for parents: LTV 100 for households with a child at home.

Once they have children, households use the credit: renter-parents aged 22 to 25 buy a home with probability 0.63 instead of 0.57.

6.5 Increasing property taxes

Coven et al. (2026) show that a higher property tax is capitalized into a lower house price, which lowers the down payment and makes it easier for young households to buy. This makes an increase in property taxes a natural candidate for a pro-natality policy in our context. To see whether this channel matters for fertility, I raise the annual property tax from 1.06% to 2% of value from 2023 on, and return the revenue to households as an equal transfer every period.

The channel is there: the tax lowers the price by 7.0% in 2023, and ownership at ages 18 to 29 rises by 2.9 percentage points. But a lower price does not, in this case, mean really cheaper housing. The price falls because whoever holds a home now pays more tax every year, and rental companies pass the tax on to renters: per four-year period, the cost of holding a room rises from 18.0% to 22.1% of its price in 2023, so even at the lower price a room costs more per year, and rents rise by 14.5% (Appendix I.4). Buying gets easier, but the extra room for kids is actually more expensive. As with the credit relaxation, easier access to ownership is not what keeps families out of the space they need (Section 6.3), so births barely move on impact (+0.1%). Over the following decades births do rise, and by more than with the credit relaxation (2.3% against 0.6% in 2063, Figure 21), but the gain remains modest in the long run, 2.2%. The rise seems to be mostly attributable to the rebate. Because it is the same for every household, it moves resources from households in large homes, mostly high earners, to those in small homes, mostly low and middle earners, and the additional births come from the latter.[30]

[30]When the additional revenue is instead returned in proportion to the rooms held by households of each age and

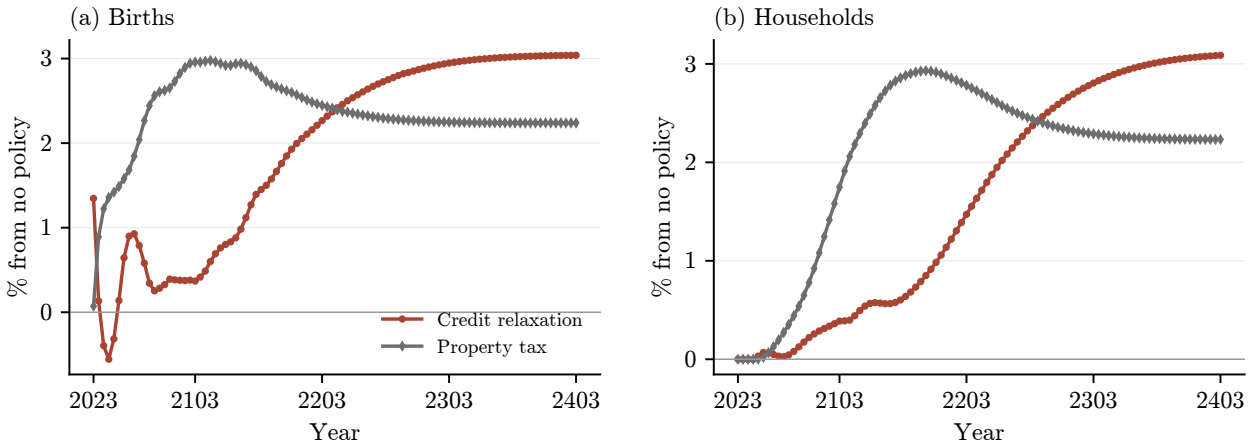


Figure 21: Increasing property taxes

Notes: % differences from the no-policy path from the same 2023 state, births in each four-year period (panel a) and the number of households (panel b), to the new stationary equilibrium. Property tax: from 1.06% to 2% of value a year from 2023 on, revenue returned equally to all households every period. Credit relaxation: LTV 80 to 100 for all households.

The comparison with Coven et al. (2026) is not one to one, but the model confirms the channel they emphasize can have a modest effect on fertility: the tax lowers prices, more young households own, and fertility does go up.[31] However, the model suggests that a higher property tax raises fertility only if its revenue is returned in a way that favors the households about to have children, since the tax itself makes the space a child needs more expensive every year.

7 Conclusion

The decline in fertility has drawn widespread attention from the media, policymakers and academics, and many governments look to housing policy to raise births. Understanding the effects of these policies, and how childbearing and homeownership interact, is increasingly important. I study both in a life-cycle model in which households choose whether to have children, whether to rent or own, and how much to save, subject to earnings risk and a down payment constraint. In the model, children raise a household's needs for both consumption and space. This cost weighs most on young households with few resources, and it interacts with earnings risk.

The model shows the need to distinguish short-run effects, which may only reflect changes in timing, from longer-run effects. Specifically, letting all buyers borrow the full price of a home raises births

earnings level, so that it no longer redistributes across earnings, the same tax lowers births by 3.3% in the final steady state even though the house price falls more. Without the redistribution, the higher cost dominates.

[31] In their model the tax falls only on owner-occupied housing: rentals are a separate market with their own supply, so the tax lowers the price young buyers pay without raising rents. Here instead it applies to rentals too, through the user cost being passed through by rental companies. Their setting is also spatially focused on Texas vs California rather than the whole United States. Older owners face a payment-to-income limit, capital gains taxes and the step-up of basis at death, which keep them in large homes, and residents value the rebated revenue at less than its cost.

by 1.3% in 2023, but young households mostly use the credit to own earlier, in relatively small homes, and the cohort aged 18 to 21 in 2023 ends up with no more children. Expanding the housing supply by enough to have the same effect in 2023 lowers housing costs by more, and births are 3.0% higher by 2063. Credit restricted to parents raises the completed fertility of the same cohort by 4.9%.

These results matter for the design of housing policy as fertility declines. As the population starts to shrink, falling house prices are a natural stimulus to fertility. In demography, however, effects compound, so a policy can matter a great deal even if it only speeds up the recovery. The idea that house prices alone could reverse the decline in fertility is stark, but most of the results of this paper would also apply to a slowdown of the decline, even one that never brings fertility back to replacement.

References

Laurence M. Ball. Optimal population growth in the Diamond OLG model. Working Paper 35823, National Bureau of Economic Research, 2026.

Nathaniel Baum-Snow and Lu Han. The Microgeography of Housing Supply. *Journal of Political Economy*, 132(6):1897–1946, June 2024. ISSN 0022-3808, 1537-534X. doi: 10.1086/728110.

Corina Boar, Denis Gorea, and Virgiliu Midrigan. Liquidity constraints in the U.S. housing market. *The Review of Economic Studies*, 89(3):1120–1154, 2022. doi: 10.1093/restud/rdab063.

Boletín Oficial del Estado. Línea de avales para la adquisición de primera vivienda por jóvenes y familias con menores a cargo. BOE no. 111, May 7, 2024, 2024.

John Bongaarts and Griffith Feeney. On the quantum and tempo of fertility. *Population and Development Review*, 24(2):271–291, 1998.

Andrew E. Clark and Anthony Lepinteur. A natural experiment on job insecurity and fertility in france. *The Review of Economics and Statistics*, 104(2):386–398, 2022. doi: 10.1162/rest_a_00964.

Diane Coffey, Michael Geruso, Dean Spears, and Sangita Vyas. Does fertility stabilize at low levels? Evidence from period, cohort, and subnational data. Working Paper 35824, National Bureau of Economic Research, 2026.

CONSAP. Fondo di garanzia per la prima casa. https://www.consap.it/fondo-prima-casa/, 2026.

Benjamin K. Couillard. Build, baby, build: How housing shapes fertility. Job Market Paper, University of Toronto, 2025.

Joshua Coven, Sebastian Golder, Arpit Gupta, and Abdoulaye Ndiaye. Property taxes and housing allocation under financial constraints. Working Paper 35587, National Bureau of Economic Research, August 2026.

Fergus Cumming and Lisa Dettling. Monetary Policy and Birth Rates: The Effect of Mortgage Rate Pass-Through on Fertility. *Review of Economic Studies*, 91(1):229–258, January 2024. ISSN 0034-6527, 1467-937X. doi: 10.1093/restud/rdad034.

David de la Croix and Aude Pommeret. Childbearing postponement, its option value, and the biological clock. *Journal of Economic Theory*, 193:105231, 2021. doi: 10.1016/j.jet.2021.105231.

Mariacristina De Nardi. Wealth inequality and intergenerational links. *Review of Economic Studies*, 71(3):743–768, 2004.

Emilia Del Bono, Andrea Weber, and Rudolf Winter-Ebmer. Clash of career and family: Fertility decisions after job displacement. *Journal of the European Economic Association*, 10(4):659–683, 2012.

Lisa J. Dettling and Melissa S. Kearney. House prices and birth rates: The impact of the real estate market on the decision to have a baby. *Journal of Public Economics*, 110:82–100, February 2014. ISSN 00472727. doi: 10.1016/j.jpubeco.2013.09.009.

Lisa J. Dettling and Melissa Schettini Kearney. Can housing policy raise birth rates? Lessons from federal mortgage programs during the baby boom. Working Paper 33446, National Bureau of Economic Research, 2026. Revised September 2026.

Matthias Doepke and Fabian Kindermann. Bargaining over Babies: Theory, Evidence, and Policy Implications. *American Economic Review*, 109(9):3264–3306, September 2019. ISSN 0002-8282. doi: 10.1257/aer.20160328.

Matthias Doepke, Anne Hannusch, Fabian Kindermann, and Michèle Tertilt. The economics of fertility: A new era. In *Handbook of the Economics of the Family*, volume 1, pages 151–254. Elsevier, 2023. ISBN 978-0-323-89965-9. doi: 10.1016/bs.hefam.2023.01.003.

Mette Ejrnæs and Thomas H. Jørgensen. Family planning in a life-cycle model with income risk. *Journal of Applied Econometrics*, 35(5):567–586, 2020. doi: 10.1002/jae.2766.

Raquel Fernández, Inés Berniell, and Milagros Onofri. Falling fertility: The changing value of freedom, fulfillment, and family. Working Paper 35651, National Bureau of Economic Research, August 2026.

Jesús Fernández-Villaverde and Patrick Norrick. Terra incognita: The economics of a shrinking world. Working Paper 35809, National Bureau of Economic Research, September 2026.

Jonas D. M. Fisher and Martin Gervais. Why has home ownership fallen among the young? *International Economic Review*, 52(3):883–912, 2011. doi: 10.1111/j.1468-2354.2011.00653.x.

Clive D. Fraser. Income risk, the tax-benefit system and the demand for children. *Economica*, 68 (269):105–126, 2001. doi: 10.1111/1468-0335.00236.

Edward L. Glaeser and Joseph Gyourko. Urban decline and durable housing. *Journal of Political Economy*, 113(2):345–375, 2005. doi: 10.1086/427465.

Edward L. Glaeser and Joseph Gyourko. The economic implications of housing supply. *Journal of Economic Perspectives*, 32(1):3–30, 2018. doi: 10.1257/jep.32.1.3.

Mikhail Golosov, Larry E. Jones, and Michèle Tertilt. Efficiency with endogenous population growth. *Econometrica*, 75(4):1039–1071, 2007. doi: 10.1111/j.1468-0262.2007.00781.x.

Andrew Goodman-Bacon. Difference-in-differences with variation in treatment timing. *Journal of Econometrics*, 225(2):254–277, 2021.

Government of Hungary. 518/2023. (XI. 30.) Korm. rendelet a családok otthonteremtését támogató kedvezményes CSOK Plusz hitelprogramról. Government decree on the CSOK Plusz loan programme, 2023.

Brian Greaney, Andrii Parkhomenko, and Stijn Van Nieuwerburgh. Dynamic Urban Economics. *NBER Working Paper*, 2025.

Daniel L. Greenwald and Adam M. Guren. Do credit conditions move house prices? *American Economic Review*, 115(10):3559–3596, 2025. doi: 10.1257/aer.20211715.

Isaac Hacamo. The babies of mortgage market deregulation. *Review of Financial Studies*, 34(2): 907–948, 2021. doi: 10.1093/rfs/hhaa073.

Jonathan Halket and Satyajit Vasudev. Saving up or settling down: Home ownership over the life cycle. *Review of Economic Dynamics*, 17(2):345–366, 2014.

Harris for President. Vice president harris lays out agenda to lower costs for american families. Campaign press release, August 2024. August 16, 2024.

Hellenic Republic. Spiti mou II programme. https://stegasi.gov.gr/programs/spiti-mou-ii/, 2026.

Larry E. Jones, Alice Schoonbroodt, and Michèle Tertilt. Fertility theories: Can they explain the negative fertility-income relationship? In John B. Shoven, editor, *Demography and the Economy*, pages 43–100. University of Chicago Press, 2010.

Greg Kaplan, Kurt Mitman, and Giovanni L. Violante. The housing boom and bust: Model meets evidence. *Journal of Political Economy*, 128(9):3285–3345, 2020. doi: 10.1086/708816.

Melissa S. Kearney, Phillip B. Levine, and Luke Pardue. The Puzzle of Falling US Birth Rates since the Great Recession. *Journal of Economic Perspectives*, 36(1):151–176, February 2022. ISSN 0895-3309. doi: 10.1257/jep.36.1.151.

Melissa Schettini Kearney and Phillip B. Levine. Why is fertility so low in high-income countries? *Journal of Economic Literature*, 64(3):907–949, 2026. doi: 10.1257/jel.20261786.

Nathan Keyfitz. On the momentum of population growth. *Demography*, 8(1):71–80, 1971. doi: 10.2307/2060339.

KfW. Wohneigentum für familien – neubau (300), merkblatt. https://www.kfw.de/inlandsfoerderung/Privatpersonen/Neubau/F%C3%B6rderprodukte/Wohneigentum-f%C3%BCr-Familien-(300)/, 2025. Version 12/2025.

Natalia Khorunzhina and Robert A. Miller. American dream delayed: Shifting determinants of homeownership. *International Economic Review*, 63(1):3–35, 2022. doi: 10.1111/iere.12557.

Seongeun Kim, Michèle Tertilt, and Minchul Yum. Status Externalities in Education and Low Birth Rates in Korea. *American Economic Review*, 114(6):1576–1611, June 2024. ISSN 0002-8282, 1944-7981. doi: 10.1257/aer.20220583.

Henrik Kleven, Camille Landais, and Gabriel Leite-Mariante. The child penalty atlas. *Review of Economic Studies*, 92(5):3174–3207, 2025.

Henri Leridon. Can assisted reproduction technology compensate for the natural decline in fertility with age? A model assessment. *Human Reproduction*, 19(7):1548–1553, 2004.

Michael F. Lovenheim and Kevin J. Mumford. Do Family Wealth Shocks Affect Fertility Choices? Evidence from the Housing Market. *The Review of Economics and Statistics*, 95(2):464–475, May 2013. ISSN 0034-6535. doi: 10.1162/REST_a_00266.

Ministry of Land, Infrastructure and Transport. [From 2024, home purchase loans of up to 500 million won for households with a newborn]. https://www.korea.kr/briefing/pressReleaseView.do?newsId=156607815, 2023. Press release in Korean, December 27, 2023.

Ministry of National Development. Priority schemes for HDB BTO flat buyers. https://www.mynicehome.gov.sg/get-started/hdb-priority-schemes-guide/, 2026.

Kanato Nakakuni. Fertility under income uncertainty: The role of education subsidies. Author manuscript, July 2026, 2026.

NewsNation. JD Vance: Housing costs are biggest threat to the American dream. https://digital-release.newsnationnow.com/?p=3101836, 2024. October 25, 2024.

Gonzalo Paz-Pardo. Homeownership and portfolio choice over the generations. *American Economic Journal: Macroeconomics*, 16(1):207–237, 2024. doi: 10.1257/mac.20200473.

John Karl Scholz, Ananth Seshadri, and Surachai Khitatrakun. Are americans saving "optimally" for retirement? *Journal of Political Economy*, 114(4):607–643, 2006.

Sejm of the Republic of Poland. Act of 1 october 2021 on family home loans, consolidated text. Dz.U. 2024 poz. 1724, consolidated text, 2024.

Curtis J. Simon and Robert Tamura. Do higher rents discourage fertility? evidence from U.S. cities, 1940–2000. *Regional Science and Urban Economics*, 39(1):33–42, 2009. doi: 10.1016/j.regsciurbeco.2008.08.002.

Kamila Sommer. Fertility choice in a life cycle model with idiosyncratic uninsurable earnings risk. *Journal of Monetary Economics*, 83:27–38, October 2016. ISSN 03043932. doi: 10.1016/j.jmoneco.2016.08.002.

Sara Ström. Housing and first births in Sweden, 1972–2005. *Housing Studies*, 25(4):509–526, 2010. doi: 10.1080/02673031003711519.

Liyang Sun and Sarah Abraham. Estimating dynamic treatment effects in event studies with heterogeneous treatment effects. *Journal of Econometrics*, 225(2):175–199, 2021. doi: 10.1016/j.jeconom.2020.09.006.

United Nations Population Fund. State of world population 2025: The real fertility crisis. Technical report, UNFPA, June 2025. URL https://www.unfpa.org/swp2025.

U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics. Consumer expenditures in 2024. News release, U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, 2025. URL https://www.bls.gov/news.release/cesan.nr0.htm.

Bernardus van Doornik, Dimas Fazio, Tarun Ramadorai, and Janis Skrastins. Housing and fertility. CEPR Discussion Paper 19805, Centre for Economic Policy Research, 2024.

World Bank. World development indicators: Fertility rate, total (births per woman), SP.DYN.TFRT.IN. https://data.worldbank.org/indicator/SP.DYN.TFRT.IN, 2026. Accessed July 2026.

A Housing Around the First Birth: Data and Additional Results

A.1 Sample, measures and estimation

Sample. I use the PSID family and individual files for 1968–2023. An observation is a person-year in which the person is a current member of a family unit and at least 18 years old. The year of first birth is the earliest birth year of a biological child in the person's relationship-to-child history, which records up to twenty children. The comparison group is adults whose full history shows no children. I drop people whose history is incomplete or unknown, and parents whose first birth comes before I first observe them as adults. All estimates use the PSID longitudinal individual weight and so include only sample persons with a positive weight.

The PSID records the rooms and tenure of the home a person lives in. These describe the person's own housing only if the person is the reference person or the spouse, and not, for example, an adult child living with the parents.[32] I use two samples. The main sample keeps parents who were reference person or spouse two to three years before the first birth and follows them in every later year. The controls are all childless adults. This sample leaves out parents who set up their own household only at the birth. The second sample keeps women who are the reference person or spouse in each year.[33] Since many young adults set up their own household around the time of their first child, this sample changes around the birth.

Rooms and ownership rise after the first birth in both samples. The increase is larger in the main sample, and only the second sample displays a rise in rooms before the birth, consistent with women entering it as they form their own household. Both samples use the same weights and entry rule. Appendix A.2 compares the two samples in detail. Table 6 reports summary statistics for both samples.

For the calibration, I align the PSID sample with the model. I drop parents whose first birth comes at an age at which the model has no births, and years outside the model's life cycle. This changes the estimate very little. Rooms rise by 1.44 (0.05) three to four years after the birth, against 1.47 (0.05) in the full sample, with 3,131 instead of 3,302 parents. I report all other results on the full sample.

Housing measures. I consider four housing outcomes: rooms (the number of rooms in the dwelling, excluding bathrooms), ownership (whether the family owns its home), moving (whether the family moved since the previous interview), and the main reason for moving (more space or a

[32] A third option is to keep all adults, whatever their position in the household. But for an adult who still lives with the parents, the PSID records the parents' home, and the change in rooms at the birth would then partly reflect moving out.

[33] In the PSID, a family unit is the reference person, a spouse or partner, and the relatives living with them. Sometimes two family units share a home, for example when a grown child has split off into a separate PSID family but still lives with the parents. In the women sample I keep only homes with one family unit, so rooms and tenure are those of the woman's own family. I also keep one woman per household and year.

Table 6: Summary Statistics, First-Birth Samples (PSID)

	Main sample			Women sample		
	Parents	Childless	Childless, ages 20–35	Parents	Childless	Childless, ages 20–34
Age	26.5	38.8	26.8	26.1	45.8	27.7
Woman	0.50	0.47	0.43	1.00	1.00	1.00
Married or cohabiting	0.61	0.30	0.20	0.66	0.40	0.36
Years of education	13.9	13.3	13.6	14.2	13.7	14.3
Family income (thousands, 2022 $)	95.5	93.5	91.8	92.7	83.7	75.8
Rooms	4.69	5.14	4.82	4.70	4.83	4.09
Owner	0.43	0.61	0.48	0.41	0.59	0.30
Persons	3,302	6,008	5,445	3,655	1,654	1,376
Person-years	60,253	57,600	31,322	46,799	16,539	6,748

Note: This table reports means weighted by the PSID longitudinal individual weight for the samples of Table 8. Parents are measured two to three years before the first birth, and childless adults in all their years in the sample. The third column of each sample keeps childless adults at the ages of the parents (the 5th to 95th percentile of the parents' age). Married or cohabiting is one when the person is the reference person or spouse and the reference person is married or cohabiting. Family income is total family income in the previous year; it is not reported in 1994 and 1995. Persons and person-years cover all years in the sample.

better neighborhood, among movers). All four come from the PSID family files and refer to the year of the interview.[34]

Estimator. Event time is the survey year minus the year of the first birth, grouped into two-year windows, with the earliest and latest years pooled. I use two-year windows because the PSID became biennial after 1997, so a single reference year would be observed for only some birth cohorts. The reference window is two to three years before the birth, and I drop cohorts never observed in it (first births in 1968–1970 and 1985–1986 in the women sample, none in the main sample). Following Sun and Abraham (2021), I estimate an event path for each birth cohort relative to childless adults and average the paths with cohort-share weights. The regressions include person and survey-year fixed effects and indicators for age and years of education. Standard errors are clustered by person and account for the estimation of the cohort shares.

Robustness. Table 7 reports alternative estimates of the room response for the main sample. Each column changes one element of the baseline in column (1).

Columns (2) to (4) move the reference window. In column (2), the reference window is one to two years before the birth, and I report the change two to three years after it. Rooms rise by 1.12.

[34]Rooms answer the question "How many rooms do you have (for your family) not counting bathrooms?" Room codes that do not denote a count (9 through 1984, 99 in 1985–1993, 98 and 99 from 1994) are set to missing, and a reported zero is kept. Ownership is zero for renters and missing for other arrangements. The moving question refers to the spring of the previous survey year in the annual waves and to January 1 of the previous survey year in the biennial waves, so it covers about one year in the annual waves and two years in the biennial waves. For the main reason for moving, *more space* is the PSID category "expansion of housing: more space, more rent, better place", and *neighborhood* is the category for a better neighborhood, schools, and being closer to friends or relatives. Code 9 of the reason item, unknown before 2019 and homelessness in 2019, is set to missing.

The estimate is smaller because part of the increase in rooms happens in the year before the birth, which now falls in the reference window. In columns (3) and (4), the reference window is four to five and six to seven years before the birth. Rooms rise by 1.47 and 1.35 three to four years after the birth, close to the baseline, because rooms change little in the years before the reference window of the baseline.

Column (5) changes the comparison group. Instead of childless adults, the parents with the latest first birth in the sample serve as the comparison cohort in the estimator of Sun and Abraham (2021); childless adults remain in the sample. Rooms rise by 1.46.

Table 7: Rooms Around the First Birth: Alternative Specifications (PSID)

	(1) Baseline	(2) Reference $-2/-1$	(3) Reference $-5/-4$	(4) Reference $-7/-6$	(5) Latest cohort as controls
Change in rooms	1.47^{***}	1.12^{***}	1.47^{***}	1.35^{***}	1.46^{***}
	(0.05)	(0.04)	(0.06)	(0.07)	(0.05)
Reference window	$-3/-2$	$-2/-1$	$-5/-4$	$-7/-6$	$-3/-2$
Reported window	$+3/+4$	$+2/+3$	$+3/+4$	$+3/+4$	$+3/+4$
Reference-window mean rooms	4.69	4.87	4.81	5.06	4.69
Observations					
N	117,853	117,853	116,224	114,460	117,853
N individuals	9,310	9,310	9,263	9,205	9,310
N first-time parents	3,302	3,302	3,255	3,197	3,275

Standard errors in parentheses. $^{+}$ $p < 0.10$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$.

Note: This table reports alternative estimates of the change in rooms around the first birth for the sample of the main text: adults, women and men, who were reference person or spouse two to three years before the birth. Column (1) is the baseline of Table 8, column (1). Each other column changes one element. Columns (2) to (4) move the reference window, holding the sample fixed. Column (5) uses the latest first-birth cohort as the comparison group and keeps never-parents in the sample. "Reference window" is the omitted window and "Reported window" the reported one, both in years relative to the first birth.

A.2 Sample comparisons

Tables 8 and 9 and Figures 22 and 23 report the estimates for the two samples described in Appendix A. Fixing headship before the birth removes the pronounced pre-birth increase in rooms visible when the sample is reselected in each interview. It also yields larger post-birth room and ownership responses.

Both partners of a couple can appear in the sample. Clustering standard errors by household instead of by person leaves the estimates unchanged and raises the standard errors by at most 2.4%.

Table 8: Rooms Around the First Birth (PSID)

	(1) Adults who were reference person or spouse two to three years before the birth	(2) Women who are reference person or spouse in each year
Years relative to first birth		
−8 or earlier	0.15^{+}	−0.50***
	(0.08)	(0.12)
−7 and −6	0.04	−0.50***
	(0.06)	(0.10)
−5 and −4	−0.03	−0.34***
	(0.04)	(0.06)
−3 and −2	reference window	
−1 and 0	0.61***	0.41***
	(0.04)	(0.05)
+1 and +2	1.19***	0.82***
	(0.04)	(0.06)
+3 and +4	1.47***	1.03***
	(0.05)	(0.07)
+5 and +6	1.62***	1.17***
	(0.06)	(0.08)
+7 and +8	1.64***	1.20***
	(0.07)	(0.09)
+9 and +10	1.83***	1.25***
	(0.08)	(0.10)
+11 or later	1.85***	1.16***
	(0.09)	(0.13)
Reference-window mean rooms	4.69	4.70
Observations		
N	117,853	63,338
N individuals	9,310	5,309
N first-time parents	3,302	3,655

Standard errors in parentheses. $^{+}$ $p < 0.10$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$.

Note: This table reports interaction-weighted event-study estimates (Sun and Abraham, 2021) of the change in rooms relative to years −3 and −2, in two-year windows of event time, with standard errors clustered by person. The comparison group consists of adults with no children in their full relationship history. All regressions include person and survey-year fixed effects and indicators for age and years of education, and use PSID longitudinal weights. Rooms are the total rooms in the dwelling reported at the interview. Column (2) excludes first births in 1968–1970 and 1985–1986, which have no observation in the reference window. N individuals counts first-time parents and childless controls.

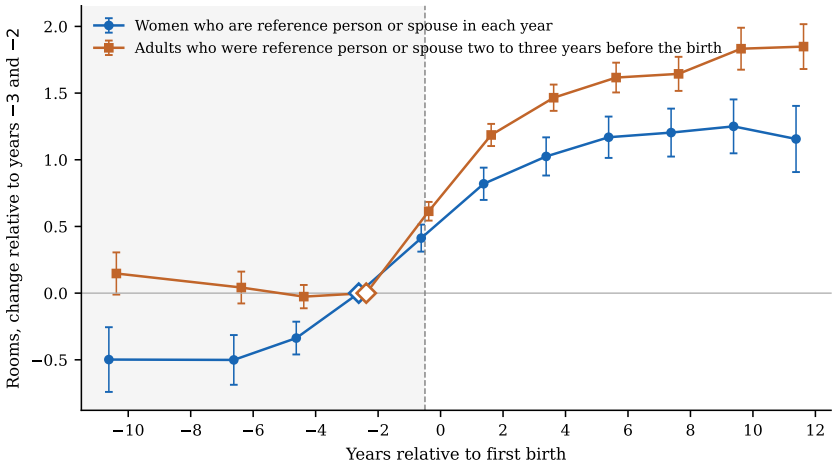
Table 9: Ownership and Moving Around the First Birth (PSID)

	(1) Owns the dwelling	(2) Moved since last interview	(3) Moved for more space	(4) Moved for neighborhood	(5) Share of moves for more space	(6) Share of moves for neighborhood
A. Adults who were reference person or spouse two to three years before the birth						
−1 and 0	0.16***	−0.07***	0.015*	−0.009*	0.050***	−0.022**
	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.006)	(0.004)	(0.013)	(0.009)
+1 and +2	0.25***	−0.17***	0.021***	−0.008*	0.114***	0.005
	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.006)	(0.004)	(0.017)	(0.011)
+3 and +4	0.27***	−0.21***	0.010	−0.009**	0.142***	−0.002
	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.006)	(0.004)	(0.020)	(0.013)
+5 and +6	0.26***	−0.21***	0.009	−0.003	0.147***	0.012
	(0.01)	(0.01)	(0.006)	(0.004)	(0.022)	(0.015)
Reference-window mean	0.43	0.54	0.064	0.030	0.123	0.058
N	111,272	118,875	116,697	116,697	27,462	27,462
N individuals	9,070	9,346	9,245	9,245	5,488	5,488
N first-time parents	3,142	3,323	3,255	3,255	2,184	2,184
B. Women who are reference person or spouse in each year						
−1 and 0	0.11***	−0.04**	0.014	−0.004	0.054**	−0.017
	(0.01)	(0.02)	(0.009)	(0.006)	(0.017)	(0.012)
+1 and +2	0.16***	−0.12***	0.034***	−0.005	0.140***	−0.011
	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.009)	(0.006)	(0.021)	(0.014)
+3 and +4	0.16***	−0.16***	0.020*	−0.010+	0.133***	−0.017
	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.010)	(0.005)	(0.023)	(0.014)
+5 and +6	0.14***	−0.16***	0.007	0.002	0.108***	0.022
	(0.02)	(0.02)	(0.010)	(0.006)	(0.026)	(0.018)
Reference-window mean	0.41	0.58	0.070	0.032	0.122	0.054
N	61,229	63,817	62,813	62,813	19,456	19,456
N individuals	5,238	5,315	5,282	5,282	4,327	4,327
N first-time parents	3,619	3,656	3,640	3,640	3,105	3,105

Standard errors in parentheses. $^{+}$ $p < 0.10$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$.

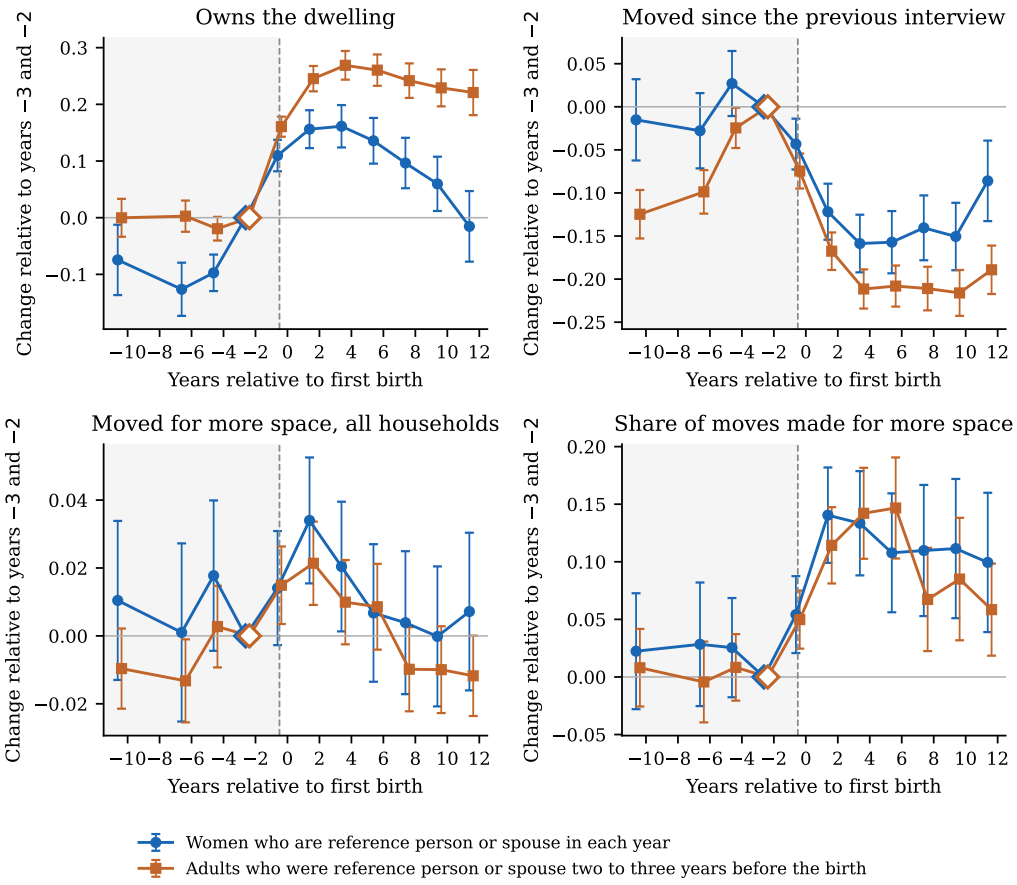
Note: This table reports the change in ownership and moving in windows of years relative to the first birth, relative to years −3 and −2, with the same estimator, comparison group, controls, weights and reference window as Table 8. The reference-window mean is the weighted mean among first-time parents in years −3 and −2. Each outcome uses its own sample of non-missing observations. "Moved for more space" equals one if the household moved since the previous interview and gave expansion of housing (more space, more rent, a better place) as the first reason, and zero otherwise; "moved for neighborhood" is defined in the same way for neighborhood-related reasons (a better neighborhood, going to school, being closer to friends or relatives). Columns (5) and (6) restrict the sample to household-years with a move and therefore condition on an outcome of the birth.

Figure 22: Rooms Around the First Birth, Two Samples (PSID)



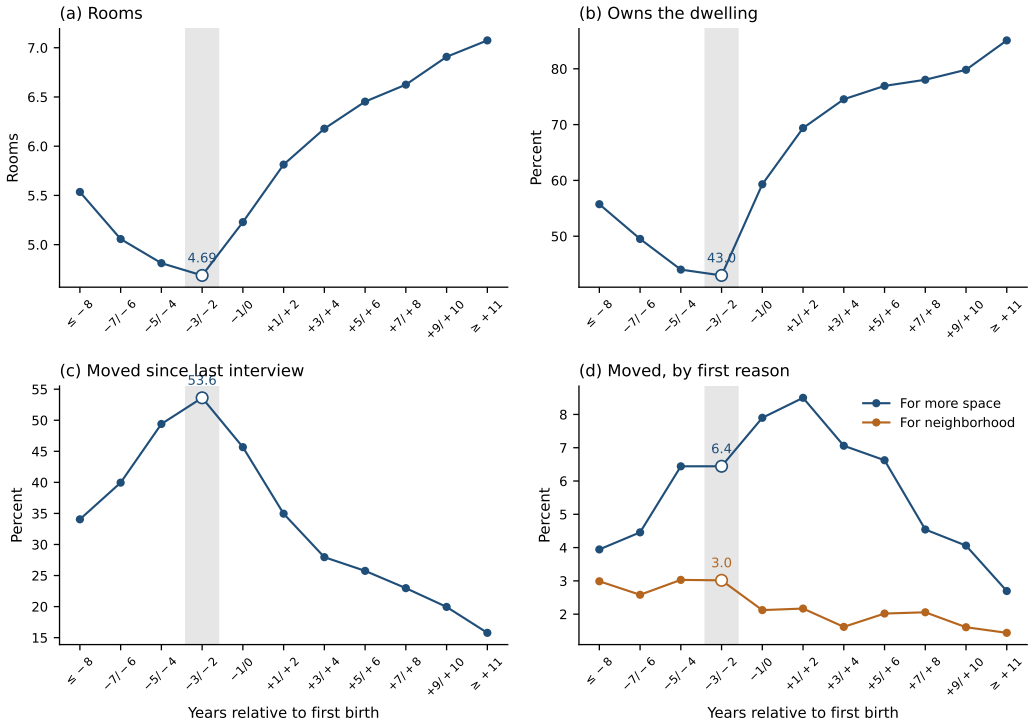
Note: This figure shows the change in rooms around the first birth for two samples: women selected as reference person or spouse in each interview, and treated adults selected as reference person or spouse before birth, with eligible childless controls. Both paths use the full sample for their definition and omit years −3 and −2.

Figure 23: Ownership and Moving Around the First Birth, Two Samples (PSID)



Note: This figure shows the change in ownership and moving for the two sample definitions of Figure 22, using available observations for each outcome. Reasons for moving in these panels are measured among all observed households, rather than only among movers.

Figure 24: Housing Outcomes by Years Relative to the First Birth (PSID)



Note: This figure shows the levels of the housing outcomes among first-time parents by two-year window of years relative to the first birth, weighted by the PSID longitudinal weight. The sample is the one of panel A of Table 9: adults, women and men, who were reference person or spouse two to three years before the birth. Each outcome uses its available observations. The hollow marker and the shaded band mark the reference window, years −3 and −2, and the label gives its level. Levels are raw means, without fixed effects or controls; before the reference window, these adults need not be reference person or spouse.

A.3 House value around the first birth

The rise in rooms could reflect a move to a cheaper location, where space costs less, rather than a larger expenditure on housing. To check this, I estimate equation (2.1) for the log of house value, the log of rooms and the log of house value per room among owners, and for a move across state lines among all households. House values are reported by the household and expressed in 2022 dollars. Table 10 reports the estimates three to four years after the birth. Among households that already owned in the reference window, house value rises by 30 percent and rooms by 18 percent, so value per room rises by 11 percent. The coefficients on value per room before the reference window are small and not significant. Moves across state lines become less frequent after the birth. Households therefore do not obtain space by moving to places where it is cheaper.

Table 10: House Value Around the First Birth (PSID)

	All owners			Owners in $-3/-2$			All households
	(1) Log house value	(2) Log rooms	(3) Log value per room	(4) Log house value	(5) Log rooms	(6) Log value per room	(7) Moved across state lines
Years +3 and +4	0.230^{***}	0.151^{***}	0.079^{***}	0.266^{***}	0.163^{***}	0.102^{***}	-0.025^{***}
	(0.022)	(0.011)	(0.020)	(0.024)	(0.012)	(0.021)	(0.006)
Reference-window mean	231.7	5.91	40.2	232.4	5.89	40.8	0.092
Observations							
N	70,538	70,538	70,538	47,282	47,282	47,282	120,847
N individuals	7,008	7,008	7,008	5,061	5,061	5,061	9,727
N first-time parents	3,099	3,099	3,099	1,152	1,152	1,152	3,596

Standard errors in parentheses. $^{+}$ $p < 0.10$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$.

Note: Estimates of β_k in equation (2.2) three to four years after the first birth, relative to two to three years before. The sample and estimator are those of Figure 1, on the full sample. Columns (1) to (6) include owners who report a positive house value and rooms. Columns (4) to (6) include only parents who owned their home at every interview two to three years before the birth. The reference-window mean is the mean among first-time parents in years -3 and -2. House value and value per room are in thousands of 2022 dollars. A move across state lines means the state differs from the one at the previous interview, one or two years earlier.

B Additional Evidence from the ACS and AHS

In this appendix I report evidence from the ACS and the AHS that complements the PSID event study of Section 2. Large homes are mostly owned, and most large owned homes are held by older households. A matched pseudo-panel and two sibling designs in the ACS give further estimates of how housing changes with children.

B.1 Large homes are owned

Figure 25 divides the 2023 housing stock in the American Housing Survey (AHS) by number of bedrooms and tenure. Of the homes with four or more bedrooms, 87% are owner-occupied and 9%

are rented. Of the homes with at most one bedroom, 13% are owner-occupied and 74% are rented. In rooms, the unit I use in the rest of the paper, 43% of owner-occupied homes have seven or more rooms, against 7.5% of rented homes. The same gap appears among families. Owners with children live in 6.8 rooms on average, and renters with children in 5.2. Of renter households with children, 48.7% live in homes with at most two bedrooms, against 7.4% of owner households with children. These shares describe the homes that households occupy, and they say nothing directly about the homes on offer. Still, in the existing stock a family that wants a large home usually has to buy one.

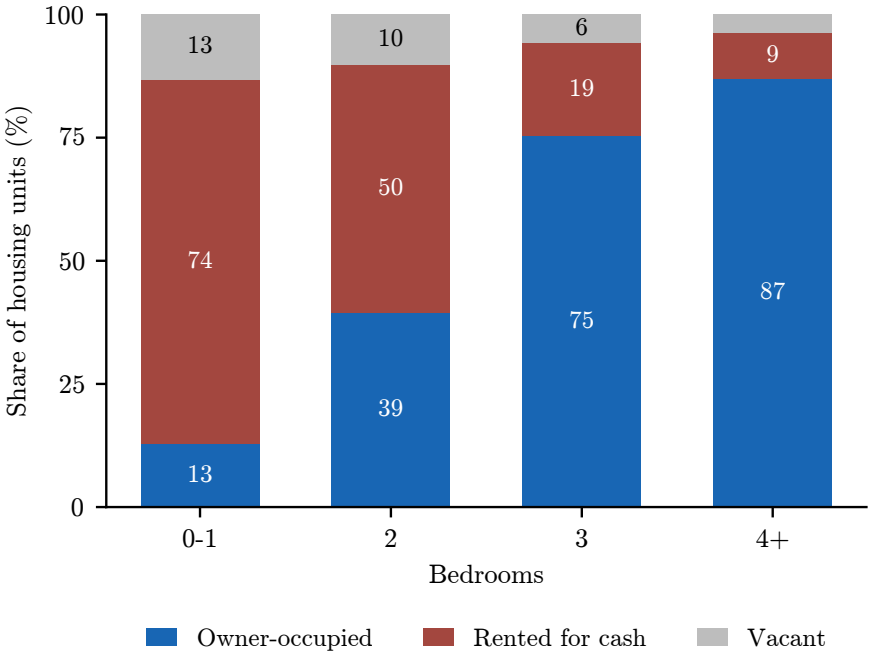


Figure 25: Tenure of the housing stock by number of bedrooms, AHS 2023

Notes: Each bar divides the housing units with the stated number of bedrooms into owner-occupied units, units rented for cash and vacant units, in %. Units occupied without payment of cash rent and units whose occupants have a usual residence elsewhere are excluded. Weighted by the housing-unit weight. Source: American Housing Survey 2023, national public-use file.

B.2 Older households hold the large homes

Figure 26 divides the owner-occupied homes with six or more rooms in 42 large metropolitan areas in the 2023 American Community Survey (ACS) by the age of the householder and by whether a child of the householder younger than 18 lives in the home. Households aged 60 to 85 without children at home hold 40.0% of these homes, and households aged 40 to 59 without children another 21.8%. Households aged 22 to 39 with children hold 10.6%. Across all ages, 68.3% of the large owned homes house no child of the householder, close to the 72.9% of all households in these areas without a child at home. So large homes house children about as often as other homes, and their owners differ mainly in age. I call this concentration the intergenerational allocation of housing. For a young family, it means that the existing large homes come on the market mainly when older

households sell or leave them.

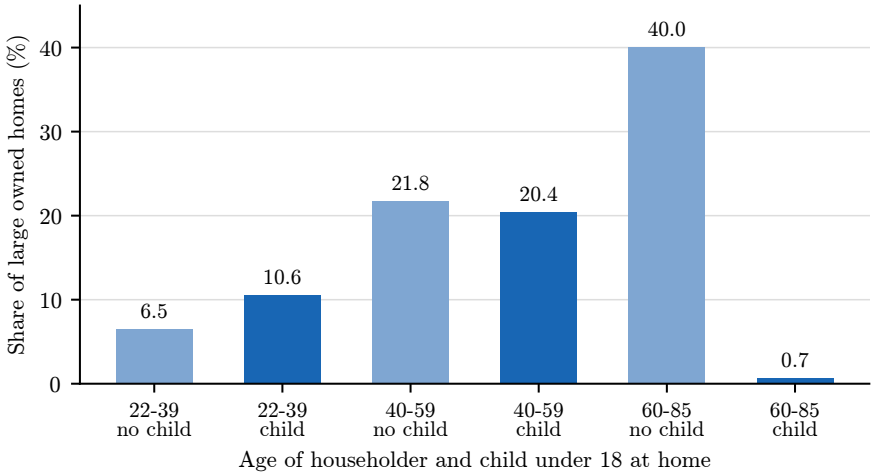


Figure 26: Who holds the large owner-occupied homes, ACS 2023

Notes: Share of owner-occupied homes with six or more rooms held by each group, in %. The six shares sum to 100%. Groups are defined by the age of the householder and by whether an own child of the householder younger than 18 lives in the household. Householders aged 22 to 85 in 42 large metropolitan areas, weighted by the household weight; 289,109 households. Source: American Community Survey 2023.

B.3 Ownership of recent parents

Recent parents also own more often in the cross-section. In the 2005–2006 ACS, heads aged 30 to 55 whose oldest child is under four are 12.8 percentage points more likely to own than heads without children. The calibration in Section 4 targets this gap. It compares different households at one point in time, while the PSID estimates follow the same households over time.

B.4 ACS matched pseudo-panel

The PSID event study of Appendix A follows the same households over time, but its samples are small. As a check on the size of the housing response, I estimate the same kind of event study in the American Community Survey, which has no panel dimension but is far larger. I follow the matched pseudo-panel design of Kleven et al. (2025).

Design. The sample is the ACS one-year files for 2005–2019, all states and the District of Columbia. The ACS has no birth histories. A woman is treated as having had her first birth in the year implied by the age of her oldest own child in the household roster, and only first births at ages 25 to 45 are used. Her housing before the birth is not observed, so each pre-birth year is represented by childless women interviewed in that earlier year who share her cell of age, education, marital status, race and state. Housing does not enter the matching. Rooms are capped at nine and codes that are not a count are set to missing, bedrooms are capped at five, and ownership is one for owned

units and zero for rented ones. The regression has event-time indicators from −5 to +10, with year −2 omitted, and state, age and survey-year fixed effects. It is weighted by the matching weights, and standard errors are clustered by source household, because one household can supply several matched records. The sample has 14.2 million matched records from 2.8 million households.

Results. Table 11 reports the change between one year before and three years after the first birth. With all fixed effects, rooms rise by 0.49, bedrooms by 0.34 and ownership by 3.3 percentage points. The ownership estimate depends on the age fixed effects. Without them it is 10.6 to 10.7 points, and with only the age fixed effects it is 4.3 points. Ownership rises steeply with age at these ages, so the age effects absorb part of the change around the birth. The room estimate moves much less, from 0.49 to 0.71.

Table 11: Housing around the first birth, ACS matched pseudo-panel

	All fixed effects	Age only	State and year only	None
Rooms	0.49	0.53	0.70	0.71
	(0.008)	(0.008)	(0.008)	(0.008)
Bedrooms	0.34	0.36	0.42	0.43
	(0.004)	(0.004)	(0.004)	(0.004)
Ownership (percentage points)	3.3	4.3	10.6	10.7
	(0.2)	(0.2)	(0.2)	(0.2)

Notes: Coefficient at event time +3 minus the coefficient at −1, with standard errors clustered by source household in parentheses. Women with a first birth at ages 25 to 45, ACS 2005–2019, 14.2 million matched records.

Comparison with the PSID. The ACS response is smaller than the PSID event study of Section 2, but the two contrasts start at different points. The PSID compares three to four years after the birth with two to three years before it, and part of the rise in space comes in the year of the birth or the year before. Among women in the PSID, rooms are 0.41 higher in that window and 1.03 higher three to four years after the birth (Table 8, column 2). The rise between the two, 0.62 rooms, is close to the ACS estimate of 0.49. The two designs also differ in what they hold fixed. In the PSID, the comparison is within the same households. In the ACS, the years before the birth are other women, so the design assumes that matched childless women live as the future mothers would have lived before the birth. The roster also does not record children who live elsewhere, and does not separate biological from other children. For these reasons I use the ACS only to confirm that space and ownership rise at the first birth in a large national sample, and I calibrate the model to the PSID.

B.5 Sibling-composition designs

The ACS sibling designs use women aged 21 to 35 in the 2005–2019 one-year samples whose oldest linked child, if any, is younger than 18. Children are linked to mothers through the household

roster, which records children living with the mother, not all children borne, and does not separate biological from step or adoptive children. The regressions control for complete sets of indicators for the mother's age at the event, her race, the survey year and the event age, are weighted by the person weight, and cluster standard errors by household.

In the first design, the sample is mothers whose oldest linked child is aged 0 to 5 (857,607 mothers). The instrument indicates that the two oldest children are recorded at the same age, and the treatment is a second resident child. Ages are recorded in whole years without quarter of birth, so the instrument is an age-only proxy for a twin birth. The first stage is 0.66 (F statistic above 77,000). The reduced form is 0.33 rooms (0.02), and the implied effect of a second child is 0.50 rooms (95 percent interval 0.45 to 0.55), 0.33 bedrooms (0.31 to 0.36), and 4.7 percentage points in ownership (3.3 to 6.1).

In the second design, the sample is mothers whose two oldest linked children differ in age and whose second child is aged 0 to 5 (656,986 mothers); it is not restricted to mothers with exactly two children. The instrument indicates that the two oldest children have the same sex, and the treatment is a third resident child. The first stage is 0.033 ($F = 715$). Mothers of same-sex pairs live in 0.038 fewer rooms (0.005) and 0.034 fewer bedrooms (0.003), and their ownership rate does not differ. Scaled by the first stage, a third child would reduce the dwelling by 1.15 rooms (95 percent interval 0.83 to 1.47). Children of the same sex can share a bedroom, so sibling sex composition may change the space a family needs without changing its size. That possibility would violate the exclusion restriction for housing outcomes. The data cannot test it formally, and I do not interpret this estimate as the effect of a third child. The same two designs are too imprecise in the PSID to add information: same-age births are rare in its smaller sample, and the sex-composition first stage is weak.

B.6 Data on the housing stock

The stock facts use the national public-use household file of the 2023 American Housing Survey, weighted by the housing-unit weight. Tenure has three occupied categories: owned, rented for cash, and occupied without payment of cash rent. Shares within a tenure use all units of that tenure as the denominator. The share of homes with seven or more rooms that are rented uses all occupied units of that size instead. It is 8.2% when the denominator contains owned and cash-rented units, and 8.1% when it also contains units occupied without cash rent and units with unreported tenure. Bedrooms and rooms are different measures. I report bedrooms for comparison with other work, and rooms because rooms are the outcome in the PSID and the ACS and the unit of the model. Mean rooms among households with children are computed over households with at least one child present.

C The Goods Market

In this appendix, I write out the goods market condition of the equilibrium in Section 3.4. Summing the budget constraints (3.7) over households, and using the pension and rebate conditions, the clearing of the rental and owner markets and the zero profit of developers, $X_t = P_t I_t$, gives

$$Y_t = \underbrace{\int c_t(\mathbf{s}_t, \boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_t)\, \mathrm{d}G_t(\mathbf{s}_t, \boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_t)}_{\text{consumption}} + \underbrace{X_t}_{\text{construction}} + \underbrace{\mu P_t \int \mathbf{1}\{h_t^O(\mathbf{s}_t, \boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_t) \neq h_{t-1}^O\}\, h_{t-1}^O\, \mathrm{d}G_t(\mathbf{s}_t, \boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_t)}_{\text{selling costs}}$$
$$+ \underbrace{C_t^g}_{\text{government}} + \underbrace{NX_t}_{\text{net exports}}.$$

The selling cost μ is a real resource cost, which nobody receives. Government consumption is the estates the government collects, the bonds and homes of the households that died at the end of period $t-1$, net of the initial wealth of new households,

$$\begin{aligned} C_t^g = {} & R_b \int (1 - p_a)\, b_t(\mathbf{s}_{t-1}, \boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_{t-1})\, \mathrm{d}G_{t-1}(\mathbf{s}_{t-1}, \boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_{t-1}) \\ & + (1 - \delta_H) P_t \int (1 - p_a)\, h_{t-1}^O(\mathbf{s}_{t-1}, \boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_{t-1})\, \mathrm{d}G_{t-1}(\mathbf{s}_{t-1}, \boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_{t-1}) \\ & - R_b \int \mathbf{1}\{a_t = 0\}\, b_t\, \mathrm{d}G_t(\mathbf{s}_t, \boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_t), \end{aligned} \tag{C.1}$$

where the government, like rental companies, sells homes without a selling cost.

Households trade bonds with the rest of the world, and the good is the only means of payment. A household that buys a bond therefore sends goods abroad, and one that receives principal and interest brings goods in. The same holds for rental companies, which are owned outside the economy. The rent they keep after the property tax leaves the economy, and the homes they buy are paid for with goods that come in. Net exports are therefore

$$\begin{aligned} NX_t = {} & \int b_{t+1}(\mathbf{s}_t, \boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_t)\, \mathrm{d}G_t(\mathbf{s}_t, \boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_t) - R_b \int b_t(\mathbf{s}_{t-1}, \boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_{t-1})\, \mathrm{d}G_{t-1}(\mathbf{s}_{t-1}, \boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_{t-1}) \\ & + (r_t - \tau^p P_t) H_t^L - P_t \big[H_t^L - (1 - \delta_H) H_{t-1}^L \big]. \end{aligned}$$

The second integral includes the bonds of the households that died, whose return enters C_t^g. Since C_t^g and NX_t are residuals, of the budget of the government and of the balance of payments, the condition is an identity. It holds whenever the other conditions of the equilibrium hold, and it does not restrict any price. In a stationary equilibrium, the same condition holds with constant aggregates.

D Household Optimality Conditions

In this appendix, I derive the conditions used in Section 3.5: the choices within a housing option, the Euler equation and the borrowing multiplier ζ_t, the effect of credit on value and on fertility, and the two results in the footnotes of that Section. Here n is the number of children at home after the birth outcome of period t. The budget constraint (3.7) of the chosen option gives c_t as a function of b_{t+1} and, for a renter, of h_t^R.

Choices within an option. In option j of (3.6), renting or owning $h_t^O \in \mathcal{H}$, the household chooses b_{t+1} and, if it rents, h_t^R. It faces the borrowing limit (3.2), with $h_t^O = 0$ for a renter, and the rental cap $h_t^R \le \bar{h}^R$. The multipliers on the two constraints are $\zeta_t \ge 0$ and $\nu_t \ge 0$. By (3.7), $\partial c_t/\partial b_{t+1} = -1$ in every option and $\partial c_t/\partial h_t^R = -r_t$ for a renter. In (3.1), the marginal utilities of consumption and of rented space are the same power of the composite in brackets, times α_0/c_t and $(1-\alpha_0)/(h_t^R - \bar{h}(n))$. Below the cap, the condition $\partial u/\partial h_t^R = r_t\,\partial u/\partial c_t + \nu_t$ then gives

$$r_t\big(h_t^R - \bar{h}(n)\big) = \frac{1-\alpha_0}{\alpha_0}\, c_t. \tag{D.1}$$

A renter spends a share α_0 of $c_t + r_t(h_t^R - \bar{h}(n))$ on consumption and $1-\alpha_0$ on space above the requirement. With $b_t = b_{t+1} = 0$ and no home to sell, this spending equals $y_t + T_t - r_t\bar{h}(n)$. Substituting the two shares into (3.1) gives (3.14). At the cap, $h_t^R = \bar{h}^R$ and $\nu_t = \partial u/\partial h_t^R - r_t\,\partial u/\partial c_t \ge 0$. An owner's space is fixed within the option, so the owner chooses only the bond.

The bond. The first-order condition for b_{t+1} is the Euler equation

$$\frac{\partial u}{\partial c_t} = \beta\,\mathbb{E}_t\Big[p_a \frac{\partial V_{t+1}}{\partial b_{t+1}} + (1-p_a)\,B'(x_{t+1})\Big] + \zeta_t, \qquad \zeta_t\big(b_{t+1} + \phi P_t h_t^O\big) = 0, \tag{D.2}$$

where $h_t^O = 0$ for a renter and $B'(x_{t+1}) = \theta_0(\theta_1 + x_{t+1})^{-\sigma}$. The multiplier ζ_t is the gain, in period-t utility, from borrowing one more unit today and repaying R_b next period. It equals today's marginal utility of consumption minus the discounted expected marginal value of the bond next period, and it is positive only at the limit. The estate $x_{t+1} = b_{t+1} + (1-\mu)P_t h_t^O$ includes the bond, so $\partial x_{t+1}/\partial b_{t+1} = 1$ and the bequest term has no R_b. The survival term has R_b through the budget of period $t+1$.

With Gumbel shocks of scale κ, the expected maximum over options is the logsum in (3.5) and (3.8). Its derivative with respect to the value of one option is the probability of that option:

$$\frac{\partial}{\partial V^k}\,\kappa \log \sum_j \exp\big(V^j/\kappa\big) = \frac{\exp\big(V^k/\kappa\big)}{\sum_j \exp\big(V^j/\kappa\big)}. \tag{D.3}$$

The household sees the shocks before it chooses. A marginal change in a state moves only the value of the chosen option, and at the shocks where the choice switches the two options have the same

value. The derivative of the expected maximum with respect to a state is then the probability-weighted average of the derivatives of the option values. When $\sigma \geq 1$, the value of an option whose feasible set shrinks to a point goes to $-\infty$, since $u \to -\infty$ as $c_t \to 0$. Its probability goes to zero, and the logsum is continuous where an option enters or leaves the feasible set. Within option j of period $t+1$, b_{t+1} enters only the budget, with $\partial c_{t+1}/\partial b_{t+1} = R_b$. Hence $\partial V^j_{t+1}/\partial b_{t+1} = R_b\, \partial u/\partial c_{t+1}$ at the option's consumption, whether or not a constraint binds in that period. Let $\frac{\partial u}{\partial c_{t+1}}(j, n')$ be this marginal utility with n' children at home. Applying (D.3) to (3.8) and to (3.5),

$$\frac{\partial V_{t+1}}{\partial b_{t+1}} = R_b \Big[\big(1 - \pi_{a+1}\pi^F_{t+1,a+1}\big) \sum_j \pi^H_{t+1}(j \mid n_{t+1})\, \frac{\partial u}{\partial c_{t+1}}(j, n_{t+1}) \\ + \pi_{a+1}\pi^F_{t+1,a+1} \sum_j \pi^H_{t+1}(j \mid n_{t+1}+1)\, \frac{\partial u}{\partial c_{t+1}}(j, n_{t+1}+1) \Big], \quad \text{(D.4)}$$

where n_{t+1} is the number of children at home at the start of period $t+1$ and $\pi_{a+1}\pi^F_{t+1,a+1}$ is the probability of a birth in that period, zero outside the fertile ages. This derivative is R_b times next period's marginal utility of consumption, averaged over the birth outcome and the housing choice. The cost ξ drops out. The expectation $\mathbb{E}_t$ in (D.2) then averages over z_{t+1} and the departure of children.

A birth and the multiplier. At the limit, ζ_t is the gap between the two sides of (D.2) at $b_{t+1} = -\phi P_t h^O_t$. A birth moves both sides. In period t, a first birth adds $r_t h_P$ to the spending a renter cannot avoid and lowers an owner's space above the requirement by χh_P. Any birth raises $e(n)$. For $\sigma > 1$, each of these raises $\partial u/\partial c_t$ at the given bond position. In period $t+1$ the same holds with probability $1-\lambda$, if the child is still at home. The bequest term does not depend on n. Within an option,

$$\zeta_t(h^O_t, n+1) - \zeta_t(h^O_t, n) = \Big[\frac{\partial u}{\partial c_t}\Big]^{n+1}_n - \beta p_a\, \mathbb{E}_t \Big[\frac{\partial V_{t+1}}{\partial b_{t+1}}\Big]^{n+1}_n, \quad \text{(D.5)}$$

where $[\,\cdot\,]^{n+1}_n$ is the difference between the values with $n+1$ and with n children at home, at $b_{t+1} = -\phi P_t h^O_t$ in both. The first term is positive. It is larger when spending in period t is low, because the marginal utility of consumption is convex in spending. The second term is scaled by βp_a and by $1-\lambda$, averaged with the choice probabilities of period $t+1$, and evaluated at next period's spending, which is higher when earnings rise with age. The multiplier rises for a young household with low spending today whose spending is higher next period in every state. It can fall for a household that expects to spend less next period, so in general its sign is ambiguous.

Credit. Take a change in ϕ in period t only. For an owner, ϕ enters only the borrowing limit, whose derivative with respect to ϕ is $P_t h^O_t$. By the envelope theorem, $\partial V^j_t/\partial\phi = \zeta_t(h^O, n) P_t h^O$ for owning $h^O \in \mathcal{H}$ and $\partial V^j_t/\partial\phi = 0$ for renting, where $\zeta_t(h^O, n)$ is the multiplier when the household owns h^O with n children at home. Applying (D.3) to (3.8) gives the value of credit to a household

with n children at home,

$$\frac{\partial V_t^H(n)}{\partial \phi} = \sum_{h^O \in \mathcal{H}} \pi_t^H(h^O \mid n)\, \zeta_t(h^O, n)\, P_t h^O, \tag{D.6}$$

where $\pi_t^H(h^O \mid n)$ is the probability of owning h^O. For the probability of trying, (3.5) and $V_{t,A}^F - V_{t,0}^F = \pi_a \big[V_t^H(n_t+1) - V_t^H(n_t) - \xi\, \mathbf{1}\{\text{first child}\}\big]$ give

$$\frac{\partial \pi_{t,a}^F}{\partial \phi} = \frac{\pi_{t,a}^F\big(1-\pi_{t,a}^F\big)}{\kappa}\, \frac{\partial\big(V_{t,A}^F - V_{t,0}^F\big)}{\partial \phi} = \frac{\pi_{t,a}^F\big(1-\pi_{t,a}^F\big)}{\kappa}\, \pi_a \left[\frac{\partial V_t^H(n_t+1)}{\partial \phi} - \frac{\partial V_t^H(n_t)}{\partial \phi}\right], \tag{D.7}$$

where $\kappa = \kappa_1$ before the first child and κ_C after. The cost ξ does not depend on ϕ and drops out. This is (3.13). If the change in ϕ is permanent, it also enters V_{t+1}, and the envelope theorem adds $\beta p_a \mathbb{E}_t\, \partial V_{t+1}/\partial \phi$ to the derivative of each option. By (D.3), this term is (D.6) in period $t+1$, averaged over the choices of that period, and so on. The derivative is the sum of these terms over all future periods, discounted by β and weighted by survival and by the probabilities of the choices that lead to each option.

The bracket in (3.13) has two parts,

$$\begin{aligned}\frac{\partial V_t^H(n+1)}{\partial \phi} - \frac{\partial V_t^H(n)}{\partial \phi} = &\sum_{h^O \in \mathcal{H}} \big[\pi_t^H(h^O \mid n+1) - \pi_t^H(h^O \mid n)\big]\, \zeta_t(h^O, n)\, P_t h^O \\ &+ \sum_{h^O \in \mathcal{H}} \pi_t^H(h^O \mid n+1)\big[\zeta_t(h^O, n+1) - \zeta_t(h^O, n)\big]\, P_t h^O,\end{aligned} \tag{D.8}$$

where the first sum holds the multipliers at their values without the child and the second holds the probabilities at their values with the child. The first sum is positive when the child shifts probability away from renting, and from homes where the limit is slack, toward homes where $\zeta_t(h^O, n) P_t h^O$ is large. The second is positive when the child raises the multiplier in the homes the household is likely to own with it, and has the sign of (D.5). Both are small for a household that is likely to rent with or without the child.

The owner's cost of space. By (3.7), a household that buys a unit of housing in period t pays $(1+\tau^p)P_t$ in period t. In period $t+1$ it either sells what survives, $(1-\delta_H)P_{t+1}$ before the selling cost, or keeps the unit and pays maintenance $\delta_H P_{t+1}$, which leaves it with the same value. Discounted at R_b, the cost of holding the unit for one period is then

$$(1+\tau^p)P_t - \frac{(1-\delta_H)P_{t+1}}{R_b} = r_t, \tag{D.9}$$

by (3.10). Apart from the selling cost μ, a unit of space costs the same each period whether the household rents or owns it.

The cost of a child's space and earnings. Let $\tilde{y}_t = y_t + T_t$, $k = r_t h_P$ and $\Theta_t = \alpha_0^{\alpha_0}(1-\alpha_0)^{1-\alpha_0} r_t^{\alpha_0 - 1}$. The first term of (3.14) is $(\Theta_t \tilde{y}_t)^{1-\sigma}/(1-\sigma)$ without children and $\big(\Theta_t(\tilde{y}_t - k)/e(1)\big)^{1-\sigma}/(1-\sigma)$ with one child. The utility cost of a first child and its second derivative are

$$\begin{aligned} \Delta_t(\tilde{y}_t) &= \frac{\Theta_t^{1-\sigma}}{1-\sigma}\Big[\tilde{y}_t^{1-\sigma} - e(1)^{\sigma-1}(\tilde{y}_t - k)^{1-\sigma}\Big], \\ \Delta_t''(\tilde{y}_t) &= \sigma\,\Theta_t^{1-\sigma}\Big[e(1)^{\sigma-1}(\tilde{y}_t - k)^{-\sigma-1} - \tilde{y}_t^{-\sigma-1}\Big], \end{aligned} \tag{D.10}$$

where $\tilde{y}_t > k$. For $\sigma \geq 1$, $e(1)^{\sigma-1} \geq 1$ and $(\tilde{y}_t - k)^{-\sigma} > \tilde{y}_t^{-\sigma}$, so $\Delta_t'(\tilde{y}_t) = \Theta_t^{1-\sigma}\big[\tilde{y}_t^{-\sigma} - e(1)^{\sigma-1}(\tilde{y}_t - k)^{-\sigma}\big] < 0$ and $\Delta_t'' > 0$. The cost falls with earnings, and falls by less as earnings rise. By Jensen's inequality, earnings risk then raises the expected cost of a child above its cost at expected earnings, $\mathbb{E}_t\Delta_t(\tilde{y}_t) > \Delta_t(\mathbb{E}_t\tilde{y}_t)$. The second derivative rises with k, since $\partial\Delta_t''/\partial k = \sigma(\sigma+1)\Theta_t^{1-\sigma}e(1)^{\sigma-1}(\tilde{y}_t - k)^{-\sigma-2} > 0$, and, for $\sigma > 1$, with r_t, since $\Theta_t^{1-\sigma}$ is proportional to $r_t^{(1-\alpha_0)(\sigma-1)}$. Now take a renter at the cap with and without the child. Then $c_t = \tilde{y}_t - r_t\bar{h}^R$ in both cases, and the child lowers space above the requirement from $\bar{h}^R$ to $\bar{h}^R - h_P$, so

$$\Delta_t(\tilde{y}_t) = \frac{(\tilde{y}_t - r_t\bar{h}^R)^{\alpha_0(1-\sigma)}}{1-\sigma}\Big[(\bar{h}^R)^{(1-\alpha_0)(1-\sigma)} - e(1)^{\sigma-1}\big(\bar{h}^R - h_P\big)^{(1-\alpha_0)(1-\sigma)}\Big],$$

which for $\sigma > 1$ is positive, decreasing and convex in $\tilde{y}_t$, and rises with r_t and h_P.

The figures of Section 3.5. I compute Figure 6 and panel (b) of Figure 7 from the model at the parameters of Table 1. The estimated values are $\beta_{\text{ann}} = 0.9357$, $\psi_0 = 0.1774$, $\gamma = 0.6457$, $\xi = 0.2946$, $\kappa_1 = 0.0505$, $\kappa_C = 0.1285$, $h_P = 0.8899$, $\chi = 1.1121$, $\kappa_T = 0.0131$ and $\theta_0 = 0.2435$. The assigned parameters are those of the same table. In the 2007 steady state at these values, the price is $P_0 = 0.7707$, the rebate is $T = 0.1879$ per household and there are $N_0 = 1$ households. Supply (3.9) is $H = 6.776\,P^{0.63}$. In every solve, the rebate balances the government budget (relative residual below 10^{-6}). The steady-state rent is

$$r = \Big[1 + \tau^p - \frac{1-\delta_H}{R_b}\Big]P = 0.1698\,P.$$

The axes of the figures have no numbers, so I report the values at the marked points below.

Figure 6. This figure comes directly from (3.14), without a solve. With $\sigma = 2$, (D.10) gives the cost of a first child

$$\Delta(y) = \frac{1}{\Theta}\Big[\frac{e(1)}{y + T - rh_P} - \frac{1}{y+T}\Big], \qquad \Theta = \alpha_0^{\alpha_0}(1-\alpha_0)^{1-\alpha_0} r^{\alpha_0 - 1}.$$

I set $\alpha_0 = 0.733$, $e(1) = 1.35^{0.7} = 1.234$ and $h_P = 0.890$, and both curves use the 2007 rebate, $T = 0.188$. The solid curve uses the 2007 rent, $r = 0.1308$, so $rh_P = 0.116$. The dashed curve uses the rent at the new steady-state price $P_1 = 0.408$ of Figure 7, $r = 0.0693$, so $rh_P = 0.062$. Earnings

$y_L = 0.274$ and $y_H = 0.752$ are after-tax earnings per period at ages 22–25 in the first and third of the nine efficiency states, $z = 0.103$ and $z = 0.284$, and $\bar{y}$ is their mean. In the 2007 solve, at least 98% of renters of that age in these two states end the period at the borrowing limit. Over the plotted range, renters stay below the rental cap $\bar{h}^R = 6$, with and without children, at both rents. The braces mark the extra cost due to risk,

$$\tfrac{1}{2}\big[\Delta(y_L) + \Delta(y_H)\big] - \Delta(\bar{y}),$$

which is 0.245 at the 2007 rent and 0.110 at the new steady-state rent.

Figure 7. Panel (a) is a schematic of the owner market. Panel (b) comes from 22 solves at given prices: a solve of the household problem and of the distribution of households at that price, with the flow of new households fixed at one. Ten are at $\psi_0 = 0.1774$, at prices from 0.30 to 0.92. The other twelve are at $\psi_1 = 0.1484$ over the same range, and three of them are steps of the search for P_1. Here ψ_1 is the limit ψ' of the decay path (4.1), with $\rho = 0.35$. At each price, $n(P;\psi)$ is births per entering household, with the bin of three or more children counted as 3.60 and replacement at $\bar{n} = 2.1$, and $h(P;\psi)$ is owned plus rented housing per household. The fertility curves are monotone cubic splines through the solved points. The marked points are:

- A, the 2007 steady state: $P_0 = 0.771$, $H = 5.750$, $N_0 = 1$ and $n = \bar{n}$.
- A', preferences ψ_1 at the price P_0 with N_0 households: $n = 1.654$.
- B, the new steady state: $P_1 = 0.408$, $n = \bar{n}$ (births within 10^{-6} of replacement), $H = 3.851$, $N_1 = H/h(P_1;\psi_1) = 0.488$ and $T = 0.136$.

From A to B, the price falls by 47%, the stock by 33% and the number of households by 51%. The arrows show the direction of the adjustment.

E Identification

Of the eleven calibrated parameters of Section 4.3, ten, ϑ, minimize

$$\sum_{k=1}^{10} w_k\big[m_k(\vartheta) - \hat{m}_k\big]^2, \tag{E.1}$$

where $\hat{m}_k$ is a data moment, $m_k(\vartheta)$ its counterpart in the stationary equilibrium at parameters ϑ, and w_k the inverse square of a tolerance for the moment. At each ϑ, the house price makes completed fertility equal to replacement, and $\bar{H}$ is the supply scale at which that price clears the housing market with one unit of households. Table 12 reports the tolerance of each moment and

its contribution to the loss at the estimates.[35]

Table 12: Tolerances and loss by moment

Moment	Tolerance	Gap	Loss
Childless, women 40–44	0.0053	+0.0022	0.17
Exactly one child, mothers 40–44	0.0061	+0.0033	0.29
Mean age at first birth	0.085	−0.006	0.01
Mothers by age 25	0.010	−0.0018	0.03
Mean occupied rooms	0.088	+0.021	0.06
Ownership, heads 30–55	0.021	−0.007	0.11
First-birth room response	0.085	+0.036	0.17
Recent-parent ownership gap	0.0061	−0.0022	0.13
Wealth / annual earnings	0.363	−0.106	0.08
Bequests / wealth	0.00044	+0.000004	0.00
Total			1.04

Notes: Gap is model minus data. The weight of a moment is the inverse square of its tolerance, so its loss is the squared gap in tolerances.

Table 13: Elasticity of each targeted moment to each parameter

	ψ_0	γ	κ_1	κ_C	ξ	h_P	χ	κ_T	β	θ_0
Childless, 40–44	0.02	−0.44	−0.12	−0.14	0.35	0.04	0.07	−0.01	−1.74	0.00
One child, 40–44	0.08	0.34	0.17	0.05	−0.40	−0.03	−0.02	0.00	0.71	0.00
Mean age, first birth	0.01	−0.02	0.04	−0.04	−0.01	0.00	0.03	0.00	−0.42	0.00
Mothers by 25	0.00	0.19	−0.07	0.14	−0.09	−0.03	−0.11	0.00	1.65	0.00
Mean rooms	−1.89	0.45	0.00	−0.38	0.70	0.36	−0.04	−0.05	−3.27	0.00
Ownership, 30–55	−1.32	0.53	0.00	−0.46	0.77	0.39	3.15	0.02	−2.30	0.00
Room response	1.78	−0.63	−0.36	0.62	−1.06	−0.11	0.74	−0.17	7.73	0.00
Recent-parent gap	−4.56	0.78	−0.35	−1.31	1.91	1.18	−4.26	−0.28	−21.71	−0.01
Wealth / earnings	−0.10	0.03	0.00	−0.02	0.05	0.03	0.45	−0.03	13.71	0.03
Bequests / wealth	−0.10	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.03	−0.01	−0.29	0.00	0.57	0.19

Notes: Each entry is $\partial \log m_k / \partial \log \theta_p$, from central differences of 1%. The recent-parent gap, bequests and ownership are not smooth at the estimates: their forward and backward derivatives differ, so their entries are less reliable than the others.

Small changes in the parameters. Table 13 reports the second exercise of Section 4.3: I change each parameter by 1%, hold the others fixed, solve the equilibrium again, and measure the percentage change in each moment. Read by column, the table shows that patience moves nearly every moment, while the bequest scale moves almost only bequests. Read by row, it shows that wealth responds almost only to patience, so wealth pins down β, and that ownership responds most to χ. The cost of the first child and the curvature of the benefit of children move the same two moments, the share of childless women and the share of mothers with one child, by similar amounts and in opposite directions, so they are pinned down jointly.

[35]The search that produced the estimates used the number of children ever born by age 25 in place of the share of mothers by age 25. Searching again with mothers by 25 returns the same parameters to the third digit and a loss of 1.03.

The table is least informative about the space requirement and the tenure taste scale. The two moments tied to them, the room response at the first birth and the ownership gap of recent parents, respond little to small changes in them, and the gap is not smooth at the estimates. A 1% increase in h_P, for instance, lowers the room response slightly, while over a wider range a larger h_P clearly raises it (Figure 9). For this reason I test the space requirement directly.

Setting the space requirement elsewhere. Table 14 sets h_P at 0.5 or 1.3 rooms and re-estimates the other parameters. A much higher requirement clearly worsens the fit, and a lower one worsens it somewhat. The last row leaves h_P free and adds three moments to the loss: the rise in ownership at the first birth, the difference in rooms between large and small families, and the share of first births at 30 or later. The estimate of the space requirement barely moves.

Table 14: Setting the space requirement elsewhere

	h_P	κ_T	Loss	Room response	Gap	Mean rooms	Ownership at birth
Data				1.44	0.128	5.73	0.261
Estimates	0.89	0.013	1.03	1.47	0.125	5.75	0.140
$h_P = 0.5$	0.50	0.003	1.77	1.36	0.128	5.73	0.250
$h_P = 1.3$	1.30	0.027	7.91	1.56	0.122	5.84	0.095
Three added moments	0.85	0.002	—	1.46	0.126	5.77	0.248

Notes: Each row re-estimates the parameters not shown, keeping the best of two or three starting points. Ownership at birth is the rise in ownership at the first birth, from the same event study as the room response; it is not targeted except in the last row, whose loss is over thirteen moments and is not comparable.

Simpler versions of the model. Table 15 takes one feature out of the model at a time and re-estimates the other parameters. Without a cost of the first child, the model cannot match the shares of childless women and of mothers with one child together. Without a space requirement, households with a first child add too few rooms. With a single taste shock for all births, or with almost no taste shocks, the fit of the family-size moments worsens. Each simpler version fits worse than the full model.

Table 15: Simpler versions of the model

	Data	Full model	Single shock	No first-birth cost	No space requirement	No taste shocks
Childless, women 40–44 (%)	19.8	20.0	20.8	19.4	20.4	21.5
Exactly one child, mothers 40–44 (%)	21.4	21.7	22.6	23.9	21.6	23.9
Mean age at first birth	25.98	25.97	25.97	26.03	25.87	25.83
Mean occupied rooms	5.73	5.75	5.73	5.87	5.73	5.73
First-birth room response	1.44	1.47	1.40	1.58	1.09	1.43
Loss		1.03	7.29	25.93	20.04	29.63

Notes: Each column removes one feature and re-estimates the other parameters on the same ten moments, keeping the best of three starting points. "No taste shocks" sets the shock scales to 0.001, since the model needs a positive scale.

The response of births to housing costs. The policy experiments change the cost of housing. The response of births runs through three objects, and the moments of Section 4.3 discipline each of them. The first is how much space a child requires: a household with children at home pays for h_P rooms every period, whether it rents or owns, and the room response at the first birth pins h_P. The second is what this space costs: mean rooms pin the 2007 price, and ψ_0 keeps births at replacement at that price. The third is how strongly the decision to try for a child responds to its value. From (3.5),

$$\frac{\partial \pi^F_{t,a}}{\partial\big(V^F_{t,A} - V^F_{t,0}\big)} = \frac{\pi^F_{t,a}\big(1 - \pi^F_{t,a}\big)}{\kappa},$$

so the scales κ_1 and κ_C, disciplined by the timing of births and their spread across mothers, govern how far a given change in the cost of a child moves births.

Table 16 shows how much the first of these matters. It holds every parameter but h_P at its estimate, raises and lowers the house price by 10% from its 2007 level, and reports the response of births per household. The larger the space a child requires, the more births respond to the cost of housing: the elasticity triples between 0.1 and 1.3 rooms.

Table 16: Response of births to the house price, by space requirement

h_P (rooms)	0.1	0.3	0.5	0.89	1.3
Price elasticity of births	−0.15	−0.20	−0.25	−0.35	−0.46

Notes: Arc elasticity of births per household between prices 10% below and above the 2007 price, holding the price fixed in each solve and re-balancing the property-tax rebate. A partial-equilibrium exercise, not a calibration.

F Solution Algorithms

Stationary equilibrium. I solve for the house price P and the rebate T, given the parameters, the preference for children and the payroll tax. In a stationary population the age distribution follows from survival and entry, so the pension that balances the payroll tax is known before the search. I check the pension budget at the end.

1. Guess P and compute the rent r from (3.10).
2. Solve the household problem backward over age and compute the choice probabilities.
3. Compute the stationary distribution of households, iterating on the rebate until T times the number of households equals property-tax revenue. In the calibration, the number of households is one and $\bar{H}$ is set so that supply equals demand at P. In the counterfactuals, $\bar{H}$ is fixed and the number of households equals housing supply divided by mean housing per household.
4. Compute the renewal residual: adjusted births divided by 2.1, relative to the number of entrants, minus one. It is zero when the population reproduces itself.

5. Update P by bracketing the root of the renewal residual, and stop when the renewal and rebate residuals are below 10^{-6}. Re-solve at the selected price, require the same residuals, and check that the pension budget balances to the same tolerance.

Transition. I solve for the paths of the price, the pension and the rebate, $(P_t, m_t, T_t)_{t \geq t_0}$, given the inherited households and the path of ψ_t, which households foresee.

1. Solve the terminal stationary equilibrium. It gives the terminal value function.
2. Guess the three paths. Compute rents from (3.10) and, with a slowly adjusting stock, the stock from (H.1).
3. Solve the household problem backward in calendar time from the terminal value.
4. Move households and the queue of entrants forward from the inherited state, and add up housing demand and taxes at each date.
5. Compute the residuals of the housing market, the pension budget and the rebate at every date. The loss is the largest residual across dates.
6. Update the three paths jointly and repeat until the loss is below tolerance. Extend the horizon to check that early responses are stable.

With free entry and $\eta = 0.63$, the transitions use 100 four-year periods, from 2007 (2023 for the policy experiments) to 2403. With $\eta = 1.5$ and with a slowly adjusting stock, they use 200 periods, to 2803. The tolerances are 2×10^{-4} on the housing market, 2×10^{-5} on the pension and the rebate, and 10^{-6} on the renewal condition of the terminal stationary equilibrium.

G The 2023 Economy

In this appendix I compare the 2023 economy with the 2023 data in full; Section 4 gives a summary. The transition matches only period fertility, so none of these moments is targeted. Table 17 compares the change from 2007 to 2023 in the data and in the model. The model moves first births later, but by less than the data. The share of women who are mothers by 25 falls by 13 percentage points in the model and by 18 in the data, the mean age at first birth rises by 0.9 years against 2.1, and the share of first births at 30 or later rises by 5 points against 13. Three changes have the wrong sign. Childlessness among women aged 40 to 44 rises by 8.6 points in the model and falls by one point in the data. Ownership among heads aged 30 to 55 rises by 4.1 points and falls by 8.9. The house price falls by 3.6%, while the real price rose by 15.6% and real rents by 15 to 19%. Wealth relative to earnings rose from 4.46 to 7.05 in the PSID and stays near 4.4 in the model. Mean rooms are close to the data, 5.51 against 5.58. The extra space of families with three or more children falls by 0.03 rooms in both, but stays larger in the model, 0.54 rooms against 0.36.

The misses in childlessness and in the timing of first births have the same cause. In the data,

Table 17: The 2023 economy: data and model

	Data		Model	
Moment	2007	2023	2007	2023
Completed fertility, ages 40–44	–	1.92	2.10	1.69
Childless, ages 40–44 (%)	19.8	18.8	20.1	28.7
Exactly one child among mothers, 40–44 (%)	21.4	22.2	21.7	22.2
Mean age at first birth (years)	25.98	28.09	25.97	26.88
Mothers by age 25 (%)	45.7	27.4	45.5	32.2
First births at age 30+ (%)	24.9	37.7	24.2	28.9
House price (2007 = 100)	100	115.6	100	96.4
Mean occupied rooms (capped at 9)	–	5.58	–	5.51
Ownership, heads 30–55 (%)	67.6	58.7	66.9	71.0
First-birth room response‡	1.440	1.476	1.475	0.55
Rooms: 3+ versus 1–2 resident children	0.385	0.355	0.574	0.543
Wealth / annual gross earnings	4.46	7.05	4.35	4.38
Annual bequests / wealth (%)	0.73	0.88	0.73	0.83
Wealth/income p90 / median, ages 76–84	3.52	3.45	3.27	3.29

Notes: Model, 2007: the calibrated stationary equilibrium (Tables 2 and 3); model, 2023: the period dated 2023 of the transition in Section 4.4, evaluated on the full 2023 distribution. Data, 2007: the sources of Tables 2 and 3; data, 2023: the same sources in their most recent waves, with wealth over earnings from the PSID 2021 and 2023. House price: S&P CoreLogic Case–Shiller national index deflated by the CPI. A dash marks a 2007 value not measured on the 2023 definition. ‡ In 2023 the model value compares otherwise identical households with and without a first birth in the same period, not the event study of the data.

childlessness barely moved after 2007 while first births came later. In the model, the lower ψ_t applies to every cohort alive, including women already in their thirties. As a result, 29% of women aged 40 to 44 in 2023 are childless, and their completed fertility is 1.69, against 1.92 in the data. The price misses for a related reason. When the only shock is to preferences, fewer births lower the demand for family space, and the price falls. Part of the decline in fertility since 2007 came with a rising cost of space, which the estimation assigns to preferences.

Figure 27 compares life-cycle profiles in 2023. The model reproduces the rise of ownership with age and the hump in housing size, but its households buy too early. In the model, 43% of heads aged 18 to 21 and 52% of those aged 22 to 25 own their home, against 11% and 15% in the ACS. Too many young households are then near the margin of buying, which matters for the credit experiments of Section 6. First births also come too early. In the model, 29% of first births are to women aged 18 to 21, against 17% in the 2021–2023 natality data, and 14% are at 30 to 33, against 22%.

H Robustness of the Policy Results

In this appendix I repeat the experiments of Section 6 with a more elastic supply and with a slowly adjusting stock.

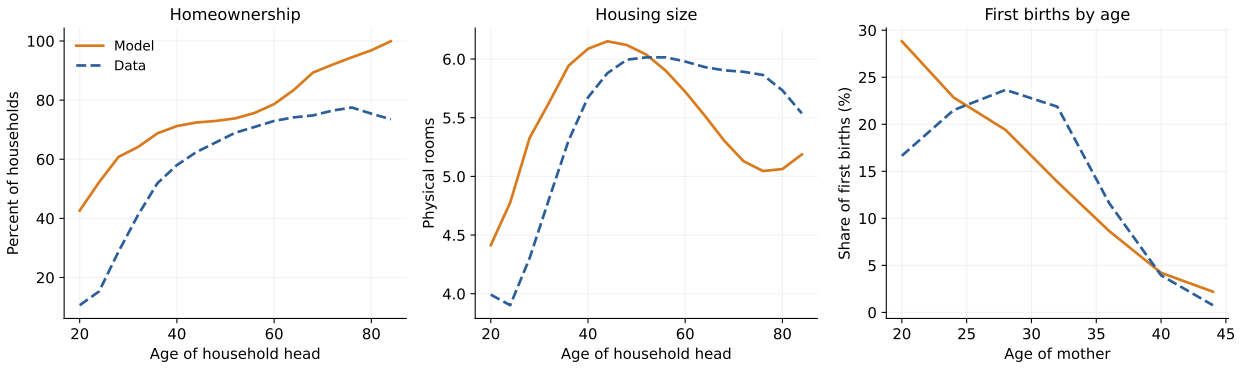


Figure 27: Life-cycle profiles in 2023, model and data

Notes: Homeownership and rooms by age of the household head, and first births by age of the mother. Model: the 2023 period of the transition in Section 4.4. Data: ACS 2023; NCHS first births 2021–2023.

H.1 A more elastic supply

Table 18 repeats the experiments with free entry and $\eta = 1.5$. With a more elastic supply, a 10% expansion lowers the price by 5.0% on impact, against 8.6% with $\eta = 0.63$, and raises births in 2023 by 1.6%, as much as the credit relaxation. It is therefore the matched expansion. Credit again moves births earlier. The completed fertility of the 2023 cohort falls by 1.0%, while the supply expansion raises it by 2.6%. In the steady state the price is again the one at which fertility is at replacement, so credit for parents raises it by about as much as with $\eta = 0.63$, 34%. With a more elastic supply, more households fit at that price: 76% more, against 36%.

Table 18: Counterfactuals from 2023 with $\eta = 1.5$

	Births			Completed fertility	House price	
	2023	2063	Steady state	2023 cohort	2023	Steady state
Credit relaxation	+1.6	+0.1	+4.8	−1.0	−0.1	+2.6
Housing supply, +10%	+1.6	+4.3	+10.0	+2.6	−5.0	0.0
Credit for parents	+5.1	+14.2	+75.6	+5.8	+0.1	+33.9

Notes: As in Table 4, with free entry and $\eta = 1.5$. The 10% supply expansion raises births in 2023 as much as the credit relaxation. Without policy, period fertility is 1.63 in 2023 and 1.67 in 2063.

H.2 A slowly adjusting stock

Here the housing stock adjusts slowly, as in Kaplan et al. (2020). Developers combine labor with building permits, which the government issues in a fixed number each period. Construction and the stock then follow

$$I_t = \delta_H \bar{H} P_t^{\eta}, \qquad H_t = (1 - \delta_H) H_{t-1} + I_t. \tag{H.1}$$

In a stationary equilibrium construction replaces depreciation, so the stock lies on the same curve $H = \bar{H} P^{\eta}$ as under free entry, and the 2007 equilibrium is the same. Along a transition only

construction responds to the price within a period, so the stock responds with an elasticity of about $\delta_H \eta$, and the price absorbs most of a change in demand. The decline in the preference for children from 2007 to 2023 is fitted under this rule, so the 2023 state differs from the one in Section 6. Everything else is as in Section 6.1.

Table 19 reports the results with $\eta = 0.63$. The credit relaxation raises births by 1.7% in 2023, but the gain falls to 0.6% by 2063, and the completed fertility of the 2023 cohort falls by 0.2%. A 10% supply expansion lowers the price by 3.0% in 2023 and raises births by only 0.4%. To raise births in 2023 as much as credit, the supply curve has to shift out by 40%. This matched expansion lowers the price by 10.9% in 2023. Construction keeps adding space, births are 12.2% higher by 2063, and the completed fertility of the 2023 cohort rises by 5.3%. In the steady state the price is back at its level without policy, so the supply expansions add as many households as they add space, 10% and 40%, and credit adds 3.2%. Credit for parents raises births by 6.2% in 2023 and by 32.9% in the steady state, when the price is 31.4% higher. Figure 28 shows the paths.

With $\eta = 1.5$ the pattern is the same (lower panel of Table 19). The credit relaxation raises births by 1.9% in 2023 and by 0.6% in 2063, and the completed fertility of the 2023 cohort falls by 0.8%. To raise births in 2023 as much, the supply curve has to shift out by about 60%. This lowers the price by 10.8% in 2023, raises births by 12.1% by 2063 and the completed fertility of the 2023 cohort by 5.5%. Credit for parents raises births by 6.4% in 2023 and the completed fertility of the 2023 cohort by 7.5%.

Table 19: Counterfactuals from 2023 with a slowly adjusting stock

	Births			Completed fertility	House price	
	2023	2063	Steady state	2023 cohort	2023	Steady state
Credit relaxation	+1.7	+0.6	+3.2	−0.2	+0.2	+3.5
Housing supply, +10%	+0.4	+3.2	+10.0	+1.4	−3.0	0.0
Matched supply	+1.7	+12.2	+40.3	+5.3	−10.9	0.0
Credit for parents	+6.2	+17.1	+32.9	+5.9	+1.8	+31.4
$\eta = 1.5$						
Credit relaxation	+1.9	+0.6	+6.1	−0.8	−0.1	+3.3
Housing supply, +10%	+0.3	+2.4	+10.0	+1.1	−2.1	0.0
Matched supply, +60%	+1.9	+12.1	+60.0	+5.5	−10.8	0.0
Credit for parents	+6.4	+17.2	+64.7	+7.5	+1.1	+29.8

Notes: As in Table 4, $\eta = 0.63$ (upper panel) and $\eta = 1.5$ (lower panel), with the stock following (H.1). Matched supply: the supply shift that raises births in 2023 as much as the credit relaxation. Without policy, period fertility is 1.64 in 2023 and 1.80 in 2063 with $\eta = 0.63$, and 1.63 and 1.75 with $\eta = 1.5$.

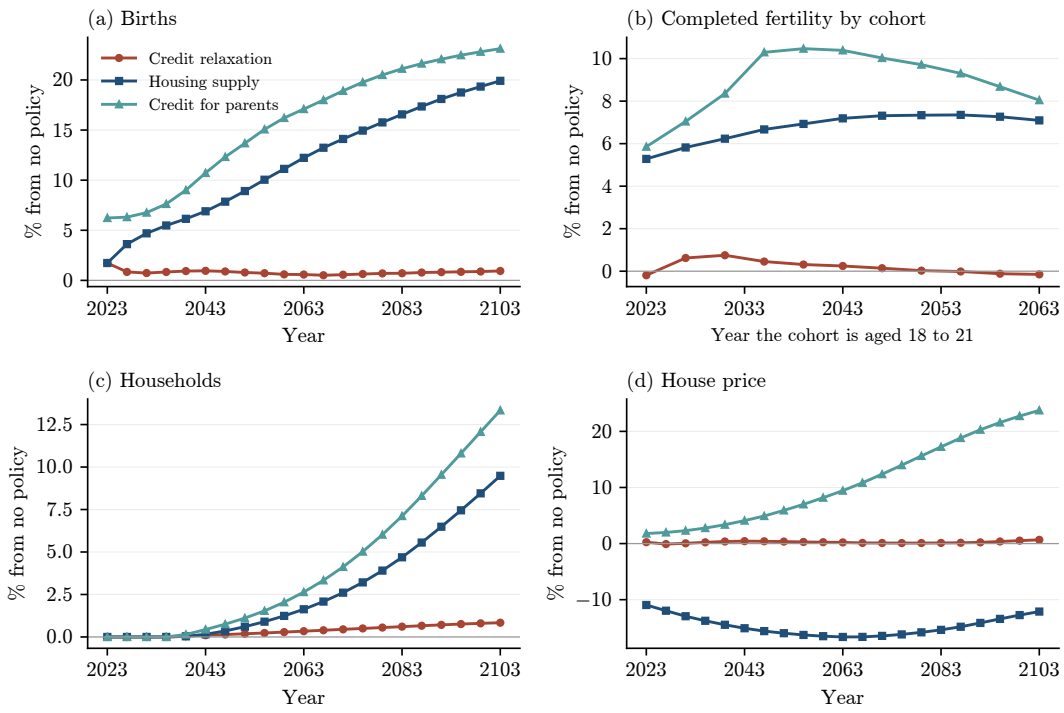


Figure 28: The credit relaxation and housing supply with a slowly adjusting stock

Notes: % differences from the no-policy path from the same 2023 state, $\eta = 0.63$, stock following (H.1). Births in each four-year period (panel a), completed fertility of the cohort aged 18–21 in the year shown (panel b), number of households (panel c) and house price (panel d). Housing supply: the supply curve shifted out by 40%, which raises births in 2023 as much as the credit relaxation.

I Additional Policy Results

This appendix gives the details behind four results of Section 6: the effect of the credit relaxation by cohort, how credit for parents works, a check of the small-home mechanism in the PSID, and the house price and rent under a higher property tax.

I.1 The credit relaxation by cohort

The credit relaxation lowers the completed fertility of the cohort aged 18 to 21 in 2023 by 1.1%, raises it for the cohorts entering between the late 2030s and the early 2060s, has almost no effect on the cohorts after them and raises it again in the steady state (Figure 29b, Baseline). To see why, I solve both scenarios again with the paths of the house price (and with it rents), the pension and the property-tax rebate held at their no-policy values, so that only the borrowing limit differs. The effects on these paths are close to the equilibrium ones (Table 20), so they do not come from the response of prices. On these paths the relaxation raises births in 2023 by 1.38%, against 1.35% in equilibrium. I then change one of these paths, the same way in both scenarios.

The 2023 cohort. The pension falls because the payroll tax is fixed while smaller cohorts reach working age: retirees per worker rise from 0.35 in 2023 to 0.47 in 2071, when this cohort retires, and the pension falls by a quarter (Figure 29a). With the pension held at its 2023 level, the relaxation raises the cohort's completed fertility by 0.6%. Holding the rebate or the house price at its 2023 level instead leaves losses of 0.5% and 0.3%. Households that buy earlier and with more debt under the relaxation have to rebuild more wealth before a smaller pension: the fall in the pension raises their net wealth at age 46 by 0.27, against 0.13 without the relaxation, and they have about 2% fewer children a year at ages 26 to 42.

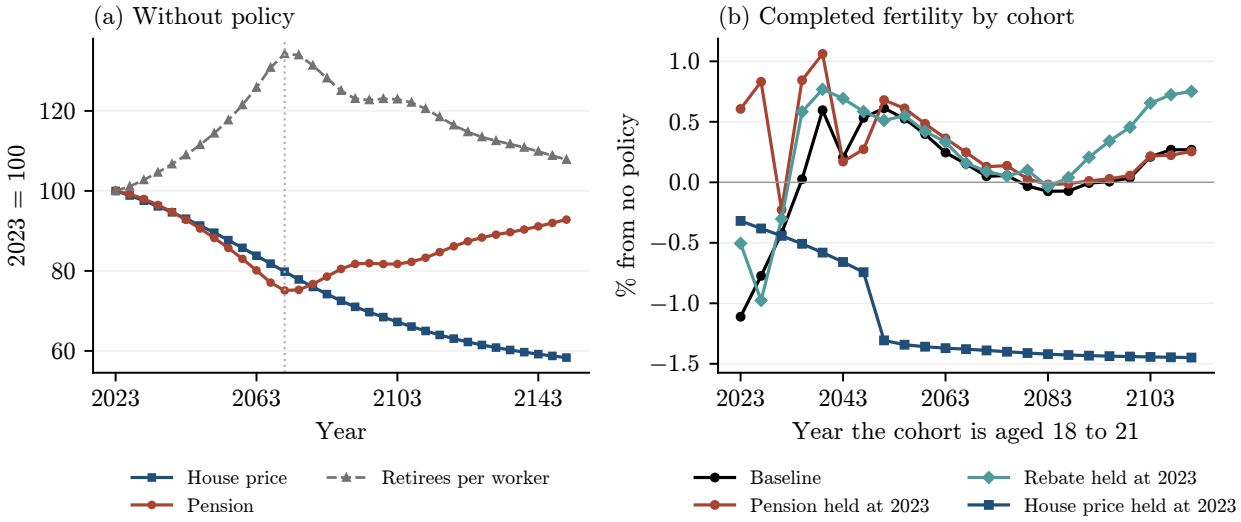


Figure 29: The credit relaxation by cohort, with one path held at its 2023 level

Notes: Panel (a): house price, pension and retirees per worker on the no-policy path, 2023 = 100; the dotted line marks 2071, when the cohort aged 18–21 in 2023 retires. Panel (b): % difference in the completed fertility of each cohort between the credit relaxation (loan-to-value 100) and no policy. Baseline compares the two equilibrium paths. In the other lines both scenarios face the no-policy paths of the house price, pension and rebate, with the path named held at its 2023 value. Each point is one cohort.

The later cohorts. Cohorts entering after the early 2030s retire once the pension has started to recover, and they gain from the relaxation only while house prices keep falling. With the price held at its 2023 level, the relaxation lowers the completed fertility of every cohort, by up to 1.4%. With the price held at its 2063 level from 2063 on (Figure 30), the gain of the cohorts entering between 2039 and 2059 turns into a loss of 0.2–0.3%, and the later cohorts are within 0.1% of zero. Without the stop, the cohorts entering between 2071 and 2095 live at prices between 0.50 and 0.60, where the steady-state effect of the relaxation at a fixed price is also close to zero (−0.11% at 0.55, +0.05% at 0.50, +0.08% at 0.61). For completed fertility, the second fall in the effect is the end of the gain from falling prices, not a new loss.

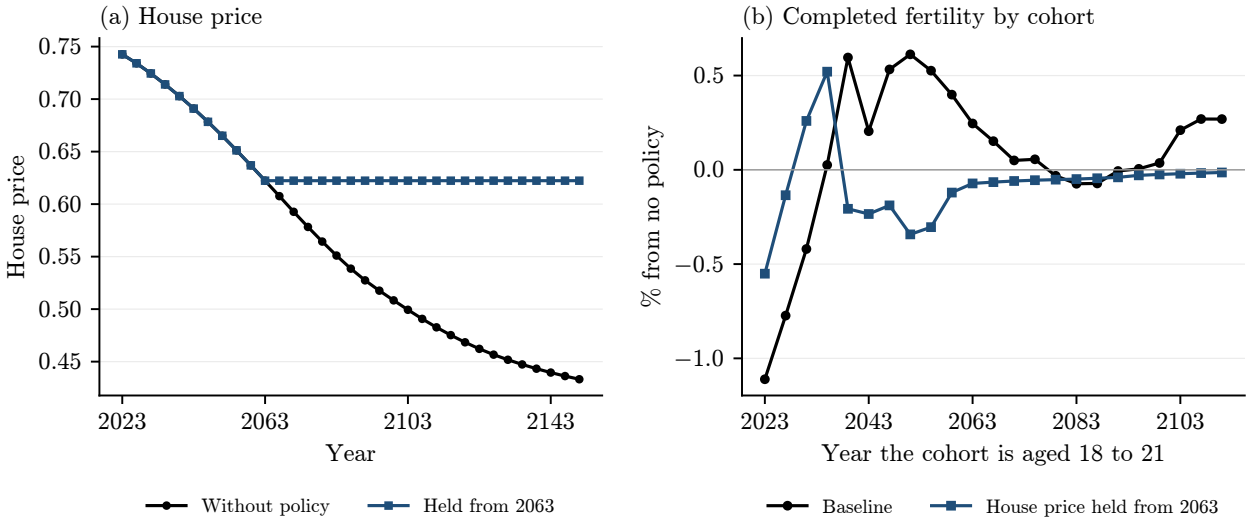


Figure 30: The credit relaxation by cohort, with the house price held from 2063

Notes: Panel (a): house price on the no-policy path, and the path held at its 2063 value from 2063 on. Panel (b): as in Figure 29b. In the second line both scenarios face the no-policy pension and rebate and the held price path.

Births in each period do not follow the same pattern, because a cohort's completed fertility sums births over several periods. With the price held from 2063, the effect of the relaxation on births is +0.8% in 2047, +0.1% in 2055 and −0.5% in 2063, and between 0.1% and −0.2% after that, so the gain comes earlier and the fall around 2063 is deeper than in the baseline. With the decline after 2055 at half its speed, the effect on births stays between +0.3% and +0.6% from 2063 to 2103. The effect of the relaxation on births follows how fast prices are expected to fall.

Table 20: Credit relaxation: completed fertility by cohort

Cohort aged 18–21 in	2023	2031	2039	2055	2071	2087	2103
Baseline	−1.11	−0.42	+0.60	+0.53	+0.05	−0.07	+0.21
All paths at no-policy values	−1.28	−0.73	+0.38	+0.53	+0.10	−0.06	+0.19
Pension held at 2023	+0.61	−0.23	+1.06	+0.61	+0.13	−0.01	+0.22
Rebate held at 2023	−0.50	−0.30	+0.77	+0.55	+0.09	+0.04	+0.65
House price held at 2023	−0.32	−0.44	−0.58	−1.34	−1.39	−1.43	−1.44
House price held from 2063	−0.55	+0.26	−0.21	−0.30	−0.06	−0.04	−0.02

Notes: % difference in completed fertility between the credit relaxation and no policy, by the year the cohort is aged 18–21. Baseline: equilibrium paths. Other rows: both scenarios face the no-policy paths of the house price, pension and rebate, with the changes named.

I.2 How credit for parents works

Table 21 reports the numbers behind the description of credit for parents in Section 6.4. Most young parents already own without the policy, so ownership among households aged 22 to 29 with a child at home rises only from 75.6% to 78.3%. The policy works through the decision to have a

first child: childless renters aged 22 to 29 try for a first child 13 to 16% more often in 2023. Once they have a child, renters use the credit, buying with probability 0.63 instead of 0.57 at ages 22 to 25, and by 2031, 11% of owners aged 22 to 45 with a child at home owe more than 85% of the value of their home. The credit relaxation for all households, in the last column, instead raises the purchases of childless renters, from 0.25 to 0.75 at ages 22 to 25, and in 2023 barely changes their first-birth attempts. When parents get the higher limit only when they buy, so that owners who stay cannot borrow more against their home, first-birth attempts rise almost as much (0.157 instead of 0.161 at ages 22 to 25), and births in 2023 rise by 3.8% instead of 5.1%.

Table 21: Credit for parents and the credit relaxation, households in 2023 and 2031

	No policy	Credit for parents	Purchase only†	Credit relaxation
Ownership, ages 22–29, 2023 (%)				
With a child at home	75.6	78.3	76.3	78.9
Without a child at home	45.2	44.3	44.3	75.5
Probability of trying for a first child, childless renters, 2023				
Ages 22–25	0.139	0.161	0.157	0.143
Ages 26–29	0.151	0.171	0.167	0.154
Probability that a renter aged 22–25 buys, 2023				
With a child at home	0.565	0.628	0.607	0.634
Childless	0.245	0.236	0.235	0.754
Owners aged 22–45 with a child at home owing over 85% of home value (%)				
2023	0.0	0.0	0.0	0.0
2031	0.5	10.7	8.1	9.0

Notes: Equilibrium paths from the same 2023 state. Ownership is measured after the tenure choice of the period. Probabilities are per four-year period: trying for a first child, and buying a home for a household that starts the period as a renter. Debt relative to home value is measured at the start of the period, among owners. Credit for parents raises the loan-to-value limit to 1 for households with a child at home; the credit relaxation raises it to 1 for all households. †Credit for parents at purchase only: owners who stay keep the borrowing limit of 80% of the home's value. Provisional: the housing market in this transition clears to 3.7×10^{-4}, above the 2×10^{-4} of the other runs.

I.3 A descriptive check in the PSID

In the model, households that buy a small home before their first child are less likely to have one. Table 22 compares women in the PSID who bought their first home at ages 22 to 33. Among those who were childless at purchase, 43% of the buyers of a home of four rooms or fewer had a first birth within six years, against 63% of the buyers of larger homes; with controls the gap is 14 percentage points (standard error 6.7). Among buyers who already had one child, home size makes no difference to the second birth. The comparison is descriptive: households that do not plan to have children may also choose smaller homes.

Table 22: First-time buyers in the PSID: births within six years by home size at purchase

	First birth within six years (childless at purchase)	Second birth within six years (one child at purchase)
Share with the birth, 4 rooms or fewer	0.43	0.72
Share with the birth, 5 rooms or more	0.63	0.71
Difference, with controls	−0.139	+0.083
	(0.067)	(0.094)
Buyers of 4 rooms or fewer	69	32
Buyers of 5 rooms or more	269	198

Notes: PSID-SHELF, women who are household heads or partners with a known birth history. First-time buyers own at an interview, did not own at the previous interview (at most two years earlier) and never owned before; they are aged 22 to 33 and bought in 1997–2001, 2003–2007 or 2009–2013, and are observed six years later. One observation per woman. Rooms are counted at the first interview as an owner. The difference is from a linear probability model with dummies for purchase period, three-year age group, income decile, education (five groups) and living with a partner; standard errors clustered by woman in parentheses. Unweighted.

I.4 Increasing property taxes

Figure 31 shows the house price and the rent per room when the property tax rises from 1.06% to 2% of the house value in 2023, with the revenue rebated. The tax lowers the price by 7.0% on impact and raises the rent per room by 14.5%, because rents cover the tax. In the steady state the price is 4.7% lower and the rent 16.4% higher. Returning the revenue in proportion to the rooms held by households of each age leaves both paths almost unchanged. Returning it in proportion to the rooms held by households of each age and earnings level lowers the steady-state price by 10.1% and raises the steady-state rent by 9.9%.

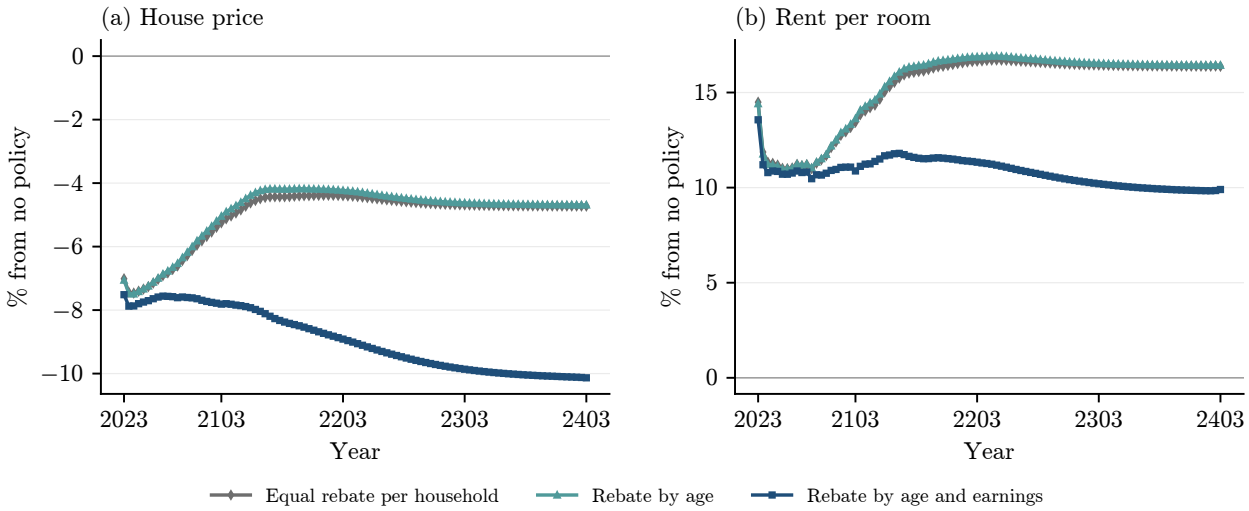


Figure 31: House price and rent with a higher property tax

Notes: % differences from the no-policy path from the same 2023 state, $\eta = 0.63$. The property tax rises from 1.06% to 2% of the house value from 2023 on. Equal rebate per household: the revenue is returned in equal amounts to every household. By age, and by age and earnings: the rebate of each household is scaled by the rooms held by its age group, or by its age and earnings group. Rent per room is the rent of one room of rented housing.